Chapter One

The air in the Silent City carries the weight of two thousand years of secrets, pressed thin like dried flowers between the pages of a forgotten hymnal. I sat cross-legged on the cold granite floor of my father's private study, a space carved so deep into the marrow of the mountains that the world above—the world of sunlight, screaming dragons, and bloodied steel—felt like a fever dream.

For twenty years, this subterranean silence had been my armor. My father, the Head Librarian of the Nephilim, had raised me among the whispers of dead poets and the logic of ancient tacticians. While other children were learning to draw the *Iratze* to heal their scrapes, I was learning the linguistic roots of the High Runes. While they were training with wooden staves in the sparring rings of Alicante, I was mapping the migration patterns of the Great Void Demons that had haunted Idris since the first age.

I ran my fingers over the gold-leafed title of *The Fall of the First Peaks*. It was a book I had read so many times the spine was held together by little more than prayer and a few temporary *Adhesive* runes I'd etched onto the leather. My father had always told me that history was the only thing more permanent than a dragon's fire. He'd say that a rider's flame could burn a city to ash in a heartbeat, but a scribe's ink could decide how that fire was remembered for a millennium.

But my father was dead. He had died in these very stacks, leaving me with a library full of knowledge and a body that was essentially a structural disaster. To the Silent Brothers—those eyeless, telepathic monks who served as our archivists and healers—I was a medical curiosity. They called it a "malady of the connective tissue," a byproduct of a childhood fever that had turned my ligaments into wet lace and my bones into porous stone. In the world of Shadowhunters, where we were supposed to be the perfected children of the Angel Raziel, I was a defect.

"You're lingering, Elara."

The voice didn't just break the silence; it shattered it like a hammer to glass. I didn't need to look up to know it was my mother, General Lilith Sorrengail. Her presence always brought a sudden, violent drop in the temperature of the room. She stood in the arched doorway, her silhouette framed by the flickering, spectral blue of the witch-light torches in the hallway.

She was in full Skystriker regalia—charcoal-black reinforced leathers that didn't just fit her; they seemed to be a part of her skin. The heavy silver wings pinned to her chest caught the torchlight, glinting like the bared teeth of a predator. At her hips sat two daggers made of Adamas—the heavenly silver forged from the Mortal Cup's heat.

"I was checking the binding on the annals," I said, my voice sounding thin and brittle. I stood up slowly, bracing myself. My knees gave a sharp, sickening *pop* as I straightened, a jolt of white-hot pain blooming in my hips. I swallowed it down. In this house, pain was a weakness to be exploited, not a symptom to be treated. My mother's gaze never softened; it only sharpened, as if she were trying to find a way to forge me into something useful.

"The annals will be here when you return, or they will be ash if the wards fall," she said, her voice a low, dangerous vibration. "The Venin have allied with Greater Demons from the Void, Elara. They aren't just raiding the borders anymore. They are draining the ley lines of Idris, turning the outer forests into a wasteland of Forsaken. We need riders. We need bodies in the sky. We don't need another girl who knows how to conjugate dead languages."

"I have a twenty-percent chance of surviving the Parapet, Mother," I reminded her. I had calculated it based on my weight, the average wind shear at the Basgiath peaks, and the friction coefficient of wet limestone. "My ankles will snap under the weight of a standard-issue rucksack. If the wind catches me on that three-foot-wide stone, I won't even have the chance to fall—the pressure differential alone will peel me off the ridge like a loose leaf."

“Then you had better find a dragon who doesn't mind a rider made of glass,” she snapped. She walked over, her heavy boots thudding against the stone, and gripped my chin. Her hand was calloused and smelled of dragon-fire and ozone. “Or you had better learn to etch runes that can hold you together when your body fails. You have your father’s constitution, but you have my blood. And my blood does not hide in a library while the world burns.”

She shoved a silver Stele into my hand. It was heavier than the scholarly one I used, built for the rapid-fire combat marks needed in the field. This wasn't for recording history; it was for surviving it.

“The carriage leaves in ten minutes. If you aren't in it, the Peacekeepers will drag you to the base of the mountain in chains. A Sorrengail enters the War College on her feet, or she doesn't enter at all.”

She turned on her heel and left, her cape snapping behind her like the wings of a predatory bird. No "happy birthday." No "stay alive." Just the cold, rhythmic click of her boots echoing down the hallway until the silence swallowed it whole.

I looked down at the Stele in my hand. It was a masterpiece of Adamas work, etched with the patterns of the first Skystrikers. On my bed lay the flight suit—a sleek, black suit of armor that felt like a funeral shroud. I reached into my desk drawer and pulled out the only thing I truly owned: a dragon-scale dagger my brother, Brennan, had given me before he vanished in the Great Uprising. The scales were obsidian, humming with a low-frequency vibration that made my teeth ache. Brennan had been a rider. He had been strong. He had been everything my mother wanted, and the mountain had swallowed him anyway.

I pulled on the leathers, the material stiff and unforgiving. I began to etch. I wasn't just drawing runes; I was stitching myself together. I drew the *Stamina* rune over my heart, the *Fortitude* mark on my sternum, and a series of *Binding* runes on my ankles and knees. The silver ink hissed as it sank into my skin, pulling the necessary energy straight from my marrow. It

was an agonizing process—every rune felt like a hot coal being pressed into my flesh—but I needed the artificial stability. Without these marks, I wouldn't make it to the carriage, let alone the Parapet.

I stood in front of the mirror, a girl made of ink and borrowed strength. I looked at the rucksack sitting by the door, stuffed with the heavy technical manuals I refused to leave behind. If I was going to die, I was going to die with the truth in my bag.

As I walked out of the library, the scent of old paper was replaced by the ozone of a brewing storm. The carriage was waiting in the courtyard of the Silent City, its black horses restless in the grey morning light. My sister, Mira—already a decorated rider—stood by the door, her expression a mix of terror and pride.

“Don’t let them see you shake, Elara,” she whispered, pressing a small vial of poppy tincture into my hand. “And when you get to the bridge... don't look at the sky. Look at the stone.”

I nodded, my throat too tight to speak. I climbed into the carriage, the door slamming shut with the finality of a prison cell. I was twenty years old. I was a Scribe. And as the carriage began its climb toward the Basgiath peaks, I realized that I wasn't just going to a college. I was going to a graveyard.

The peaks rose before us, jagged and black against the bruised sky. Somewhere up there, the dragons were waiting. And somewhere up there, Xaden Herondale—the man whose father my mother had executed—was waiting too.

I gripped my Stele until my knuckles turned white. If the world wanted to break me, it was going to have to work for it.

Chapter Two

The carriage ride to the base of the Basgiath peaks was a descent into a specific kind of hell. For three days, I was trapped in a small, rattling wooden box with two other candidates: Rhiannon, a girl from a minor Shadowhunter house who possessed a smile that felt like sunlight, and Jack Havoc, a boy whose name was as subtle as his personality. Jack spent the entire journey sharpening a massive broadsword and explaining, in exhaustive detail, exactly how he intended to "subdue" a Red Daggertail dragon.

I didn't talk much. I couldn't afford to. Every ounce of my energy was directed toward the runes etched into my skin. The *Fortitude* mark on my sternum was a constant, dull throb, siphoning my stamina just to keep my spine straight. I felt like a clockwork doll held together by fraying silver wire.

When the carriage finally lurched to a halt at the foot of the college, the sheer, vertical reality of my situation hit me.

The Alicante War College wasn't just built on the mountain; it was fused to it. It was a fortress of obsidian and white stone, jagged and hostile, perched on peaks that seemed to pierce the very belly of the clouds. To reach the entrance, we had to ascend a winding, narrow staircase carved into the cliffside—thousands of steps that felt like a deliberate attempt to kill the weak before they even reached the real test.

By the time I reached the summit, my lungs were burning and my *Binding* runes were flickering a dangerous, pale grey. I stood in a line with several hundred other candidates, all of us drenched by a freezing rain that smelled of ozone and ancient magic.

And then, I saw the Parapet.

It was a thousand-foot-long bridge of limestone, barely three feet wide, connecting the outer watchtower to the main gates of the college. There were no railings. There was no safety net. There was only a

five-hundred-foot drop into a canyon filled with jagged granite and the churning white water of the Acheron River.

“Candidate 114! Advance!” the commandant barked.

I watched as the boy in front of me—a tall, muscular candidate who had made it up the stairs without breaking a sweat—stepped onto the stone. He took five confident strides. Then, the wind shrieked. It was a localized gale, a literal wall of air that slammed into the side of the bridge. He didn't even have time to scream. One moment he was a person; the next, he was a black speck tumbling into the mist.

The line went dead silent. The rain felt colder.

"Sorrengail!" the commandant yelled. "Move or be disqualified."

I adjusted the straps of my rucksack. It was heavy with the books I refused to leave behind, but I’d balanced the weight meticulously. I pulled my Stele from my belt and touched it to the *Balance* runes on my ankles. They flared a desperate, blinding blue.

I stepped onto the stone.

The first sensation was the vibration. The bridge wasn't static; it hummed with the resonance of the wind and the distant roars of the dragons in the upper peaks. I didn't look down. I couldn't. If I saw the void, my brain would override the runes and send me into a spiral of vertigo. I focused on the stone six inches in front of my boots.

One. Two. Three.

The wind clawed at my flight suit, trying to find a grip. Every muscle in my body was locked in a state of high-tension terror. My joints felt like they were being pried apart by invisible levers. Ten feet in, a gust slammed into my left shoulder. I swayed, my boot skidding on a patch of slick moss.

My heart hammered—*thump-crack, thump-crack*—as I dropped to one knee. The impact sent a jolt of agony through my patella that made my vision swim with white spots.

"Don't stop," I whispered to myself, the rain stinging my eyes. "If you stop, you're a statue. If you're a statue, you're a target."

I forced myself back up, the *Fortitude* mark on my chest burning so hot I could smell the faint scent of singed skin. I was halfway across when the shadows began to change.

They weren't moving with the clouds. They were detached. At the far end of the bridge, a figure stood silhouetted against the dark obsidian archway of the college. He was lean, dressed in charcoal-black leathers that seemed to drink the rain. As I drew closer, the details sharpened.

Xaden Herondale.

I knew the name from my mother’s maps of the Great Uprising. I knew the face from the sketches in the Scribe files—the "Traitor's Son" who had been spared only because the dragons had chosen him. He stood with his arms crossed, watching my agonizing progress with a look of cold, clinical detachment.

"You're late, Sorrengail," he called out. His voice was a low rumble that somehow carried perfectly through the howling wind.

I didn't answer. I couldn't breathe, let alone speak. I was twenty feet from the end when the bridge gave a sickening groan. A section of the limestone edge crumbled away, taking the space where my next step should have been.

I lunged forward, my fingers clawing at the rough stone. I was dangling off the edge, my legs swinging over five hundred feet of nothingness. My rucksack pulled at my shoulders, the weight of the books suddenly feeling like a literal anchor to my grave.

"Let the bag go," Xaden said. He was standing right at the edge now, looking down at me. His eyes were a terrifying mix of onyx and gold, shifting like a storm.

"No," I gasped, my fingers slipping.

"It's paper, Elara. It’s not worth your life."

"It's history," I bit out, find a finger-hold in a crack in the stone. "And I'm a Scribe."

I hauled myself up, my *Binding* runes screaming in protest as they held my joints together under the impossible strain. I rolled onto the solid obsidian floor of the courtyard, gasping for air, the rain washing the copper taste of blood from my mouth.

I looked up. Xaden was standing over me. Up close, the air around him was different—heavy, charged with the static of the Void. On his neck, the "Mark of the Traitor" swirled like a living thing, a jagged, obsidian tattoo that marked him as the son of a rebel.

"You have a lot of heart for a girl made of glass," he said, his voice dropping to a dangerous whisper. He reached down and gripped my chin, much like my mother had, but his touch didn't feel like ice. It felt like a spark. "But heart doesn't keep you alive when Sgaeyl gets hungry. And my dragon is very hungry today."

He looked at the dragon-scale dagger in my boot—the one with the Herondale crest. His eyes narrowed, a flash of pure, unadulterated hatred flickering in the gold. "Where did you get that?"

"It was my brother's," I said, meeting his gaze.

Xaden’s jaw tightened, the shadows at his feet lashing out like whips. "Brennan Sorrengail is dead. And you shouldn't be carrying the steel of a family your mother destroyed."

He let go of my chin, stepping back into the darkness of the archway. "Welcome to Fourth Wing, Elara. Try not to die in your sleep. My shadows don't like the smell of rotting Scribes."

I stood up, my body shaking, and watched him walk away. I had survived the Parapet. But as I looked at the dark fortress surrounding me, I realized the bridge was the easy part.

Chapter Three

The walk from the obsidian courtyard to the Fourth Wing barracks was a slow-motion descent into agony. Every step I took felt like a betrayal. My *Binding* runes, which had held my joints together during the literal life-or-death struggle on the Parapet, were now fading into a dull, ashen grey. Without their constant, magical reinforcement, my ligaments felt like frayed rope. My hips ground together with a sickening, audible *click* with every second step, and a sharp, white-hot needle of pain shot up my spine every time my boot struck the stone floor.

I followed the line of bedraggled, shivering candidates through the jagged maw of the fortress. The walls of Alicante War College weren't just stone; they were warded obsidian, etched with silver veins of Adamas that hummed with a low, oppressive frequency. To a Scribe, the architecture was a marvel of ancient engineering. To a cadet who could barely stand, it was a tomb.

"Keep moving, Sorrengail," a voice hissed behind me. It was Jack Havoc. He had made it across the bridge—likely through sheer, pig-headed luck—and he was currently vibrating with an aggressive energy that suggested he wanted to hit something. "You're clogging the artery."

I didn't give him the satisfaction of a response. I just adjusted the straps of my rucksack, which now felt like it was filled with lead ingots rather than books, and kept my eyes on the back of Rhiannon’s head.

The Fourth Wing barracks were located in the lowest, dampest quadrant of the fortress, tucked into the shadow of the dragon stalls. The air here was different—thicker, smelling of sulfur, wet leather, and the unmistakable metallic tang of blood. We were led down a spiraling staircase that seemed to drop into the very roots of the mountain.

"These are your cells," a Second-Year corporal announced, gesturing to a long hallway of arched stone openings. "They are not rooms. They are cages. You will live here, you will bleed here, and most of you will die here.

There are no locks. In the Fourth Wing, if you can’t defend your own door, you don’t deserve the air you’re breathing."

I found my assignment: Cell 4-B. It was a six-by-nine space with a narrow cot, a stone basin, and a single wooden desk. I slumped against the doorframe, my breath coming in ragged gasps. The moment I crossed the threshold, the last of my *Fortitude* rune flickered out.

I collapsed onto the cot, my legs finally giving way. The pain wasn't just a sensation anymore; it was a physical weight, pressing me into the thin mattress. I reached for my Stele with fingers that shook so violently I nearly dropped it. I needed to etch a *Healing* mark, but my energy reserves were dangerously low. Drawing a rune was a transaction—the magic provided the effect, but the user provided the fuel.

I just need a minute, I thought, closing my eyes. *Just one minute of silence.*

But silence was a luxury the Fourth Wing didn't provide.

A shadow moved in the corner of my eye. I didn't hear a footstep. I didn't hear the rustle of fabric. I only felt the sudden, unnatural chill that swept through the room, turning my breath into a faint mist.

I lunged for the dragon-scale dagger in my boot, but before my hand could even touch the hilt, a ribbon of solid darkness lashed out from the floor. It wrapped around my wrist like a cold iron manacle and pinned my arm to the stone wall behind the cot.

"A Scribe who can't even sense a shadow shouldn't be holding a Herondale blade."

Xaden Herondale stepped out of the darkness of the corner. He didn't come through the door; he simply manifested from the gloom, the shadows peeling off his shoulders like a discarded cloak. He stood over me, his presence swallowing the meager light of the hallway torches.

"Get... out," I wheezed, my heart hammering against my ribs.

"I told you on the bridge, Sorrengail," Xaden said, his voice a low, terrifyingly calm vibration. He leaned down, placing his free hand on the mattress next to my head. He was so close I could see the golden flecks in his onyx eyes, shifting like embers in a dying fire. "My shadows don't need an invitation. And right now, they're telling me that you're about three seconds away from a total physical collapse."

He looked down at my wrist, where the shadow-bind was holding me. His gaze shifted to the fading, messy lines of my *Binding* runes. "Your runework is sloppy. You're over-etching the secondary lines, wasting energy you don't have. If you keep drawing them like this, you'll burn out your marrow before the first week of training is over."

"I don't remember asking for a tutor," I spat, though my voice lacked any real bite.

Xaden's eyes narrowed. The "Mark of the Traitor" on his neck pulsed with a dull, obsidian light. "You didn't. But you're in my wing. If you fail, it's a stain on my record. And if you die because you're too stubborn to admit your body is breaking, it's a waste of my time."

He reached out with his other hand. For a terrifying second, I thought he was going to choke me. Instead, his fingers brushed against the *Fortitude* rune on my collarbone. His touch wasn't cold like the shadows; it was searingly hot, like a brand.

"Your mother killed my father for a rebellion he believed in," Xaden whispered, his face inches from mine. "She branded every one of us—the children of the traitors—with these marks. She thought it would ensure our loyalty. She thought the dragons would burn the treason out of us."

He let go of my wrist, and the shadows retracted instantly, pooling at his feet like loyal hounds. He stood up, looking down at me with a mixture of hatred and something I couldn't quite identify—something that looked dangerously like curiosity.

"But the dragons didn't burn it out," he continued. "They amplified it. We are the most powerful riders this college has seen in a century, and we are all under your mother’s thumb. Do you have any idea how much my people want to see a Sorrengail bleed?"

"I imagine about as much as you do," I said, rubbing my sore wrist.

"More," Xaden said. "I want to see if you're actually as fragile as you look, or if you're just another lie your mother told the world. Sleep with your eyes open, Elara. The 'Traitor’s Children' are hungry, and you look like a feast."

He turned and walked toward the doorway, but paused at the threshold. "And Sorrengail? Use more silver ink on the *Stamina* anchor. If you're going to cheat death, at least do it with some dignity."

He vanished into the hall, the shadows following him like a living cape.

I stayed on the cot for a long time, the silence of the room feeling heavier than before. My wrist was still cold where the shadow had touched it, but my collarbone—where his fingers had brushed the rune—was burning.

I picked up my Stele and began to etch, this time following his advice. I reinforced the anchors, deepened the silver lines, and felt the energy settle into my joints with a new, terrifyingly efficient precision.

I was a Scribe. I was a Shadowhunter. And I was trapped in a room with a man who had every reason to kill me, yet had just shown me how to survive.

As the distant roar of a dragon echoed through the mountain, I realized that the Parapet was just the beginning. The real war wasn't in the sky; it was in the shadows of the Fourth Wing.

Chapter Four

The silence that followed Xaden's departure was a vacuum, a hollow space filled only by the rhythmic, distant thrum of the mountain's heart—the collective breathing of hundreds of dragons perched in the heights above.

I lay on my back, staring at the uneven obsidian ceiling of my cell. Every breath felt like a labor, my ribs aching where the rucksack straps had bruised the skin. The *Healing* rune I had just etched—using Xaden's unsolicited advice—was working differently than my previous marks. Usually, my runes felt like a frantic bandage, a temporary hold against the inevitable collapse. This one felt like a deep, slow heat, radiating from the bone outward. It didn't take away the pain, but it made the pain feel… manageable.

It was a terrifying realization: Xaden Herondale, the man who should want me dead more than anyone in Idris, knew my body's limitations better than I did.

Don't think about him, I told myself, clutching the dragon-scale dagger to my chest. *Think about the morning. Think about the first bell.*

But sleep was a ghost. My mind kept drifting to the "Mark of the Traitor." I had seen the files in the Silent City archives—the redacted reports from the Great Uprising. When the rebellion was crushed, my mother hadn't just executed the parents; she had branded the children. Every child of a rebel was forced to witness their parents' deaths and then subjected to the "Binding of the Traitor"—a magical brand that ensured they would serve the Skystrikers as frontline fodder. It was a death sentence draped in the guise of a second chance.

Xaden was the first of them. The leader of the "Children of the Damned." And I was the daughter of their executioner, sleeping in a room without a lock.

A sudden, sharp *clang* echoed through the stone corridor—the sound of a heavy iron bar being struck against the cell doors.

"Roll call! Out! Now!" a voice bellowed.

I rolled off the cot, my joints screaming a protest that I ignored with practiced ease. My *Binding* runes flared, locking my ankles into place as I pulled on my heavy combat boots. I didn't have time to look in the mirror; I grabbed my Stele and stepped out into the hallway.

The Fourth Wing cadets were a sea of black leather and bruised faces. We were lined up against the cold stone walls, our breaths hitching in the frigid subterranean air. To my left, Rhiannon stood with her jaw set, a jagged cut above her eyebrow from the Parapet still weeping blood. To my right stood a boy I didn't recognize—thin, pale, with a "Mark of the Traitor" that snaked up his neck like a blackened vine.

At the end of the hall stood the Second-Year who had led us here: a tall, cruel-faced Shadowhunter named Vane.

"You think you're cadets because you survived the bridge?" Vane sneered, walking down the line. He stopped in front of a girl three doors down and backhanded her across the face. She didn't flinch, though her lip split instantly. "You're nothing. You're meat. The dragons haven't looked at you yet. Until they do, you are the property of the Fourth Wing."

He stopped in front of me. His eyes—a dull, muddy brown—raked over my frame with a sneer. "And you. The General's little doll. I heard you almost fell twice."

"Almost doesn't count in history, Corporal," I said, my voice steadier than I felt.

Vane leaned in, his breath smelling of stale ale and tobacco. "In history? No. But in the pits, 'almost' is just a slow way to die." He looked at the *Stamina* rune on my collarbone. "You're cheating, Sorrengail. Using runes to augment a body that clearly should have stayed in the nursery. If I catch you using a Stele during the combat trials, I'll break your fingers one by one."

"Runes are legal until the Threshing," Rhiannon interrupted, her voice clear and defiant. "It’s in the Codex."

Vane turned his predatory gaze on her. "The Codex doesn't apply in the dark, Blackthorn. But if you want to defend her, you can join her for the midnight scour."

He turned back to the line. "Listen up. The ley lines are thinning. The wards at the southern border are failing because we don’t have enough Skystrikers to fuel the Adamas stones. That means your training is being accelerated. Tomorrow morning, you don't go to the classroom. You go to the Gauntlet. If you don't finish the course in under ten minutes, you don't eat. If you don't finish it at all… the dragons get their morning exercise."

He struck the iron bar against the wall one last time, the sound vibrating in my teeth. "Back in your holes. Lights out in five minutes."

The line broke, and we scrambled back into our cells. As I turned to enter mine, I felt a hand on my arm.

It was the boy with the Traitor’s Mark from the line. He looked at me with an expression that wasn't hatred, but a strange, hollow pity.

"Don't let Vane see the Stele again," he whispered, his voice barely a breath. "He’s a Herondale loyalist. He wants to be the one to give Xaden your head."

"Why are you telling me this?" I asked.

The boy touched the jagged mark on his neck. "Because Xaden said you were off-limits until the Threshing. And Xaden doesn't like it when people touch his things."

He vanished into his cell before I could respond.

I retreated into my room, my heart hammering. *His things.* Xaden didn't see me as a person; he saw me as a political piece on a board. A Sorrengail to be used, protected, or discarded when the time was right.

I sat on my cot and pulled out a small piece of parchment and a charcoal pencil. I couldn't sleep, so I did the only thing that made sense. I began to map the Gauntlet from memory. I had read the tactical diagrams in my father’s office. I knew the height of the walls, the depth of the mud pits, and the frequency of the swinging iron pendulums.

I spent hours in the dark, my fingers moving in a blur. I wasn't training my muscles; I was training my mind. I was finding the shortcuts. I was calculating the exact moment my *Balance* rune would need the most energy.

I was about to finish the map when a single shadow detached itself from the wall near my desk. It didn't take the shape of a man, but it moved with an intentionality that made my hair stand on end. It hovered over my drawing for a second, almost as if it were reading the notes, before it dissipated into the floor.

He was watching. He was always watching.

I blew out the candle and lay down in the dark, gripping my dagger. I was Elara Sorrengail. I was twenty years old. I was made of glass and ink and borrowed fire. And tomorrow, I was going to show Xaden Herondale that a Scribe can be more dangerous than a soldier.

Chapter Five

The morning bell screamed. It was a jagged, bronze sound that tore through the thin veil of my restless sleep, vibrating against the stone walls of my cell until my very marrow seemed to hum in protest.

I was awake before the second strike. In the Fourth Wing, being caught in your cot after the bell was an invitation for a corporal to find a "creative" way to motivate you. My body felt like a rusted machine. The *Healing* rune Xaden had helped me fix had settled into a dull, low-thrumming ache, but the moment I swung my legs over the side of the cot, a sharp, familiar bolt of lightning shot through my left hip.

Move, I commanded myself. *Pain is just data. Process it and move.*

I dressed in silence, the ritual of the flight leathers becoming a sort of meditation. Boots laced tight to support my weak ankles. Dagger secured to the inner thigh. Stele hidden in the secret pocket of my sleeve. I didn't reach for the Stele yet; siphoning energy for runes too early would leave me hollow by the time I actually reached the Gauntlet.

The hallway was already a chaotic river of black-clad bodies. The smell was a suffocating mix of unwashed sweat, damp wool, and the underlying, omnipresent scent of dragon sulfur that clung to the very pores of the fortress.

"You look like you've seen a ghost, Sorrengail," a voice chirped beside me.

It was Rhiannon. She looked remarkably put-together for someone who had spent the night on a stone slab. Her dark hair was braided tight against her scalp, and she was already chewing on a piece of dried fruit she’d likely scavenged.

"I spent the night dreaming of ways to gravity-proof my joints," I muttered, falling into step with her as we headed toward the mess hall.

"Better than my night," she sighed, her expression darkening. "The girl in the cell next to mine—Tessa—she didn't make it through the night. Not a traitor's child, just a regular cadet. Someone went in with a garrote around midnight. No one heard a thing."

I felt a cold shiver that had nothing to do with the drafty corridors. "Was it a grudge?"

"In here? It's all a grudge," Rhiannon said, lowering her voice as we entered the massive, vaulted dining hall. "But word is, she was bragging about having a high affinity for Green Daggertails. Someone wanted to thin the competition before the Threshing."

The dining hall was a sea of long, obsidian tables. It was the only place where the different wings mixed, though the lines were clearly drawn. At the center, under the massive hanging banners of the Shadowhunter houses, sat the Third-Years—the elite. They ate in relative silence, their movements graceful and predatory. Further out were the Second-Years, and at the very edges, huddled like sheep in a wolf den, were the First-Year cadets.

We grabbed our trays—metal plates holding a greyish porridge that smelled of oats and iron—and found a spot at the end of a Fourth Wing table.

"Don't eat the bread," a voice whispered from across the table.

I looked up. It was the pale boy from the night before—the one who had warned me about Vane. Up close, his "Mark of the Traitor" was even more intricate, a swirling pattern of thorns that disappeared beneath his collar.

"Why not?" Rhiannon asked, her hand hovering over a small, hard roll.

"Laxatives," the boy said, not looking up from his bowl. "The Second-Years like to see who has the stomach for the Gauntlet. Half those rolls are spiked. If you're cramping on the swinging poles, you're dead."

Rhiannon dropped the bread like it was made of hot lead. "I'm Ridoc," the boy added, finally looking at me. His eyes were a startling, clear blue. "And you're the girl Xaden is watching."

"He isn't watching me," I said, though the lie felt heavy in my mouth.

"He is," Ridoc insisted, leaning forward. Around us, the chatter of the mess hall felt like a physical pressure. "The Traitor’s Children... we have a way of knowing where his attention is. Right now, it’s a localized storm centered right on your head. Which means you're either the most important person in this wing, or you’re a dead woman walking."

"Can't I be both?" I asked, stirring the flavorless porridge.

A heavy silence fell over our section of the table as a group of cadets from the Second-Year tier approached. Leading them was a girl with hair the color of blood and a sneer that looked permanent.

"Look at this," she said, her voice dripping with mock pity. "A Blackthorn, a Traitor, and a Scribe. It’s like the start of a very bad joke."

"Leave it, Imogen," Ridoc muttered, his posture slumping as if he were trying to become invisible.

Imogen ignored him, her eyes locking onto mine. "Sorrengail. I saw your mother at the last execution. She has such a way with the sword. I wonder if you’ll make the same sound your brother did when the mountain finally takes you."

I felt the blood drain from my face. My hand moved instinctively toward the dagger at my thigh, but Rhiannon’s hand clamped onto my wrist beneath the table.

"Not here," Rhiannon whispered. "She’s a Second-Year. She’ll have you in the pits before you can draw breath."

Imogen laughed—a sharp, jagged sound—and reached out, dragging a finger through my porridge. "Eat up, little Scribe. The Gauntlet doesn't care about your family tree. It only cares about how much blood you can lose before you stop moving."

She sauntered away, her group following like a pack of jackals.

"She's a Speed-type," Ridoc whispered once they were out of earshot. "Bonded to a Swift-wing. She can move faster than the eye can follow. If she challenges you to a duel, refuse. It’s the only way you stay alive."

"I'm not here to duel," I said, my appetite completely gone. "I'm here to survive."

I looked toward the high table, where the wing leaders sat. Xaden was there, perfectly still, his dark head bowed as he spoke to a woman with silver hair. He didn't look at me. He didn't look at anyone. But I could feel it—that strange, cold tether between us, like a shadow stretching across the room to wrap around my heart.

"Look," Rhiannon whispered, nudging me.

In the center of the hall, a massive hourglass was being turned. The sand inside wasn't white; it was a deep, shimmering crimson—the color of Adamas under a blood moon.

"The Blood-Clock," Ridoc said, his voice trembling. "When the sand runs out, the Gauntlet begins. Anyone not at the base of the chimney is considered a forfeit."

"What happens to forfeits?" I asked.

Ridoc didn't answer. He just looked up toward the ceiling, where the faint, rhythmic scratching of dragon claws could be heard against the stone.

I stood up, my joints groaning in protest. I looked at Rhiannon, then at Ridoc. We were a group of misfits, held together by nothing but shared terror and the shadow of a man who might be our savior or our executioner.

"Then let's go," I said, reaching for my Stele beneath the table. I didn't care about the rules. I didn't care about Vane's threats. I was going to etch the most powerful *Balance* rune this college had ever seen, even if it cost me every ounce of energy I had.

I wasn't just a Scribe anymore. I was a cadet of the Fourth Wing. And today, I was going to make the mountain move for me.

Chapter Six

The walk from the mess hall to the base of the Gauntlet was a march. We were led through the "Tunnel of the Damned," a narrow, winding passage of jagged obsidian that had been carved out during the first demon incursions. The air here was damp and carried the scent of subterranean rot, a sharp, suffocating contrast to the sulfurous heat of the upper peaks.

The silence was absolute, save for the rhythmic, metallic *clink* of Stele-cases against belts and the heavy, uneven breathing of three hundred terrified cadets.

I fell into step between Rhiannon and Ridoc, our shoulders brushing as the tunnel narrowed. Every footfall was a calculated risk for me. My *Stamina* rune was already beginning to draw from my core—a low-grade heat spreading across my chest that felt like I had swallowed a glowing coal. I could feel the silver ink pulsing beneath my flight leathers, a constant reminder that I was living on borrowed time and artificial strength.

"You're shaking, Elara," Rhiannon whispered, her eyes darting to my hands. She didn't say it with judgment, but with a terrifying kind of clarity.

"It’s the energy draw," I lied, though we both knew it was only half the truth. "The *Binding* marks are hungry today."

"They're going to be hungrier in twenty minutes," Ridoc muttered from my other side. He looked smaller today, his flight leathers hanging off his thin frame. "I saw the roster. We’re in the fifth wave. That means the logs will be wet with the sweat—and blood—of four waves of cadets before we even touch them."

"Don't," Rhiannon snapped. "Don't talk about the blood. Talk about the footholds. Talk about the pivot points."

"The bottleneck is coming," Ridoc whispered, his voice hitching.

He was right. As the tunnel opened up, we were met with the Gate of Whispers, a massive natural archway where the path constricted to a mere two feet in width. This was where the Second-Years liked to play their games. They stood along the jagged ledges above, draped in their dark capes, looking down at us with the boredom of gods watching insects struggle in a jar.

"Look at them," I murmured, glancing up despite Rhiannon’s earlier warning. "They look like vultures waiting for a carcass."

"Worse," Ridoc whispered. "They're spectators. There’s a betting pool in the common room. I heard Vane put ten gold marks on a total squad wipe for Fourth Wing's tail-end. That’s us, by the way. We’re the tail."

"Vane can choke on his gold," Rhiannon said, her jaw setting in that hard, Blackthorn line. She looked at me, her eyes searching. "Elara, if your hip gives out on the logs, you grab my harness. Do you hear me? You don't try to be a hero. You grab me and you hang on."

"And pull you down with me?" I asked, a bitter taste in my mouth. "No. If I fall, I fall alone."

"The hell you do," Rhiannon hissed. "We’re a squad. If one of us goes over, the instructors mark the rest of us as 'unfit for bond.' You falling doesn't just kill you—it kills our chances of ever getting a dragon."

It was a brutal truth, one I’d read in the archives but never felt in my bones until now. In the Fourth Wing, your life wasn't your own. You were a tethered unit.

We emerged from the tunnel, and the world simply... ended.

We were standing on a massive limestone precipice, thousands of feet above the valley floor. To the south, the ancient forests of Idris stretched out like a bruised purple carpet, the ley lines appearing as sickly silver veins pulsing in the distance—a visual reminder that our land was dying. But ahead of us was the reason for our collective dread: The Gauntlet.

It was a vertical nightmare carved into the very face of the cliff. It wasn't one obstacle, but five distinct ascents, each more jagged and impossible than the last. Even from this distance, I could see the first test: the Rotating Log. It was a fifteen-foot span of timber, slick with mountain moss and rain, that groaned as it spun over the five-hundred-foot abyss.

"Look at the Chimney," Ridoc gasped, pointing upward with a trembling finger.

My gaze traveled upward, past the spinning timber and the shaking iron pillars, to the fourth ascent. The Chimney was a vertical slit between two sheer obsidian towers, barely wide enough for a person to wedge their shoulders into. It was a test of pure, unadulterated grip and core strength.

"I heard a girl from Third Wing fell there yesterday," Ridoc muttered, his face going a shade of grey that matched the limestone. "The wind caught her just as she was reaching for the lip. She screamed the whole way down. It took three minutes for her to hit the river."

"Stop it, Ridoc," I said, my voice sharper than I intended. "Visualizing the fall only makes the gravity stronger. Remember the diagrams I showed you last night? The Chimney has a hidden ledge three feet up on the right side. It’s a structural flaw in the obsidian. If you find that, you can rest your weight for ten seconds."

"A structural flaw?" Ridoc looked at me like I was speaking a foreign language. "Elara, we're about to climb a murder-wall, and you're talking about architecture?"

"It's not architecture, it's survival," I countered. "The mountain was built by the first riders. They left gaps. You just have to know where the Scribes marked them."

A sudden hush fell over the crowd. A massive shadow eclipsed the pale morning sun, and the air temperature dropped ten degrees in a second.

Xaden Herondale landed Sgaeyl on a needle-thin spire of rock directly above the Chimney.

The dragon was a masterpiece of lethal evolution. Her scales shimmered with a dangerous, oily luster, and her claws dug deep, smoking furrows into the granite. Xaden didn't dismount. He sat in the saddle with a terrifying ease, his dark gear blending into the dragon’s obsidian hide. He looked down at us—not with pity, not even with malice, but with a cold, predatory expectation.

He wasn't looking at the wing as a whole. He was looking at *me*.

"He's watching you again," Rhiannon whispered, her voice barely audible over the rising wind. "Why is he always watching you?"

"Because he's waiting for me to break," I said, my heart hammering against the *Stamina* rune on my chest. "He wants to see the Scribe shatter."

"Then don't," Ridoc said, suddenly serious. He reached out and bumped his shoulder against mine. "Shatter later. Over a bottle of wine in the village. Not here."

"Cadets! Line up by squad!" Vane’s voice boomed, cutting through the howling wind like a whip.

The first squad approached the edge. I watched as a girl I’d seen in the mess hall—someone who had been laughing only an hour ago—stepped onto the Rotating Log. She took three steps, the log spun, and she was gone. No scream. Just a sudden, violent absence.

"Next squad! Advance!" Vane shouted.

Rhiannon took a deep breath and stepped toward the ledge. "On my count. Elara, you stay in the middle. Ridoc, you're tail-watch. If she slips, you grab her pack. If you slip, I’m coming for you both."

"Got it," Ridoc said, his voice cracking. "Let's go show this mountain that we're too spiteful to die."

I reached for my Stele, my fingers trembling as I touched the tip to the *Binding* runes on my ankles. I poured more energy into the marks than I ever had before, feeling my pulse quicken as the silver ink flared a bright, desperate blue. I looked up one last time at Xaden. He didn't move. He didn't wave. He just watched.

"Step up, Sorrengail," Vane sneered as we reached the front of the line. "Let's see if those runes can carry the weight of your mother's expectations."

I didn't look at him. I looked at the log. I looked at the void. And then, I took the step.

Chapter Seven

The first step onto the Rotating Log didn't feel like a step.

The timber was ancient, a massive trunk of Idrisian pine that had been stripped of its bark and worn smooth by the boots of a thousand cadets who had come before me—and the blood of those who hadn't. It was suspended by iron chains that groaned with every shift of the wind, a low, rhythmic sound that reminded me of a funeral bell.

"Don't look at the drop, Elara," Rhiannon whispered, her voice barely audible over the howling gale. She was five feet ahead of me, her body perfectly balanced, her own *Agility* runes glowing a steady, confident gold. "Look at the nape of my neck. Focus on the seam of my leather jacket. That’s your world now. Nothing else exists."

I took a breath, my lungs burning with the thin, freezing mountain air. I touched my Stele to the *Binding* marks on my ankles one last time, feeling the energy draw reach a fever pitch. My marrow felt like it was being hollowed out, the silver ink on my skin glowing a desperate, electric blue.

I stepped out.

The log immediately lurched. It didn't just spin; it bucked. The weight of my rucksack—stuffed with the heavy technical manuals I had refused to leave behind—threatened to pull me backward. I felt my left hip hitch, that familiar, sickening *click* of the joint sliding toward the edge of its socket.

"Keep the rhythm!" Ridoc shouted from behind me. He was the anchor, his eyes wide and fixed on my heels. "Left, right, pivot! Left, right, pivot!"

My boots—reinforced with the dragon-scale grips I’d spent all night etching—slapped against the wet wood. The log began to rotate, a slow, inevitable roll designed to dump the uncoordinated into the five-hundred-foot void below. I could hear the wind shriek as it whipped through the canyon, a physical force trying to peel me off the timber like a loose leaf.

Left. Right. Pivot.

Halfway across, the log gave a violent shudder. A cadet from the squad ahead of us had lost their footing on the far end, their desperate flailing sending a harmonic vibration through the entire span. I watched, paralyzed for a split second, as the boy—a Second-Year who had been sneering at us in the tunnels—vanished into the mist. He didn't scream. The air was moving too fast to carry the sound.

"Elara! Move!" Rhiannon yelled.

But I couldn't move. My hip had locked.

The pain was a white-hot spike, radiating from my pelvis down to my knee. I dropped to a crouch, my fingers clawing at the slick, mossy wood. The log continued to spin. I was now on the side of the timber, my body perpendicular to the ground, staring directly into the churning white water of the Acheron River five hundred feet below.

"I've got you!" Ridoc's voice was strained, frantic. I felt his hand clamp onto the handle of my rucksack, his weight acting as a counter-balance. "I'm not letting go, Sorrengail! Fix your damn hip and move!"

I reached for the Stele, my fingers fumbling with the hidden pocket in my sleeve. I didn't have time for a perfect etch. I slammed the tip of the silver tool against my thigh, through the leather, and channeled every remaining drop of my energy into a raw *Stability* mark.

The energy draw was so violent I tasted copper. My vision went black at the edges, my heart stammering in a terrifying, uneven rhythm. But the rune held. The joint snapped back into place with a sickening thud, and the artificial strength of the mark fused my muscles into iron.

I hauled myself back to the top of the log, my breath coming in ragged, sobbing gasps.

"Go! Go!" Rhiannon urged, reaching back to grab my hand.

We scrambled across the last five feet of the timber, our boots hitting the solid obsidian of the first landing with a force that rattled my teeth. I collapsed against the cold stone wall, my chest heaving, the *Stability* rune on my leg still pulsing with a dying, angry light.

I looked up, my vision clearing just enough to see the spire above us.

Xaden Herondale hadn't moved. He was still perched on Sgaeyl, his dark silhouette a jagged tear in the grey sky. He was looking directly at me, his arms crossed over his chest. He had seen the slip. He had seen the illegal use of the Stele mid-ascent.

He didn't signal the corporals. He didn't call a forfeit.

Instead, he slowly raised one hand and touched his fingers to his own collarbone—the exact spot where he had brushed my *Fortitude* rune the night before. It wasn't a salute. It was a reminder.

I see you, the gesture said. *And I know how much you're cheating to stay alive.*

"You okay?" Rhiannon asked, her face pale as she checked the straps of my pack.

"I'm alive," I wheezed, wiping the rain and sweat from my eyes. I looked at the next ascent—the Shaking Pillars, a series of iron poles greased with animal fat that led to the base of the Chimney.

"The logs were the easy part," Ridoc muttered, wiping his bloodied palms on his leathers. "The pillars... that’s where the fat kids and the librarians die."

"I'm not a librarian today, Ridoc," I said, my voice hardening as I felt the cold, sharp spite rising in my chest. I looked back up at Xaden, then at the jagged obsidian height of the mountain. "Today, I’m the girl who’s going to make him watch me reach the top."

I stood up, my joints groaning under the weight of the runes, and stepped toward the edge of the first pillar.

The ascent had only just begun.

Chapter Eight

The first landing was a small mercy of solid obsidian, but it was a mercy that lasted only as long as it took to catch my breath. The air at this altitude was thinning, turning every gasp into a cold burn in the back of my throat.

"Don't look up," Rhiannon cautioned, though she was doing exactly that.

Ahead of us lay the Shaking Pillars. They were twenty vertical iron poles, each a foot in diameter, rising from the cliffside like the ribs of a buried giant. They weren't fixed; they were mounted on heavy spring-hinges that allowed them to sway three feet in any direction. To make matters worse, the instructors had coated the top five feet of each pillar with rendered animal fat.

"It’s not just grease," Ridoc whispered, leaning over the edge to inspect the first pole. "They’ve mixed it with graphite. If you don't have a death-grip, you're a human slide."

I looked at my hands. My fingers were thin, the knuckles already swollen from the strain of the logs. I didn't have the forearm strength to muscle my way across. I had to be smarter.

I reached for my rucksack, pulling out a small jar of powdered rosin I’d swiped from the Scribe’s workrooms. It was used for gripping heavy parchment, but here, it was gold. I began to rub it into the leather of my gloves, the grit sticking to the dragon-scale grips I’d etched earlier.

"Sorrengail! Move your ass!"

The shout came from behind us. It was Jack Havoc. He had reached the first landing with his squad, and he looked entirely too energized by the carnage of the first obstacle. His eyes were wide with a manic, bloodthirsty light, and he was covered in the spray of someone else's blood.

"The pillars are a bottleneck, Jack," I said, my voice cold. "Going faster won't make the hinges move any slower."

"It will if I'm the one pushing you off," he sneered, stepping closer. "The mountain is hungry, Scribe. I think it wants a snack that tastes like old paper."

"Touch her and I'll carve the *Ruin* mark into your forehead," Rhiannon snapped, stepping between us. Her golden *Agility* runes were still humming, a soft light reflecting off the rain on her face.

Jack laughed, but he stayed back. For now.

I turned back to the pillars. I needed to move. I touched my Stele to the *Adhesive* rune on my palms—a scholarly mark I'd modified for high-tension grip. I felt the energy draw tug at my core, a sharp, biting cold that made my stomach churn.

I leaped for the first pillar.

The iron was freezing, the grease immediately trying to lubricate my path into the void. My arms jolted as the pillar swung outward, the momentum threatening to snap my shoulders out of their sockets. I wrapped my legs around the pole, my *Binding* runes on my ankles screaming as they fought to keep my joints from separating.

One. Two. Slide.

I moved like an inchworm, agonizingly slow. Every time the pillar swayed, I had to time my breathing to the oscillation.

"You're doing it, Elara!" Ridoc cheered from the landing, waiting his turn.

I reached the midpoint—ten pillars in. The wind was a physical wall now, howling through the iron forest. My muscles were vibrating with a fatigue so deep it felt like my cells were breaking down.

Suddenly, the pillar I was holding shuddered violently.

It wasn't the wind. I looked back and saw Jack Havoc on the pillar behind me. He wasn't just climbing; he was jumping with unnecessary force, deliberately amplifying the sway of my pole.

"Oops," he grinned, his face inches from mine as our pillars swung toward each other. "Must be the wind, Sorrengail. It’s a real killer today."

On the next swing, he reached out a heavy, boot-clad foot and kicked the base of my pillar. The iron groaned, the spring-hinge bottoming out. My grip slipped. I slid down two feet, the rendered fat coating my chest and stomach, making me as slick as a seal.

I was dangling by my fingertips, my legs kicking at empty air. Five hundred feet of Idaho mist waited below.

"Jack! Stop it!" Rhiannon yelled from the landing, but she was too far away to intervene.

I looked up. Jack was preparing to kick again, a look of pure, joyous malice on his face.

I didn't have the strength to fight him. But I had a Stele.

I pulled the silver tool with my free hand, the metal slipping in the grease. I didn't aim for a rune on myself. I aimed for the iron. I slammed the tip of the Stele against the pillar Jack was holding and channeled a raw, unfiltered *Repulsion* burst—a mark used to drive away demons.

The energy flared a violent, jagged white. The iron pillar Jack was clinging to bucked as if it had been struck by lightning.

"What the—!" Jack screamed as his pillar swung violently away from mine, the force nearly throwing him into the canyon. He was forced to use both hands and both legs just to stay attached, his face turning a sickly shade of green.

The burst gave me the second I needed. I hauled myself back up the pole, the *Adhesive* rune on my palms glowing a blinding, desperate silver. I lunged for the eleventh pillar, then the twelfth, my movements fueled by a cocktail of adrenaline and pure, unadulterated spite.

I hit the second landing—the base of the Chimney—and rolled onto the stone, my lungs screaming for oxygen.

I looked back. Jack was still struggling to stabilize his pillar, his squad shouting at him from behind.

Then, I looked up.

Xaden Herondale was still there, perched on Sgaeyl. He hadn't missed a second of the fight. He didn't look angry about the illegal use of the *Repulsion* burst. If anything, there was the ghost of a smirk on his face—a dark, dangerous thing that made my heart do a very different kind of stumble.

He nudged Sgaeyl, and the dragon flared her wings, a gust of hot, sulfurous air washing over me.

The Chimney is next, his gaze seemed to say. *And there are no pillars to hide behind in the dark.*

"Elara!" Rhiannon landed beside me, her face white with terror. "You... you just used a demon-mark on a cadet!"

"He tried to kill me," I wheezed, pushing myself up. My *Healing* rune was cold now—completely drained. I was operating on nothing but sheer will. "The mountain doesn't care about the rules, Rhiannon. Why should I?"

I looked at the narrow, vertical slit of the Chimney. It was dark, slick with moisture, and higher than anything I had ever climbed.

"Let's go," I said, my voice sounding like gravel. "Before I realize how much this is going to hurt."

Understood. We will keep the dragons as distant, terrifying observers only. Chapter Nine will focus entirely on the grueling, claustrophobic physical battle of the Chimney—the most demanding obstacle of the Gauntlet—and the deepening psychological connection between Elara and Xaden as he watches her from above.

Chapter Nine

The base of the Chimney was a place where hope went to die.

It was a vertical fissure in the mountain, a jagged slit between two massive towers of obsidian that looked like the bared teeth of a titan. The space was barely eighteen inches wide—just enough to wedge a body into, but not enough to move with any semblance of grace. The stone was black, polished smooth by centuries of mountain runoff, and it wept a cold, mineral-rich moisture that made every surface as slick as glass.

"This is it," Ridoc whispered, standing at the mouth of the fissure. He looked up, his head craning back until he nearly toppled over. The top was a narrow strip of grey sky, hundreds of feet above. "This is where the Scribes say the mountain swallows the weak."

"I'm not being swallowed," I said, though my voice lacked conviction. My legs were vibrating with a fatigue so deep it felt like my muscles were liquefying. The *Stability* rune on my thigh was cold, the silver ink gone dull and grey. I was running on nothing but the dregs of my adrenaline and the lingering heat of the *Stamina* mark on my chest.

"I'll go first," Rhiannon said. She didn't wait for an argument. She stepped into the crack, her back against one wall and her boots against the other. She began to "chimney" up—a rhythmic, brutal movement of pushing with the legs and bracing with the shoulders.

I watched her for a moment, my scribe-brain automatically calculating the physics of it. The friction of the leather against the obsidian. The torque required to lift a human body against the pull of gravity. It was a nightmare of geometry.

"Your turn, Sorrengail," Vane’s voice drifted up from the landing below. He was watching us from the safety of the Second Ascent, his arms crossed. "Unless you'd like to take the express way down."

I stepped into the cold dark of the fissure.

The first thing I felt was the silence. The howling wind of the cliffs was suddenly muffled, replaced by the sound of my own frantic heartbeat echoing off the obsidian walls. The stone was freezing, the cold biting through my flight leathers and sinking into my bones.

I braced my back against the rear wall and jammed my boots into the opposite side.

The pain was immediate. My hips—already pushed past their breaking point—screamed as they took the full weight of my body. I felt a sickening *thud* in my pelvis, a joint sliding precariously close to the edge of its socket.

Push. Brace. Slide.

I moved an inch. Then another.

The Chimney wasn't just a physical test; it was a sensory deprivation chamber. The walls pressed in on my chest, making every breath a struggle. I could smell the ancient dampness of the mountain, the scent of wet stone and old moss.

Twenty feet up, my strength flickered. My left boot slipped on a patch of wet mineral deposit, and I lurched downward. My shoulders slammed into the obsidian, the friction burning through my leathers and searing the skin of my shoulder blades.

"Elara!" Rhiannon’s voice drifted down, sounding miles away. "Find the ledge! You told us there was a ledge!"

I gasped for air, my vision swimming with black spots. I reached out with my hand, fingers clawing at the smooth stone. I wasn't looking for a handhold; I was looking for the structural flaw I had seen in the architectural scrolls.

Three feet up. Right side. A three-inch indentation in the obsidian.

There. My fingers found a jagged break in the stone, a place where the mountain had buckled under its own weight centuries ago. I wedged my

fingers into the crack, the sharp obsidian slicing through my glove and into my palm. I didn't care about the blood. I used the grip to haul my body upward, jamming my elbow into a secondary notch.

I rested my head against the cold stone, my forehead slick with sweat and rain.

I looked out, through the narrow slit of the fissure, at the world I was leaving behind. Far below, the other squads were struggling on the pillars. And there, perched on the spire directly level with my current position, was Sgaeyl.

Xaden Herondale hadn't moved. He was so close now I could see the individual scales on his dragon’s neck. He was leaning forward in his saddle, his dark eyes fixed on the gap where I was wedged.

He knew I was hurting. He knew my runes were failing.

He reached into a pouch on his saddle and pulled out a small, dark stone—an Adamas-shard, a fragment of the heavenly silver used to forge the Mortal Instruments. He held it between his thumb and forefinger, the stone pulsing with a faint, rhythmic violet light.

It was a taunt. A single shard of Adamas could refuel my runes in seconds. It could turn my agony into ease.

He didn't throw it. He didn't offer it. He simply held it, letting me see what I was missing because I wasn't "strong" enough to earn it.

The spite that flared in my chest was hotter than any dragon’s fire.

"I don't need your help, Herondale," I whispered, the words lost to the stone.

I pulled my Stele. I didn't have the energy to draw a new rune, so I did something the Scribes warned against in the first year of study: I tapped into the *resonance* of the mountain itself. Every piece of obsidian in Idris

was connected to the ley lines. It was a dangerous, volatile source of power—unfiltered and prone to exploding—but it was there.

I touched the tip of the Stele to the obsidian wall and closed my eyes. I didn't look for a mark. I looked for the *vibration*.

I found it—a deep, low hum that felt like the mountain was breathing. I pulled a thread of that energy into the Stele and slammed it into the *Binding* rune on my ankle.

The reaction was violent. A spark of white-violet light erupted from the stone, lashing through my leg like a whip. I screamed, the sound muffled by the narrow walls, as my muscles seized into iron cords. The energy was jagged and raw, but it worked.

I surged upward.

I didn't push and brace; I *climbed*. I moved with a frantic, artificial speed, my boots finding every microscopic crack in the stone. I passed Ridoc, who was staring at me with wide, terrified eyes. I bypassed the next two landings, my body a blur of black leather and silver sparks.

I reached the lip of the Chimney and hauled myself over the edge, rolling onto the final summit of the Gauntlet.

I lay there on the obsidian floor, my body smoking—literally emitting a faint trail of grey vapor as the mountain’s raw energy burned through my nervous system. My *Binding* runes were blackened charred lines on my skin.

I had made it.

I looked up. Xaden was hovering Sgaeyl just a few feet above the summit. He looked down at me, his expression no longer cold. There was something else there—a dark, grudging respect that was far more terrifying than his hatred.

He pocketed the Adamas-shard and turned Sgaeyl toward the higher peaks.

"You're alive, Sorrengail," he called out, his voice a low thunder. "But the mountain doesn't give its power for free. I hope you’re ready to pay the interest."

He vanished into the clouds, leaving me alone on the summit as the first of my squad crawled over the edge. I was a Scribe who had stolen the mountain’s fire. And I knew, deep in my aching bones, that the dragons would be the ones to collect the debt.

Chapter Ten

The high of the mountain’s energy shattered.

The moment the last of my squad—a trembling, tear-streaked Ridoc—hauled himself over the lip of the summit, the borrowed power snapped. It felt like every nerve ending in my body was being cauterized at once. I didn't just fall; I folded. My knees hit the obsidian with a sound like dry wood snapping, and the world dissolved into a smear of grey mist and the smell of ozone.

"Elara!" Rhiannon’s voice was a distant echo, filtered through leagues of water.

I felt hands on my shoulders, but they felt miles away. My skin was hot—feverishly, dangerously hot—and the blackened lines where my *Binding* runes had been were pulsing with a sickly, dying light. Tapping into the ley lines was a death sentence for most; for a girl with my constitution, it was a miracle I hadn't simply vaporized on the Chimney wall.

"Don't touch her!" a new voice barked.

Through the haze, I saw a blur of charcoal leathers. The air around me suddenly grew cold—deliciously, impossibly cold. Shadows swirled around my vision, dousing the fire in my nerves. I felt a pair of strong arms slide beneath my knees and back, lifting me with an ease that made my head loll against a hard, leather-clad shoulder.

I caught a scent—woodsmoke, winter rain, and something metallic, like a blade freshly sharpened.

Xaden.

"I've got her," he muttered, his voice a low vibration against my ear. "Rhiannon, take the squad to the mess. If any corporal asks, she's with me for a disciplinary hearing."

I wanted to protest. I wanted to tell him I didn't need his protection, that I wasn't his "thing" to carry. But my tongue was a lead weight in my mouth, and the darkness he radiated was the only thing stopping the world from spinning. I drifted into a black, dreamless void.

…

I woke to the sound of dripping water and the low, rhythmic hum of Adamas-stones.

The infirmary was a vaulted chamber carved into the cooler side of the mountain, lit by the pale violet glow of healing lanterns. It was empty, save for the shadows dancing on the ceiling. I was lying on a stone plinth covered in soft furs, my flight suit cut away at the sleeves and collar to reveal the damage I'd done.

My arms and legs were wrapped in linen bandages soaked in a cooling paste of ground valerian and silver-dust. The pain was still there, but it was a dull, throbbing thing now, like a bruise that covered my entire soul.

"You're awake. I was beginning to think the mountain had decided to keep your mind even if it gave back your body."

Xaden was sitting in a high-backed stone chair in the corner of the room. He had discarded his flight jacket, wearing only a thin black tunic that showed the hard, corded muscle of his forearms and the jagged, swirling ink of the "Mark of the Traitor" on his neck. He was holding my Stele, turning it over in his long fingers.

"Give it back," I croaked, my throat feeling like I'd swallowed glass.

He stood up and walked toward the plinth. He didn't move like a soldier; he moved like a shadow—silent, fluid, and predatory. He stopped inches from the bed, looking down at me with an expression that was dangerously unreadable.

"You tapped the ley lines, Elara," he said, his voice dropping to a whisper. "Do you have any idea how many riders have died trying to siphon raw power from the obsidian? It's unfiltered. It's volatile. It's like trying to drink from a volcano."

"I was falling," I said, trying to sit up. The movement sent a flare of agony through my hip, and I gasped, my hand flying to the stone to steady myself.

Xaden was faster. His hand clamped onto my shoulder, gently but firmly pinning me back against the furs. His palm was warm—a startling contrast to the cold shadows he commanded. "Stay down. Your ligaments are currently the consistency of wet parchment. If you move, you'll undo three hours of work the healers put in."

"Why do you care?" I looked up at him, my breath hitching as I realized how close he was. The violet light of the lanterns caught the gold flecks in

his eyes, making them burn. "You told me you were waiting to watch me break. You told me your people wanted me dead."

"They do," he said, his thumb grazing the line of my collarbone, just above the bandage. The touch was light, almost a caress, but it sent a jolt of electricity through me that had nothing to do with the runes. "And I should want it too. Every time I look at you, I see the woman who stood on the dais and watched my father die."

He leaned in closer, his face inches from mine. I could feel the heat radiating from him, the scent of woodsmoke and storm-air filling my lungs. His shadows began to creep up the sides of the plinth, cloaking us in a private, dark world.

"But then I watch you on that bridge," he whispered, his gaze dropping to my lips before snapping back to my eyes. "I watch you outthink a mountain that was designed to kill you. I watch you use a Scribe's brain to wield a warrior’s fire. And I realized..."

"Realized what?" My voice was a thready whisper.

"That killing you would be the most boring thing I could do," he murmured.

His hand slid from my shoulder to the side of my neck, his thumb tracing the pulse point at my throat. My heart was thudding against his palm—*thump-crack, thump-crack*—fast and frantic. He wasn't just a threat anymore; he was a gravity I couldn't escape.

"You’re a disaster, Elara Sorrengail," he said, his voice turning husky. "You’re fragile, you’re stubborn, and you’re going to be the death of me."

"Then let go," I challenged, though I didn't want him to.

"I can't," he whispered.

He leaned down, and for a second, I thought he was going to kiss me. The tension between us was a physical cord, pulled taut until it hummed. I could

feel the ghost of his breath on my skin, the pull of his shadows against my own soul.

But then, the heavy iron doors of the infirmary groaned open.

Xaden pulled back instantly, the shadows snapping back to his feet like a leashed dog. His face went back to that cold, impenetrable mask in the blink of an eye.

"General," he said, his voice flat.

I looked toward the door. My mother was standing there, her grey eyes taking in the scene with a sharp, lethal clarity. She looked at Xaden, then at my bandaged body, and finally at the Stele in Xaden’s hand.

"Herondale," my mother said, her voice like cracking ice. "I didn't realize the Wing Leader’s duties included playing nursemaid to a first-year."

"I was simply explaining the disciplinary consequences of siphoning ley-line energy, General," Xaden said, his posture straightening. He tossed my Stele onto the bed beside me. "She’s a liability. But she’s a survivor. For now."

He walked past her without another word, but as he passed the doorway, his hand brushed against the stone frame. For a split second, a single shadow flickered toward me—a tiny, dark ribbon that touched my hand before vanishing.

My mother walked toward the bed, but I wasn't looking at her. I was looking at the door where he had gone. My skin still burned where he had touched me, and the cold void of the infirmary felt suddenly, unbearably lonely.

"You survived," my mother said, looking down at me. There was no praise in her voice, only a cold, clinical observation.

"I did," I said, clutching the Stele.

"Don't get used to the infirmary, Elara. The Threshing begins in three days. And the dragons won't care about your injuries. They only care about your worth."

She turned and left, leaving me in the violet light. I closed my eyes and reached for the spot on my neck where Xaden’s thumb had rested.

The mountain had tried to break me, but it was the boy with the shadows who had finally made me crack.

Chapter Eleven

The morning after the Gauntlet arrived with the steady, rhythmic ache of bones that had been pushed to the edge of shattering and then forcibly knit back together.

I woke in my own cell, the grey light of a misty Idrisian dawn filtering through the narrow slit that served as a window. The healers had sent me back to the barracks after my mother's "visit," likely under Xaden's orders to keep me out of the public eye while I was still vibrating from the ley-line burnout. My skin felt like a map of fire—sensitive to the slightest brush of the thin wool blankets—and the bandages on my arms were stiff with dried salve.

I sat up, moving with the agonizing caution of a woman made of glass. My hips held. My spine didn't snap. The *Healing* rune was gone, replaced by a faint, silver-white scar that looked like a lightning strike.

The room was silent, but it didn't feel empty. It felt... heavy.

"You're late for breakfast," a voice said from the corner.

I didn't jump. I didn't have the energy to jump. I just turned my head slowly to find Xaden sitting on my narrow desk, his long legs stretched out across the stone floor. He was dressed in a simple black tunic and loose trousers, his feet bare. It was the most vulnerable I had ever seen him, and yet he still looked like he could dismantle me in five seconds.

"I'm not hungry," I croaked, my voice still a ghost of itself.

"You should be," he said, standing up. He held a small wooden tray with a bowl of broth and a piece of bread that—for once—didn't look like it could be used as a weapon. He walked over and set it on the edge of my cot. "The energy you pulled from the mountain didn't just burn your nerves; it emptied your reserves. If you don't eat, you won't have enough strength to walk to the Threshing grounds, let alone bond a dragon."

"Why are you here, Xaden?" I asked, looking up at him. The tension from the infirmary was still there, a living thing coiled between us. "The General saw us. You're risking everything just to bring me soup?"

"I’m risking everything every time I breathe in this fortress, Sorrengail," he said, his voice dropping to that low, dangerous register that made my toes curl. He sat on the edge of the cot, the mattress dipping under his weight. He was so close I could see the faint silver scar running through his eyebrow, a souvenir from a fight I hadn't witnessed.

He reached out, his hand hovering over my bandaged arm before he pulled back, his jaw tightening. "My shadows told me you were restless. They said your heart was racing even in your sleep."

"Maybe your shadows should learn to mind their own business," I whispered, though my pulse was already quickening to prove them right.

"They don't have a choice," he murmured, his eyes locking onto mine. "They’re drawn to you. Just like I am."

The confession hung in the air, thick and sweet and terrifying. I reached out, my fingers trembling, and touched the back of his hand. His skin was warm, his pulse steady and strong—the anchor to my storm.

"You shouldn't be," I said. "I'm a Sorrengail. I'm the daughter of the woman who—"

"I know whose daughter you are," he interrupted, his fingers interlacing with mine. He squeezed, not enough to hurt, but enough to remind me he was real. "I've spent every day of the last six years memorizing the names of the people who took my family from me. I thought I knew exactly what a Sorrengail looked like. I thought they were all steel and ice."

He leaned in, his face so close I could see the flecks of gold in his onyx eyes dancing in the dim light. "Then I met you. A girl who carries a library in her head and enough spite in her bones to fight a mountain. You aren't ice, Elara. You're a wildfire."

He reached up, his thumb tracing the line of my jaw, then moving slowly, agonizingly, to the fullness of my bottom lip. I let out a shaky breath, my eyes fluttering shut as the heat of his touch flooded my system. It wasn't like the runes; it wasn't a borrowed power. It was a resonance I felt deep in my soul.

"Xaden," I breathed.

"I should leave," he whispered, his face inches from mine. "I should go back to my wing and forget that you exist. I should let the dragons decide your fate."

"But you won't," I said, a small, daring smile touching my lips.

"No," he groaned, his hand sliding into my hair, his fingers tangling in the knots. "I won't."

He kissed me then.

It wasn't a gentle kiss. It was a collision. It tasted of woodsmoke and desperation, a frantic reclaiming of territory. It was the kiss of two people who knew they were likely to die in forty-eight hours and were tired of pretending they didn't care.

I leaned into him, my hands finding the hard muscles of his shoulders, pulling him closer until there was no air between us. The shadows in the room seemed to rise up, swirling around the cot like a protective cocoon, shutting out the rest of the world. For the first time since I arrived at Alicante, I felt safe. Not because the danger was gone, but because I had found someone who was more dangerous than the mountain.

He pulled back just an inch, his forehead resting against mine, his breath coming in ragged gasps. "If you die during the Threshing, Elara, I'm going to find your soul in the Void and drag it back just so I can kill you myself for leaving me."

"I'm not going to die," I said, my voice finally finding its strength. "I have too much to live for now."

He looked at me for a long moment, his expression a mix of agony and adoration. He stood up, the shadows retracting into his shadow as he smoothed his tunic.

"Eat the broth," he commanded, his voice returning to that of the Wing Leader. "The Threshing begins at dawn tomorrow. I won't be there to catch you. You have to be the one to choose, Elara. Don't wait for a dragon to pick you. You find the one that’s as broken and as angry as you are, and you take it."

He walked to the door, but paused, looking back over his shoulder. "And keep your Stele ready. You’re going to need more than just balance tomorrow."

He vanished into the hall, leaving me alone with a bowl of cooling broth and a heart that felt like it had finally found its rhythm.

I picked up the bread and took a bite. It tasted like hope. And as the sun began to rise over the jagged peaks of Idris, I realized that for the first time in twenty years, I wasn't afraid of the fire. I was looking forward to it.

Chapter Twelve

The silence of the Fourth Wing barracks in the hours before dawn was a heavy, suffocating blanket woven from the collective dread of three hundred cadets who knew that, by sunset, many of them would be nothing more than ash on the wind. I sat on the edge of my cot, the stone floor biting into my bare heels. My cell, once a sanctuary of old paper and ink, now felt like a cage where the air was growing thinner by the second. The technical manuals I had carried across the Parapet and hauled up the Gauntlet sat in a neat stack on my desk, their leather spines mocking me. I had memorized the migration patterns of the Great Void Demons and mapped the internal ley lines of the mountain, but no book in my father's library could teach me how to survive a dragon that decided I was too fragile to exist.

I reached for my flight leathers, the material cold and stiff against my sensitive skin. Every movement was a negotiation with a body that seemed determined to fail. I had to slide my left leg in at a specific angle to avoid the sickening "click" in my hip that signaled a potential subluxation. My fingers, thin and prone to swelling, fumbled with the heavy brass buckles of the bodice. I wasn't just dressing; I was armoring a structural disaster. To the world, I was a Shadowhunter, a child of the Angel Raziel meant to be perfected, but inside these leathers, I felt like a clockwork doll held together by fraying silver wire and pure, unadulterated spite.

I pulled out my Stele, the silver tool feeling like a natural extension of my arm. I began the "Pre-Flight Etch," a series of low-level runes designed to provide baseline stability. These weren't the high-energy bursts I'd used on the Chimney; these were the "Scribe's Crutches." I drew a *Support* mark on the small of my back to help carry the weight of my gear, and a *Fluidity* rune on my wrists to ensure my joints didn't lock up during a climb. The silver ink hissed as it sank into my skin, pulling a steady, rhythmic thrum of energy from my marrow. It was a hungry magic. It settled into the bone, a constant reminder that my strength was borrowed and my time was running out.

“You’re thinking too loud again, Sorrengail.”

I didn't jump. I had grown used to the way the air changed when he was near—a sudden drop in temperature, a thickening of the shadows in the corners of the room that made the torchlight seem pale and sickly. Xaden Herondale was leaning against the doorframe, his silhouette a jagged tear in the grey morning light. He wasn't in his flight gear yet; he wore a simple black tunic, the material straining against the corded muscle of his shoulders. His presence always brought a sudden, violent shift to my pulse, a rhythm I couldn't calculate or control.

“It’s a big day,” I said, my voice sounding thin. “I thought I’d get a head start on the panic.”

Xaden walked into the room, his movements silent and fluid. He didn't ask for permission; he simply occupied the space, his presence pushing back the walls of the cell until it felt like the only world that existed was the six feet between us. He stopped in front of me, looking down at the bandages still wrapped around my forearms from the ley-line burns.

“Panic is a waste of glucose,” he said, his voice a low, dangerous rumble. He reached out, his long fingers hovering over the pulse point at my throat. “And you’re already running on empty. If you go into the Threshing grounds with your heart racing like this, the dragons will smell the adrenaline before they even see the runes. They don't want a rider who is already defeated by her own mind.”

“I can't help it, Xaden. I’m a Scribe. My entire life has been built on the premise that I am an observer. Now I’m expected to stand in a field and convince a multi-ton apex predator that I’m worth its time? It’s a nightmare of logistics.”

Xaden’s eyes narrowed, the gold flecks in the onyx shifting like embers in a dying fire. He stepped closer, until the heat radiating from his body was the only thing I could feel. “You aren't just a Scribe. You’re the girl who stole fire from the mountain. Stop looking at yourself through your mother’s eyes, Elara. She sees a defect. I see a wildfire that just needs a place to burn.”

He reached into the pocket of his trousers and pulled out a small, heavy object. He took my hand, his palm warm against mine, and pressed the object into my fingers. It was the Adamas-shard—the fragment of heavenly silver that pulsed with a rhythmic, violet light.

“Keep it,” he whispered, his face inches from mine. “Don't use it unless you’re about to collapse. The dragons value strength, but they value resourcefulness more. If they see you using a shard to fuel your runes, they’ll know you’re smart enough to use every tool at your disposal. They’ll know you're a Sorrengail who knows how to survive.”

“Why are you giving this to me?” I asked, my breath hitching as the violet light reflected in his eyes. “This is a treasonous amount of power, Xaden. If the Peacekeepers find this on me, even my mother won't be able to stop them from branding me a traitor.”

“The Peacekeepers won't find it,” he interrupted, his thumb grazing the line of my jaw with a tenderness that felt like a threat. “Because you’re going to hide it in the one place they’re too afraid to look. You're going to hide it in your heart.”

He moved his hand to the collar of my tunic, his fingers brushing the skin just above my sternum. The contact sent a jolt of electricity through me that had nothing to do with the runes. For a second, the world outside simply ceased to exist. There was only the scent of woodsmoke and winter rain, and the terrifying, magnetic pull of the man standing in front of me.

“Xaden,” I breathed, my eyes fluttering shut as the shadows in the room seemed to lean in, listening.

“Don't,” he murmured, his forehead resting against mine. “Don't say my name like that. Not when we’re three hours away from a massacre.”

He pulled back, the shadows at his feet lashing out as if they were reflecting his internal turmoil. He looked at me one last time before he turned and vanished into the hallway, leaving the air behind him feeling cold and empty.

The bell for the Threshing didn't ring; it tolled. It was a deep, mournful sound that echoed through the obsidian bowels of the fortress, calling the "meat" to the slaughter. I joined the stream of cadets in the hallway, moving in silence. We were a sea of black leather and bruised faces, stumbling through the Tunnel of the Damned toward the staging area.

Rhiannon found me near the staircase, her dark hair braided tight against her scalp. She didn't say "good luck." Luck was a currency we didn't have. “Check your straps,” she whispered, her hand brushing my shoulder. “Ridoc is already at the gate. He’s currently trying to trade a week’s ration of bread for a 'dragon-repellent' charm a Second-Year sold him. I think it's just a piece of dried goat dung.”

“If it works, I’ll buy two,” I muttered, trying to find a rhythm in my walk that didn't jar my spine. Every step was a calculation of weight and balance. I visualized the map of the Vale I had seen in my father's office—the high basalt cliffs, the sulfur pits, the narrow ravines where a small rider could hide from a large predator.

As we emerged onto the limestone plateau overlooking the Vale, the sheer scale of the event hit me. The Vale was a lush, green bowl carved into the mountain, hidden by permanent mist and ancient wards. It was the heart of Idris, the only place where dragons lived in their natural state, and we were about to walk into it unarmed.

“Look at the little Scribe,” a voice sneered from the edge of the crowd.

Jack Havoc stood by the iron gates, his broad shoulders blocking the path. He looked entirely too energized, his eyes wide with a manic, bloodthirsty light. He had been one of the few who hadn't struggled on the Gauntlet, and he clearly felt the mountain owed him a Red Daggertail.

“I’m surprised you didn't trip on your own shadow on the way down, Sorrengail,” Jack said, stepping into my personal space until I could smell the stale ale on his breath. “But don't worry. If the dragons don't finish you, I’ll be happy to step in. A girl who uses demon-marks on her own kind shouldn't be allowed to bond. It’s a stain on the Wing.”

“The Codex says all marks are legal until the first dragon chooses, Jack,” I said, my voice steadier than I felt. I reached into my sleeve, my fingers brushing the hidden Stele. “And according to the Scribe files, the last person who tried to bully a Sorrengail ended up as a footnote in a history of 'Unfortunate Accidents.' Do you want to be a footnote, or do you want to be a rider? Because right now, you're just a loud-mouthed distraction.”

Jack’s face contorted, his hand flying to the hilt of his training sword. But before he could draw, a shadow stretched across the ground between us—a jagged, cold line that seemed to originate from the watchtower above. Xaden was watching from the heights, his presence a silent warning that made the air hum with static. Jack swallowed hard and moved away, joining his squad of sycophants.

I turned my attention back to the Vale. To anyone else, it was a forest of emerald and mist. To me, it was a complex architecture of survival. I saw the way the trees leaned toward the ley lines, indicating the areas of highest magical resonance where the dragons would be most active. I saw the basalt outcroppings that provided natural cover from aerial thermal blasts.

I wasn't going to outrun a dragon. I wasn't going to outfight one. I was going to outthink the landscape. I reached for the Adamas-shard hidden in my tunic, the violet light a secret fire against my skin. I was Elara Sorrengail. I was twenty years old. I was made of glass and ink and borrowed strength. And today, I was going to show the mountain that the smallest spark can start the greatest fire.

The gates groaned open, the sound like the grinding of ancient teeth, and the Threshing began.

As the first wave of cadets descended into the mist, the silence of the plateau was replaced by the distant, bone-shaking roars of the dragons below. The ground vibrated beneath my boots, a low-frequency hum that made my teeth ache. I took a deep breath, the air tasting of ozone and ancient earth, and stepped into the green abyss. I didn't look for a dragon; I

looked for the shadows. Because in the Fourth Wing, the shadows were the only thing that ever told the truth.

I found my first waypoint—a narrow crevice in the limestone that led down to the lower ravines. It was too small for a dragon to follow, but just wide enough for a girl who knew how to compress her shoulders. I slid into the dark, the stone walls pressing against my ribs like a cold embrace. My Binding runes flared a desperate blue, locking my joints as I navigated the vertical drop.

Twenty minutes in, the first scream echoed through the Vale. It was high, sharp, and cut off with a sickening suddenness. The Threshing had claimed its first tribute. I didn't stop. I couldn't. I pushed deeper into the ravine, my mind moving faster than my feet, calculating the wind shear and the thermal pockets. I wasn't just a candidate anymore; I was a ghost in the machine of the mountain, and I was going to make sure that when the sun went down, I was the one holding the pen to write the history of this day.

Chapter Thirteen

The ravine was a world of damp velvet and ancient silence, a space carved so deep into the marrow of the mountain that the sun felt like a memory from a different life. I moved with the agonizing precision of a thief in a cathedral, my boots finding purchase on the mossy ledges while my mind cataloged every shift in the air. The scent of the Vale was a thick, primal soup—the rot of centuries-old cedar, the biting tang of sulfur, and the underlying metallic ozone that signaled the presence of apex predators. Every breath was a labor; the air here was heavy with moisture, clinging to my lungs like wet wool.

My Binding runes were a steady, low-grade throb against my joints, acting as magical splints that kept my ligaments from unraveling under the strain of the descent. My left hip was a constant, nagging heat, a warning that the joint was nearing its limit. I reached the bottom of the fissure and paused, pressing my back against the cold, weeping limestone. The mist here was a physical entity, a grey shroud that muffled the distant, bone-shaking roars of the upper peaks. I was alone in the dark, a girl made of glass and ink, waiting for the mountain to decide if it was done with me.

I reached inside my tunic and felt the Adamas-shard tucked against my heart. It was warm—almost hot—pulsing with a low-frequency vibration that seemed to be scanning the mist. It was a beacon, and in a valley filled with creatures that hunted by soul-scent, a beacon was a death sentence. I should have thrown it away. I should have listened to the logic of the Scribe files that warned against carrying unshielded heavenly silver into dragon territory. But the heat of the shard was the only thing keeping the chill of the ravine from sinking into my marrow.

A sudden shift in the wind brought a heat so intense it singed the fine hairs on my neck. I didn't turn; I dropped. I threw myself into a hollow beneath a gnarled root system, my face pressed into the dirt, just as a shadow the size of a warship eclipsed the narrow strip of sky above the ravine. The air was displaced with a violent *whump*, a localized gale that nearly sucked me from my hiding spot.

It was a Blue Daggertail—a mid-sized predator known for its tactical cruelty and its habit of playing with its food. I watched through the tangled roots, my heart hammering a frantic rhythm against the stone. The dragon landed on a ledge fifty yards away, its scales shimmering like oil on water in the dim light. It didn't look for a rider; it looked for sport. It sniffed the air, its bifurcated tongue flickering out to taste the fear I knew I was radiating.

Stay still, I commanded my lungs. *Be the stone. Be the shadow.*

The dragon stayed for what felt like an hour, its golden eye scanning the ravine with a clinical, terrifying detachment. It let out a low, vibrating growl that made the root system above me shudder, showering my hair with loose earth. Then, with a sudden, dismissive snort of steam that smelled of charred meat, it launched itself back into the mist. I didn't move until the sound of its wings was a ghost in the distance. My breath came in ragged, shallow gasps. That was the reality of the Threshing: we weren't just candidates; we were prey. The "Golden Opportunity" my mother had touted was nothing more than a game of cat and mouse where the mice were unarmed and the cats weighed ten tons.

I pushed forward, moving deeper into the southern quadrant where the basalt pillars formed a natural labyrinth. My hips ground together with every second step, a sickening, audible click that echoed off the obsidian walls. I was running out of energy. The Stability runes on my ankles were fading to a dull, ashen grey, and the "crutch" of the magic was beginning to fail. I was becoming a liability to myself, a girl who could barely walk in a valley where speed was the only currency of survival.

I rounded the base of a massive obsidian pillar, and the world simply... stopped.

The mist didn't just clear; it curdled into a thick, black smoke. The temperature spiked, a wave of heat so sudden it made the sweat on my forehead evaporate instantly. The smell hit me next—not sulfur, not rot, but the scent of woodsmoke, winter rain, and the freezing, empty space between the stars. It was the scent of the void.

Standing in the center of a scorched clearing was a dragon that shouldn't have existed. It was a Black Void-Strike Tail. Its scales weren't just black; they were a total absence of light, a jagged silhouette that seemed to drink the meager grey dawn of the Vale. It was twice the size of the Blue Daggertail, its body a masterpiece of lethal geometry. But it was the tail that made my throat lock. It was tipped with a crystalline, multi-faceted stinger that shimmered with a pale, violet light—the color of raw ley-line energy.

The dragon didn't roar. It didn't move. It simply looked at me.

Its eyes were a swirling storm of onyx and silver, shifting with a terrifying, sentient intelligence. The Adamas-shard against my chest began to vibrate so violently it felt like a trapped bird trying to claw its way through my ribs. The heat was unbearable, a searing brand that demanded I acknowledge the presence before me.

You are the girl who stole the mountain's fire, a voice echoed in the cavern of my skull. It wasn't a sound; it was a resonance, a frequency that vibrated through my teeth and settled in my spine.

I couldn't breathe. My knees buckled, the joints finally giving way under the sheer weight of the draconic presence. I hit the scorched earth, my hands clawing at the ash, as the dragon took a single, deliberate step toward me. The ground groaned under the pressure of its claw, the stone beneath the soil cracking like thin ice.

"I am a Scribe," I whispered, the words sounding pathetic in the face of the void.

The dragon paused, its massive snout inches from my face. I could feel the heat of its nostrils, the scent of burning empires and ancient starlight. It tilted its head, a slow, predatory movement that felt like a predator inspecting a medical curiosity.

My name is Advast, the voice resonated again, darker and more ancient than the mountain itself. *And I have waited a long time for a rider who carries a library in her head and enough spite in her bones to challenge the*

void. The others... they bring swords. They bring ambition. They bring the smell of their own ego. You bring the truth.

“I don't have strength,” I wheezed, my vision swimming with white spots. “I have a body made of glass and a heart that’s already breaking.”

Strength is a lie told by the weak to feel safe, Advast countered, his silver eyes flashing with a cold light. *I do not need a rider who can swing a sword. I need a rider who can map the stars while the world burns. Tell me, Elara Sorrengail... do you want to record history, or do you want to be the shadow that consumes it?*

Before I could answer, a flash of charcoal leather moved in the periphery of my vision. Xaden Herondale stepped out of the shadows of the obsidian pillar, his own dragon, Sgaeyl, perched on the heights above. He looked at Advast, then at me, his face a mask of pure, unadulterated terror. He looked like he was watching a child play with a lightning bolt.

“Elara, don't move,” he called out, his voice cracking for the first time since I’d met him. “That’s a Void-Strike. They don't bond; they only destroy. They were bred for the Great Uprising and then abandoned because they couldn't be controlled. He will turn your marrow to ash the moment you touch him.”

Advast let out a sound that could only be described as a dry, draconic laugh, the stinger on his tail sparking with violet lightning that turned the clearing into a strobe-light nightmare. He didn't look at Xaden. He stayed focused on me, his presence a gravity I could no longer escape.

The shadow-boy thinks he knows the dark, Advast’s voice echoed, dripping with a terrifying kind of amusement. *But he only knows the absence of light. He thinks control is the same as power. You, little Scribe... you know that power is the willingness to let go.*

The dragon took another step, his massive claw resting inches from my boot. I looked up at the void of his scales, at the storm in his eyes, and realized that the Parapet was a playground and the Gauntlet was a dream.

Everything I had been told—about my worth, about my body, about my mother’s expectations—was a lie. I wasn't a defect. I was a vessel.

“I want to survive,” I said, my voice hardening as the spite finally rose to meet the fear, a cold, sharp blade of will. I pushed myself up, my joints screaming, and pressed my palm against the freezing, obsidian-hard scale of his snout.

The reaction was instantaneous. The Adamas-shard in my tunic flared with a blinding, violet light, merging my heartbeat with his in a violent, symphonic union. The pain was gone, replaced by a cold, humming power that made my skin glow. I felt his memories—the birth of the mountains, the death of the first riders, the hunger of the void—flooding my mind.

“I want to survive long enough to make my mother regret every word she ever said to me,” I whispered, looking Advast in the eye. “If you are the void, then let me be the hand that guides the strike.”

Advast let out a puff of smoke that smelled of triumph and starlight. He lowered his shoulder, the massive wing forming a ramp of obsidian leather that led to the sky.

Then climb, wildfire, he commanded. *And let us see if the world is ready for a Scribe who has tamed the end of all things.*

I didn't hesitate. I ignored the terror in Xaden's eyes and the roaring of the wind. I climbed, my hands gripping the jagged, crystalline ridges of his spine. As I settled into the hollow between his shoulders, the world below suddenly looked very, very small. I wasn't a Scribe anymore. I wasn't a Sorrengail. I was the rider of the void.

Chapter Fourteen

The transition from the scorched earth of the Vale to the sky was a violent extraction from reality. As I hauled my bruised, trembling body up the obsidian ramp of Advast's wing, the world of Shadowhunters and Scribes felt like a fading fever dream. Every muscle in my legs screamed as I gripped the jagged, crystalline ridges of his spine. My flight leathers, designed for standard-issue dragons, felt as thin as parchment against the sheer, icy heat radiating from his scales.

I settled into the hollow between his massive shoulder blades, my knees locking into the natural grooves of his armor. The moment my skin—filtered through the leather—made contact with his primary ridge, the Adamas-shard against my heart didn't just pulse; it fused. A bridge of violet light snapped into existence, tethering my nervous system to the dragon's consciousness.

The sensory overload was a physical blow. I wasn't just Elara Sorrengail anymore. I was the mountain. I was the wind. I was the freezing, empty hunger of the ley lines. I could feel the microscopic tremors in the earth beneath Advast's claws and the way the air temperature dropped three hundred feet above us.

Hold on, little wildfire, Advast's voice resonated, no longer a sound but a core vibration in my bones. *The sky does not welcome the heavy-hearted.*

"Elara! Get down!"

Xaden's voice was a desperate rasp from the ground below. He was running toward us, his shadows lashing out in a frantic, uncoordinated swarm. Sgaeyl let out a warning shriek from the cliffs, her golden eyes wide with a terror that mirrored her rider's. In the history of the Fourth Wing, no one had ever bonded a Void-Strike and lived through the first minute. The sheer magical pressure alone was supposed to liquify a human's organs.

But I wasn't just any human. I was a Scribe who had spent twenty years learning how to contain vast amounts of information in a fragile vessel. I

took the roaring power Advast was pouring into me and channeled it into the empty spaces of my library—the memory of every rune, every tactical map, and every linguistic root I had ever learned. I used my mind as a dampening field, absorbing the void until my very breath came out as a faint, violet mist.

"I'm not getting down, Xaden," I called back, my voice sounding amplified, echoing with the resonance of the dragon. "I'm going up."

Advast didn't wait for a signal. He didn't need one. He crouched, his massive haunches bunching with the power of a thousand lightning strikes. The ground beneath us didn't just crack; it pulverized into dust. With a sound that shattered the remaining silence of the ravine, he launched.

The G-force was a hammer. My head snapped back, and for a terrifying second, my vision went white. My Binding runes flared a blinding, desperate silver, fighting to keep my neck from snapping. I gripped the ridges of his spine until my knuckles bled, my fingers finding the raw, jagged edges of the crystalline stinger that now hovered just above my head.

We didn't fly; we pierced the atmosphere. The mist of the Vale was a blur, then a memory, as we tore through the cloud layer. The transition was a physical shock—from the damp, sulfurous heat of the valley to the biting, crystalline cold of the upper peaks.

I opened my eyes, and for the first time in my life, the world made sense.

The sky wasn't blue; it was a tapestry of ley lines, glowing silver and violet against the blackness of the void. I could see the wards of Idris pulsing like a heartbeat, the Adamas stones in the distance glowing with a rhythmic, artificial light. And there, stretched out beneath us, was the Alicante War College—a tiny, obsidian toy house perched on a needle of rock.

Do you see it now? Advast asked, his wings beating with a slow, hypnotic rhythm that felt like the pulse of the universe. *The cage they built for you? The smallness of their rules?*

"It's beautiful," I whispered, the freezing wind tearing the words from my lips.

It is a graveyard, Advast countered. *And we are the only things truly alive within it.*

He banked hard to the left, and I felt the weight of the turn in my very marrow. I didn't slip. I didn't fall. The Adamas-shard was acting as a magical anchor, pinning me to his back with a force that surpassed gravity. We were a single entity—a Scribe's mind and a dragon's strike—drifting through the silence of the high peaks.

Below us, I could see the other candidates. They looked like ants, scurrying across the field for the bonding ceremony. I saw the flash of my mother's silver wings on the dais, and the smaller, frantic movements of Xaden as he tried to track us through the clouds. They were waiting for a celebration. They were waiting for a Sorrengail to bond a respectable, predictable dragon and take her place in the line.

They weren't ready for the void.

Advast hovered, his massive wings creating a localized storm that sent the clouds spiraling into a vortex. He looked down at the ceremony, his silver eyes reflecting the fire of the altars below.

They will try to bind us, Elara, Advast warned. *They will try to use the runes you love so much to turn my fire into their fuel. They will call it 'duty.' They will call it 'loyalty.'*

"Let them try," I said, the spite in my bones turning into something colder, something more permanent. I looked at my hands, where the silver ink of my runes was now laced with the violet glow of the void. "I'm done being the girl who records history. I'm ready to be the one who ends it."

Then let us give them a grand entrance, Advast said, his tail-stinger beginning to hum with a lethal, high-frequency vibration. *Let us show the General what her 'defect' has brought home.*

He tucked his wings and began the dive.

We fell like a fallen star, a streak of black and violet tearing through the morning sky. The air shrieked against my leathers, and the heat of the friction began to singe the edges of my hair. I didn't close my eyes. I watched as the ground rushed up to meet us, the faces of the cadets turning upward in a collective mask of shock and horror.

I saw my mother stand up, her hand flying to the hilt of her sword. I saw Xaden stop mid-stride, his shadows retreating in the face of the blinding light Advast was emitting.

We weren't just landing. We were making a claim.

Chapter Fifteen

The descent was an atmospheric assault that redefined the meaning of the word "spectacle." Advast did not glide; he dropped like a shard of obsidian cast from the heavens by an angry god. The air shrieked in protest as his massive wings flared at the last possible microsecond, the force of the downdraft shattering the wooden spectator benches and sending a blinding cloud of pulverized limestone over the assembled high-ranking Shadowhunters.

When the dust finally settled, the silence that followed was more violent than the roar of the dive. It was a vacuum, a hollow space where the breath of every cadet and commander in Idris seemed to have been snatched away simultaneously.

I sat atop the Black Void-Strike Tail, my hands still fused to the crystalline ridges of his spine by the violet light of the Adamas-shard. My hair had escaped its practical braid, whipping around my face in a wild, singed halo of copper. I looked down from a height of twenty feet, staring directly at the woman who had spent twenty years trying to prune me into something she could recognize—something she could control.

General Lilith Sorrengail stood at the center of the stone dais, her charcoal leathers pristine, her grey eyes narrowed into lethal slits. She didn't look at me with the pride of a mother whose daughter had survived the impossible. She looked at Advast with the cold, clinical calculation of a tactician who had just realized her most predictable pawn had transformed into a queen she didn't know how to move.

"Elara," my mother’s voice carried through the wreckage of the courtyard, sounding like the cracking of ice over a deep, dark lake. "Explain the meaning of this… display. You were instructed to bond a rider-capable breed that served the needs of the Nephilim. You have brought a relic of the Great Uprising into the heart of the college. A creature that is legally classified in the Scribe archives as a weapon of mass destruction."

Advast let out a low, vibrating growl that made the stone beneath my mother's heavy boots spider-web with cracks. The violet stinger on his tail—the source of the void-strike—hovered inches from the General's head, pulsing with the rhythmic, terrifying hunger of a dying star.

The female smells of stale ice and the blood of my kin, Advast's voice resonated in my mind, a dark, velvet rumble that skipped my ears and shook my soul. *Shall I extinguish the frost, wildfire? Shall I show her what the void does to a heart made of duty?*

"No," I said aloud, my voice amplified by the dragon's power until it echoed off the fortress walls like thunder. I didn't climb down. I stayed perched in the saddle of his spine, the master of the beast they all feared. I looked my mother in the eye, the spite in my soul finally crystallizing into a sovereign throne. "I didn't bring a weapon, Mother. I brought a partner. You told me that a Sorrengail enters the War College on her feet or not at all. I think entering on the back of the void qualifies as 'standing' quite firmly."

My mother's jaw tightened, the silver wings pinned to her chest glinting with a predatory light. "You are playing with forces you cannot conjugate, Elara. You are a Scribe. Your bones are porous stone, and your ligaments are wet lace. This bond will burn the marrow from your body before the sun sets. You are a liability to this wing, and a danger to every cadet standing on this field."

"Then I'll die with more fire in my veins than you ever had in your heart," I countered, the words sharp enough to draw blood.

The crowd of cadets—the same ones who had spent weeks calling me a defect, who had tripped me in the hallways and laughed as my Binding runes flickered—stood frozen. They weren't looking at the "Librarian's Daughter" anymore. They were looking at a girl who had tamed the end of the world.

A movement in the crowd broke the stalemate.

Xaden Herondale stepped forward, cutting through the line of Peacekeepers as if they were made of mist. His shadows weren't lashing out in the frantic, jagged bursts I had seen in the Vale; they were calm, pooling at his feet like a loyal, silent guard. He walked toward Advast, ignoring the way the dragon’s scales sparked with violet electricity as he drew near. He didn't look at the General. He didn't look at the high-ranking officers or the terrified cadets. He only looked at me.

"Elara," he said, his voice a low rumble that cut through the static of the void.

I slid down Advast’s wing, my joints protesting the sudden shift in gravity, but the violet light of the bond acted as a magical exoskeleton, holding me together. I landed on the cracked limestone, my boots skidding in the dust. My hips didn't click. My spine didn't ache. For the first time in my life, I felt truly, terrifyingly whole.

Xaden stopped inches from me. The air between us was a physical cord, pulled taut until it hummed with the same resonance as the mountain’s heart. He reached out, his hand trembling slightly—the only sign of the terror he had felt—and cupped my jaw. His thumb traced the line of my bottom lip, his touch searingly hot against my cold, ley-line-charged skin.

"You're a disaster, Sorrengail," he whispered, his eyes a storm of onyx and gold. "You actually did it. You went and found the only thing in this world more dangerous than the man you’re supposed to hate."

"I told you I was going to survive," I breathed, my fingers finding the edge of his tunic.

"You did," he murmured, leaning closer until I could smell the woodsmoke on his skin. "And now, I have to figure out how to live in a world where you're the one holding the match to the powder keg."

He didn't wait for my mother’s permission. He didn't care about the scandal that would ripple through the Scribe archives for the next century or the fact

that he was kissing the daughter of his father's executioner. He leaned in and crashed his mouth against mine.

The kiss was a collision of two opposing forces. It tasted of winter rain and the metallic tang of dragon fire. The moment our lips met, our shadows intertwined—his dark, fluid ribbons merging with the violet sparks of my bond in a dance of pure rebellion. It was a declaration of war against the status quo. It was the children of the traitors and the daughter of the elite, claiming a history that hadn't been written for them.

A collective, horrified gasp went through the assembly. I could hear my mother’s intake of breath—a sharp, hissed sound of absolute fury. But I didn't pull away. I leaned into him, my fingers tangling in the dark hair at the nape of his neck, using his strength to anchor me as Advast let out a roar that shook the very foundations of the college.

As we finally pulled apart, Xaden kept his arm locked around my waist, his presence a living shield against the General’s lethal gaze. I looked back at my mother, a small, cold smile touching my lips.

"I believe you were saying something about 'disciplinary consequences,' Mother?" I asked. "Or would you like to discuss the tactical advantages of the Fourth Wing's new Void-Strike? Because according to the Codex, a bonded dragon's rider is exempt from standard infantry discipline."

My mother looked from me to Xaden, and then to the massive, black void of a dragon standing behind us. She was a woman of war, and she knew when she had lost the hill. But her silence was a promise: this wasn't the end of the battle. It was just the first time I had won.

Chapter Sixteen

The silence after my mother's retreat was a victory.

General Lilith Sorrengail did not storm off the dais. That was the terrifying thing about her. She didn't storm anywhere. She simply looked at Xaden's arm around my waist and at the smoldering crater Advast had made of the limestone courtyard, and she made a decision behind her grey eyes that I couldn't read. Then she turned, the silver wings on her chest catching the thin morning light, and walked with perfect, measured precision into the shadowed archway of the command tower. Her Peacekeepers fell in around her like a tide reclaiming the shore.

She didn't look back. She didn't need to. The promise in her silence was louder than anything she could have shouted.

"She's going to make your life very difficult," Xaden murmured against my hair. He hadn't moved his arm.

"She's been doing that since I was born," I said. But my voice lacked its usual spite. The bond with Advast was still a roaring current beneath my skin, a river of ancient power that made the world feel like it was vibrating at a frequency no one else could hear. My hand was pressed against the Adamas-shard on my chest, its pulse synchronized with my heartbeat—and with the slow, deliberate breathing of the dragon standing twenty feet behind us like a planet in a personal orbit.

The frost-woman is afraid, Advast's voice resonated in the cavern of my skull. It wasn't a gloat. It was a clinical observation, delivered with the detachment of something that had witnessed the rise and fall of empires. *Fear makes generals dangerous. You should rest, wildfire. The bond is still burning the dead wood from your nervous system.*

"In a minute," I thought back, experimentally. The response was immediate—a low, warm rumble that I felt in my molars. Communicating with him was nothing like I'd read in the theoretical texts. The manuals described the bond as a "shared clarity of purpose." What it actually felt like

was having someone push all the furniture in your mind three inches to the left. Everything was still there, but nothing was quite where you'd left it.

The cadets had not moved. They stood in a loose, stunned semicircle, their faces a collective portrait of shock, calculation, and—in a few cases—outright terror. The bonding ceremony, which was supposed to be a controlled, organized affair, lay in ruins around us. Three of the wooden spectator benches were splinters. The limestone of the dais had buckled under Advast's landing, hairline fractures spreading through the stone like a map of every broken rule I'd just committed to.

Rhiannon was the first one to move. She crossed the courtyard at a near-run, her braid streaming behind her, and grabbed my free arm with both hands. She looked at me with an expression that contained, in equal measure, pure terror and the most radiant, incandescent pride I had ever seen on another person's face.

"You bonded a Void-Strike," she breathed.

"Apparently," I said.

"The records say the last person who touched one lost their mind in three seconds." She looked at Advast. The dragon turned one silver, swirling eye toward her and let out a slow, contemplative breath of steam. Rhiannon's grip on my arm tightened. "He's very... large."

"Yes."

"And he's looking at me like I'm a small, nutritious snack."

She smells of loyalty and dried fruit, Advast noted. *I approve. Keep her close.*

"He approves of you," I relayed.

Rhiannon blinked. "He—you can hear him?"

"He's rather difficult to not hear," I admitted.

Ridoc appeared at her shoulder, his pale face nearly translucent, his blue eyes wide as moons. He looked from me to Advast to Xaden to the ruined courtyard, and then he made a sound that wasn't quite a laugh and wasn't quite a sob. "I've been doing the math," he announced, "and I have calculated that the probability of our squad surviving the next academic year has just dropped to somewhere around eleven percent."

"It was at twelve before," I pointed out.

"I'm counting the dragon as a variable," Ridoc said. "A very large, void-powered variable with a stinger the size of a joust pole."

Xaden finally stepped back, his arm sliding from my waist with a reluctance that I felt rather than saw. His Wing Leader mask was settling back into place, the cold geometry of it reconstructing feature by feature. But his eyes—those infuriating, shifting storms of onyx and gold—stayed warm for a half-second longer than the mask would have permitted.

"Sorrengail," he said, and his voice was once again the flat authority of a commanding officer. "Get your dragon to the rider's paddock before the Commandant calls the Peacekeepers. I'll handle the disciplinary filing."

"You mean you'll make it disappear," I translated.

"I mean I'll file it in a way that takes six months for anyone to find," he corrected. A ghost of that dark, devastating smirk touched the corner of his mouth. "Move, Elara. You have until the second bell."

…

The rider's paddock for Fourth Wing occupied the lowest tier of the outer fortress, a series of massive, vaulted caves that opened onto a sheer, two-thousand-foot drop into the Acheron valley. It smelled of sulfur, rendered tallow, and the biting, mineral ozone of a dozen different breeds of dragon, all of whom went entirely silent the moment Advast walked in.

It wasn't the silence of deference. It was the silence of prey recognizing a predator at the apex of the food chain.

The other newly bonded dragons—a Green Daggertail, a pair of Bronze Scaleback, and a slender Blue Swift-Wing that belonged to a girl named Cass from First Squad—pressed themselves against the far walls of their individual stalls. The Green Daggertail made a sound I had never heard a dragon make before: a low, keening whimper that it quickly stifled, as if embarrassed by its own instincts.

They are wise, Advast observed, settling into the largest open cave with the certainty of a creature that had never in its long life doubted its right to occupy any space it chose. His crystalline tail-stinger left deep furrows in the granite as it dragged. *Tell the small ones I have no interest in consuming them. Today.*

"That is not as reassuring as you think it is," I told him.

I know, he replied, and I could have sworn he was amused.

I spent an hour in the paddock, sitting cross-legged in the curve of his folded front leg while the afternoon light crept across the stone. I was supposed to be reviewing the bonding protocols in the Codex—the official registration of a dragon, the assignment of a Wing designation, the formal logging of the rider's magical profile. But I couldn't make myself open the book.

My hands were still faintly luminescent. In the dimness of the cave, I could see the silver-and-violet tracery of the bond running up my forearms like a second skeleton of light. It didn't hurt. That was the strangest thing. After a lifetime of runes that felt like hot coals pressed into my skin, the Adamas-bond felt like something finally, irrevocably *settling*.

"Elara." The voice came from the cave entrance.

I turned. Xaden was leaning in the threshold, his arms crossed, his jacket gone. His tunic was untucked, sleeves pushed to the elbow in a way that made him look startlingly human. The "Mark of the Traitor" on his neck pulsed with its slow, obsidian rhythm.

"The Commandant wants a full incident report," he said. "Signed by you and co-signed by the Wing Leader."

"Which means you."

"Which means me." He walked into the cave without hesitation. Advast opened one massive eye and tracked him across the floor with the lazy, proprietary attention of a cat watching a bird it had temporarily decided not to eat.

The shadow-boy again, Advast noted.

"He has a name," I murmured.

They all have names. Most of them are irrelevant. This one is... not entirely irrelevant. A pause. *His shadows taste of old grief and new fire. He has been carrying the same anger for so long he has forgotten what it was originally for.*

That observation settled in my chest like a stone dropping into still water. I looked at Xaden, who had stopped a few feet away and was studying the luminescent tracery on my forearms with an expression he was working very hard to keep neutral.

"How do you feel?" he asked. The Wing Leader cadence was gone. It was just a question.

"Like I swallowed a ley line," I said honestly. "And like everything I thought I knew about the limits of my body was a story someone told me to keep me manageable."

He crouched down in front of me, bringing his eyes level with mine. "Your runes are changing," he said quietly. He reached out and, very carefully, turned my arm over. His thumb traced the luminescent line running from my wrist to the inside of my elbow—the path of the bond current. "The silver ink is being replaced. The void-energy is rewriting the marks at a cellular level. I've never seen it before." His voice was careful and clinical, but his thumb did not stop its slow passage along the line of light.

"Is it dangerous?" I asked.

"Everything about you is dangerous," he said, and it didn't sound like a complaint. He looked up at my face, his expression fracturing for just a moment—that terrifying window opening in the wall. "It's also extraordinary. Your body is adapting to the bond instead of breaking under it. The Adamas-shard is acting as a converter. It's translating a Void-Strike's raw power into a frequency your nervous system can absorb. Your father's Scribe-blood might have something to do with it. The capacity for sustained information-load. The mental architecture."

"So my useless librarian brain is the only reason I'm alive," I said.

"Among other things," he murmured, his eyes dropping briefly to my mouth.

Advast made a sound like distant thunder rolling through a canyon. It was, I was quite certain, a warning.

Xaden stood up, clearing his throat. The Wing Leader mask snapped back into place like a visor dropping. "Report. First bell tomorrow. Don't be late."

He left before I could say anything else. His shadows lingered a half-second after he did, pooling at the cave entrance before they followed him into the dark.

Yes, Advast rumbled, his eye sliding shut again. *Not entirely irrelevant at all.*

Chapter Seventeen

The Fourth Wing common room was, under normal circumstances, the social heart of a vipers' nest. Now, in the aftermath of the Threshing, it had been transformed into something that occupied the precise midpoint between a war council and a wake.

Every newly bonded First-Year was there, most still in their flight leathers, most still carrying the specific, hollow-eyed look of people who had recently been reminded of their own mortality at extreme close range. The common room was a long, low vault of obsidian, lit by iron chandeliers holding witch-light globes that cast everything in a cool, spectral blue. Someone had shoved the tables to the walls, and cadets were clustered in small groups on the stone benches, speaking in hushed, urgent voices.

When I walked in with Rhiannon and Ridoc, the room went silent.

It wasn't the comfortable silence of mutual acknowledgment. It was the jagged, complicated silence of people reassessing everything they thought they knew about the social hierarchy they were all about to live inside.

I had bonded the Void-Strike. I had kissed the Wing Leader in public. I had survived the Chimney, the Logs, and a direct confrontation with my mother in front of the assembled command staff of the Alicante War College. I was either the most powerful first-year to walk through these doors in a generation, or I was a dead woman with about a seventy-two hour head start on the inevitable.

From the looks on the faces around the room, opinions were split fairly evenly.

"Sorrengail." The voice came from the far end of the room. Imogen—the Second-Year with the blood-red hair and the permanent sneer—was sitting atop one of the displaced tables, her Speed-type runes glowing a faint, predatory gold at her throat. She was looking at me with an expression that had changed. The mocking pity from the mess hall was gone. What had

replaced it was something sharper and more dangerous: competitive assessment.

"Imogen," I said.

"Sit down," she said. It wasn't an invitation. It wasn't quite an order, either. It was a test—the first word in a conversation about power that neither of us had been explicitly invited to have. "I want to hear about the bond."

I looked at Rhiannon. She gave a fractional shrug that said *your call, but I've got your back.*

I sat down. Not because Imogen told me to, but because my hips were screaming and my pride could survive the appearance of compliance. I picked a seat at the center of the group, which felt important. I didn't hide against a wall, and I didn't take a position of dominance at the head of a table. I sat in the middle of the room, where everyone could see me, and I met Imogen's gaze across the space.

"Ask your questions," I said.

What followed was two hours that felt like a very intense academic examination combined with a political negotiation. Cadets I had never spoken to—Second-Years and First-Years alike, Traitor's Children and legacy Shadowhunters both—cycled through the room, listening, asking, watching. I told them what it felt like to touch a Void-Strike. I told them about the ley-line energy in the Chimney. I described Advast's mental voice, his perception of the wards, the way the bond felt like a second nervous system plugged directly into the mountain's root system.

I didn't tell them about Xaden. Some conversations were not for common rooms.

Ridoc, who had bonded a quiet, brown-scaled Bronze Scaleback he'd named "Tallow" (the dragon had looked at the name with what could only be described as dignified resignation), kept detailed notes on a scrap of parchment. He had a gift for synthesis, for finding the through-line in a

cluster of data, and by the end of the evening he had produced a rough schematic of what he called "the void-bond's secondary effects on rider physiology." It was twelve points long and included a footnote about the way my pupils had changed color. I hadn't known my pupils had changed color.

"They're violet now," Rhiannon confirmed, examining my face with a clinical interest that would have been disturbing from anyone else. "The left one more than the right. It started after the Chimney."

"How does it look?" I asked.

"Terrifying," she said, not unkindly. "The useful kind of terrifying."

It was Imogen who ended the evening. She slid off the table, stretched with the fluid, predatory ease of someone whose dragon had given her reflexes no human body was designed for, and looked at me for a long, measuring moment. "The Traitor's Children have been the muscle of this wing for three years," she said. "And the Peacekeepers have been using that muscle to shore up the wards while they quietly decommission the outer-ring patrols. The ley lines are failing, Sorrengail. Not slowly. Fast. The southern corridor lost two Adamas anchor-stones last week. If the western ward falls, the Venin and the Greater Demons won't need an invitation."

The room had gone very still.

"Why are you telling me this?" I asked.

"Because you bonded the only dragon in a generation that can interface directly with a ley line," Imogen said. "And because Xaden Herondale has been keeping a secret for two years that your mother's people would kill every person in this room to protect." She held my gaze. "Find out what he's hiding, Sorrengail. Before the mountain decides the secret isn't worth keeping."

She left. The room slowly, carefully exhaled.

She is correct about the ley lines, Advast said from the paddock, his voice a distant, submarine rumble in the back of my mind. *I can feel the decay from here. The mountain is bleeding.*

I sat in the empty common room for a long time after the others had gone to their cells. I turned the Adamas-shard over in my fingers, watching the violet light pulse in the dark.

What was Xaden hiding?

Chapter Eighteen

Training resumed the morning after the Threshing as if the world had not fundamentally shifted on its axis the day before. In the Fourth Wing, the world was required to be ruthlessly practical, and the practical reality was that being bonded to a dragon was not the end of anything. It was the end of the beginning.

The first session was Dragon Theory with a Second-Year instructor named Professor Carr—a lean, methodical man who wore the dark blue of a retired Skystriker and spoke about dragon physiology with the precise, loveless efficiency of a man describing load-bearing architecture. He had the kind of face that had seen too much and decided to respond by feeling as little as possible. He was, in other words, essentially my mother in an academic setting, and I hated the fact that his lecture on aerial thermal dynamics was the most useful forty minutes of information I had ever absorbed.

"The bond is not a leash," Carr said, standing at the front of a low-ceilinged lecture hall carved into the mountain rock. "It is a frequency. Your dragon does not obey you. Your dragon *resonates* with you. The distinction is not semantic. If you enter aerial combat believing your mount will do what you command, you will be dead before you reach altitude. If you enter it understanding that your dragon will do what you both *agree* is correct, you might live long enough to make a strategic error."

Beside me, Ridoc was writing so fast his notes were beginning to eat themselves. Rhiannon was rigid with concentration, her jaw set in that particular line that meant she was memorizing every syllable. Around us, the newly bonded cadets of Fourth Wing filled the tiered stone seats, many of them still wearing the expression of people who had not fully slept since the Threshing.

I was listening, but I was also listening to something else—the faint, constant background resonance of Advast at the edge of my awareness. He was in the paddock, and the specific quality of his silence told me he

was doing something he described as *reading the mountain*—a deep, slow interface with the ley lines that he explained was the equivalent of listening for structural weaknesses in a building before deciding where to stand.

The professor is correct about the frequency, Advast said, at a level that felt like a murmur rather than a declaration. *He has flown. His body-memory is accurate even if his language is inadequate.*

I tried not to smile. A girl with violet-pupil eyes smiling during a lecture on aerial thermal dynamics would not go unnoticed.

The lecture ended and we were released into the drilling yard. This was the part where the Wing Leaders became gods—or revealed, depending on your relationship with the concept, that they were very specifically mortal gods who had decided the correct response to being mortal was to become considerably more frightening.

Xaden ran the advanced combat drills himself.

I had read about his fighting style in the Scribe files—the "Shadow-Strike" methodology that the Traitor's Children had developed in the years after the Binding, a system that used darkness and terrain rather than brute force. What the files had not captured was the quality of stillness he maintained in the center of a drill that could only be described as controlled brutality.

He didn't shout. He demonstrated. He moved through three Second-Year opponents with a fluid, almost choreographic efficiency that left all three of them disarmed and on the ground in under eight seconds. Then he looked at the First-Years gathered at the edge of the yard and waited.

"The Venin fight without rest," he said, once the silence had settled into something instructive. "They don't tire. They don't feel the cold or the altitude. They don't hesitate. Your only advantage—your *only* advantage—is intelligence. If you are trying to outmuscle a Venin commander, you are already dead. You need to be three decisions ahead, operating in terrain they haven't mapped." His gaze swept the group and

stopped, for the briefest measurable moment, on me. "Sorrengail. You're with me."

The yard went very quiet.

I stepped forward, my Binding runes steady—the violet-tinted bond with Advast lending my joints an artificial solidity I still hadn't entirely learned to trust. I stopped in front of Xaden, close enough to smell the winter-rain scent of him, and waited.

"Demonstrate the shoulder-rotation deflect," he said, his voice entirely professional. "The version in the Codex."

I did. I had studied it, as I had studied everything, until the theory was so embedded it was reflex. The movement was technically sound. He watched it once.

"Now do it the way your body actually moves," he said.

I stopped. "What?"

"Your hip subluxates under a full rotation. I've watched you compensate for it twelve times in the past ten minutes." He said it simply, without cruelty, the way a structural engineer might point out a load-bearing compromise. "The Codex version will break your pelvis the first time a Venin hits back. So show me what you'd actually do."

The yard was very, very attentive.

I thought about it for a moment. Then I modified the rotation—shortening the arc, shifting my weight forward onto my stronger right leg, using my elbow rather than my shoulder as the primary deflection surface. It was uglier. It was slower. It worked in a body that was designed the way mine was designed.

Xaden watched it twice. "Better," he said. "That's your real form. Learn that. Not the one in the book." He looked at the assembled cadets. "Every one of you has a version of this problem. The Codex was written for an idealized

Shadowhunter body. You are not ideal. You are specific. Find the specific version of every technique that fits the body you actually have, and use that version until it is faster than instinct." He stepped back. "Pairs. Begin."

I was still standing in the center of the yard. He walked past me—close enough that his arm brushed mine—and said, very quietly, for no one's ears but my own: "You're going to need a sparring partner who won't break you. Meet me at the secondary yard at the seventh bell. Bring the Stele. Don't tell Rhiannon where you're going."

Before I could ask why, he had moved to the far end of the yard to correct someone's footwork, and the window had closed.

Chapter Nineteen

The secondary yard was a place that the official maps of Alicante War College did not officially contain. It was accessible through a gap in the lower barracks wall—a seam in the obsidian, wide enough for a person to turn sideways and slide through—that led to a small, circular plateau jutting from the south face of the mountain. It was exposed on three sides to open sky, sheltered on the fourth by a massive basalt overhang that turned the rain into a curtain of silver at the edge. It smelled of ozone and old stone. In the daylight it was nothing remarkable. In the dark, with the ley lines of Idris pulsing below and the stars of the Shadowhunter heavens blazing above, it felt like standing at the edge of the world.

Xaden was already there when I arrived, a minute before the seventh bell. He was sitting on the low basalt ledge, his elbows on his knees, looking out at the darkness of the valley. His shadows pooled around his feet, slow and companionable, the way they only were when he thought no one was watching. He had a piece of parchment in his hands that he folded into his jacket pocket when he heard my footsteps.

"What was on the parchment?" I asked.

"Nothing that concerns you yet," he said, standing. He turned to look at me, and in the dark, without the performance of the Wing Leader mask, he looked younger and considerably more burdened. "How are the runes?"

"Adapting," I said, turning my forearm over so the violet tracery caught the starlight. "Advast says it'll be complete in three days. Whatever *complete* means in the context of having the void rewrite your nervous system."

"It means your pain threshold is going to drop significantly," he said, walking toward me with that fluid, predatory ease. "Not because you'll feel less, but because the bond will be sharing the signal load. The void distributes. Your body won't be carrying everything alone anymore." He stopped in front of me. "Show me your left hip."

"I beg your pardon?"

"The subluxation. I want to understand the range before we develop a training approach." He said it with a surgical precision that managed to contain zero intimacy while being somehow entirely intimate. His eyes were steady and professional and entirely focused.

I exhaled. I shifted my weight onto my left leg and let the joint do what it did, which was slide approximately a quarter-inch out of its socket with the familiar, nauseating click. I watched Xaden's expression absorb the information.

"Right," he said quietly. "Okay." He circled me once, slowly, the way he had looked at the Gauntlet from the upper spire—taking inventory. "The Codex technique is useless for you in close-quarters. But the void-bond should eventually eliminate the subluxation entirely. The connective tissue will be reinforced by the ley-line energy the same way Adamas reinforces ward-stone. In the meantime, we work around it."

He demonstrated a modified hold—a close-quarters lock that used the opponent's momentum rather than the rider's physical leverage, requiring almost no hip rotation at all. It was elegant, and it was built for a body with precisely my structural profile. I had the sudden, disorienting certainty that he had been thinking about this for longer than today.

"When did you plan this?" I asked.

He showed me the grip again, adjusting my arm angle with one hand. "Since the Parapet," he said, without looking up.

"You've been designing training modifications for me since the first day?"

"Since the first day," he confirmed, as if this were entirely unremarkable. "You were always going to need a different approach. The question was whether you were going to survive long enough to need it."

I thought about Imogen's words in the common room. *He's been keeping a secret for two years.*

"Xaden," I said.

"Mm."

"What are the ley lines actually doing?"

His hands stilled on my arm. The shadows at his feet went very quiet. The quality of the silence changed—became load-bearing.

"Imogen told you," he said. It wasn't a question.

"She said the western ward lost two anchor-stones last week. She said the ley line decay is faster than anyone is admitting. She said you know something."

He let go of my arm and stepped back. He turned toward the valley below, his profile cut against the darkness, the "Mark of the Traitor" a living thing at his throat. For a long time he said nothing. I waited. I had learned, in twenty years of libraries, that silence asked better questions than words.

"The ley lines aren't failing," he said finally, his voice low. "They're being drained. There's a difference. Natural decay is slow. What's happening now is a puncture—a sustained, deliberate extraction at several points along the southern corridor. The Venin aren't raiding the borders for territory. They're harvesting the power underneath it."

I absorbed this. "How long have you known?"

"Two years."

"And my mother—"

"Your mother knows the wards are weakening. She does not know why. Or—" he paused, and something careful moved through his expression—"she does know why, and she has decided not to tell the cadets in order to avoid a collapse in morale."

"Which theory do you believe?"

He looked at me then, and his expression was old and tired and sharp all at once. "I believe your mother is the most formidable tactician I have ever

studied, and I believe she is playing a longer game than anyone in this college can see clearly." He paused. "Including me."

"Including you," I repeated softly.

He reached into his jacket and pulled out the folded parchment. He held it for a moment, looking at it, and then he held it out to me. "I found this in the restricted Scribe archive three months ago. It's a transcription from one of the earliest ley-line survey maps, pre-college. It shows a convergence point—a place where four ley lines meet directly beneath the mountain." He paused. "And a notation, in your father's handwriting, that says the convergence is what the Void-Strike dragons were originally bred to protect."

The world tilted slightly.

I took the parchment. My father's handwriting—the precise, careful script I had spent twenty years surrounded by—stared back at me in the starlight.

The Void-Strike is not a weapon, it read. *It is a lock.*

"Advast," I said aloud.

Yes, the dragon said, from somewhere deep in the roots of the mountain. His voice was quieter than it had ever been, and older, and carrying the weight of something that had been withheld for a long time. *I have been waiting for you to find that note, wildfire. We have a great deal to discuss.*

Xaden watched my face as I read. He was very still. "I think," he said, "that your father didn't just die in those stacks."

"No," I agreed, my voice steady in a way that meant I was using every Scribe's tool I possessed to keep it that way. "I don't think he did either."

Chapter Twenty

I did not sleep.

I sat at my narrow desk with the parchment spread flat, my father's handwriting illuminated by the pale, borrowed light of an Adamas reading stone I had carried from the Silent City in the bottom of my rucksack. Around the single transcription note, I built a constellation—every piece of information I had carried in my head for twenty years, exhumed and re-examined in the light of a fact that changed the foundation of every assumption they'd been built on.

The Void-Strike is not a weapon. It is a lock.

My father had known about Advast. Or known about what Advast represented. He had lived in the deepest archive of the Silent City for twenty years, and he had died in those stacks—quietly, officially, of a "cardiac event brought on by prolonged sedentary scholarship"—and I had accepted that narrative because it was the narrative I'd been given.

He found out something they didn't want him to have found, I thought.

Yes, Advast agreed. He had been awake all night too, a low, watchful presence at the edges of my consciousness, radiating the careful patience of a creature that had been waiting centuries for a rider to understand a particular truth. *Your father was the last Scribe to access the original survey records. After his death, the survey vault was reclassified and the access protocols were changed. Your mother signed the reclassification order herself.*

I stared at that for a long time.

"She knew," I said.

She knew something. Whether she understands what it means is a different question. A pause, long and deliberate. *Your mother is a woman who believes that power is something you seize and then defend. She*

would look at a ley-line convergence beneath the mountain and see a tactical asset to be controlled. She would look at me and see a relic to be weaponized or destroyed. She would not—could not—look at either and understand that some things are not meant to be wielded.

"And my father?"

Your father was a Scribe, Advast said. *He understood that some things are meant to be recorded. Preserved. Protected. He came to the archive to understand the survey maps, and he understood them, and he died because the people who needed that understanding suppressed were paying attention.* The dragon's mental voice, always so ancient and removed, dropped to something quieter. *He was a good man, wildfire. He chose to put the truth in the archive where you would eventually find it. He chose to trust that his daughter would come.*

I pressed my palm flat against the parchment, against the curve of my father's careful lettering.

Rhiannon knocked on my cell door at the first bell, before the ward-lighting in the hallways had shifted from night-violet to morning-white. She took one look at my face, at the parchment and the scattered notes and the reading stone still burning at three in the morning, and she came in without being asked and sat on the floor with her back against the wall.

"Tell me," she said.

I told her. All of it. The parchment, what Xaden had said about the ley lines, what Advast had said about my father, the reclassification order with my mother's signature, the note hidden in the survey vault for twenty years. I watched Rhiannon's expression move through shock, grief, calculation, and arrive—after a long journey—at the particular resolution of someone who has decided to stand on a side.

"Your father hid a message in the most restricted archive in the college, knowing it would only be found by a Scribe with specific access," she said

slowly. "Knowing it would only be *understood* by someone who could read his handwriting and connect it to the bond-lore and the ley-line surveys."

"Knowing it would only be found by me," I said. "Eventually."

"He was betting on your survival," Rhiannon said, and the observation landed like a gift and a wound simultaneously. She was quiet for a moment. Then: "What's in the convergence? Under the mountain? If Advast is a lock, what is the lock protecting?"

That, Advast said, with the weight of something enormous settling at the edge of my consciousness, *is what the Venin are trying to reach. And it is what the ley-line drain is designed to expose. When the wards fall, the convergence will be accessible from the surface for the first time in two thousand years.*

"What happens if they reach it?" I asked.

Then the lock breaks, the dragon said simply. *And what was sealed inside returns.*

Rhiannon and I looked at each other across the thin, cold light of the cell.

"Ridoc is going to want to update his probability calculations," she said.

"Significantly," I agreed.

I looked down at my hands—the silver and violet tracery of the bond glowing against my knuckles, the Adamas-shard warm against my chest. I thought about my mother standing on the dais with her sword at her hip and her grey eyes reading the board. I thought about Xaden sitting on the edge of the world with a piece of parchment he'd been carrying for two years, waiting for someone who could understand it. I thought about my father, dying alone in the silence of the stacks with a truth too large and too dangerous to speak aloud, trusting it to ink and paper and the eventual arrival of the daughter who couldn't stop reading.

I picked up the Stele.

"All right," I said. "Then we'd better find out what's been locked up down there before they do."

I began to write.

Chapter Twenty-One

I sat at my narrow desk, my spine a rigid line of protest against the wooden chair. Under the pale, flickering violet light of the Adamas reading stone, the silver-violet lines I'd drawn began to shimmer with a life of their own, mirroring the frantic, thrumming pulse in my own wrists. My father's handwriting—the careful, sloping script of a man who lived more in the margins of books than in the world—seemed to lift off the page, vibrating with a frequency that only I could hear.

Rhiannon and Ridoc sat in the cramped confines of my cell, their presence a grounding weight in a room that suddenly felt untethered from reality. The air was thick with the scent of ozone, damp stone, and the underlying, metallic tang of the ley-line drain.

"If the convergence is directly beneath the mountain, then the Scribe archives are just a shield," I whispered, my voice sounding amplified, as if the obsidian walls were leaning in to listen. "My father spent twenty years mapping the 'acoustics' of the Silent City. He wasn't looking at how sound traveled through the air, Rhiannon. He was mapping the density of the stone. He was looking for the thinning of the fabric."

"The Acheron Vault," Rhiannon said. She leaned forward, her dark eyes fixed on the map. She reached out, her fingers hovering just above the paper, as if she were afraid to touch the truth I'd exhumed. "But Elara, the Vault is the foundation. It's where the Mortal Instruments are housed when they aren't in Alicante. It's where the first Shadowhunters swore their blood-oaths. The wards there are older than the Nephilim themselves. They are woven from the breath of the Angel Raziel."

"Exactly," I said, a cold, sharp clarity settling into my bones, replacing the lingering ache of the Gauntlet. "The wards aren't there to keep people out of the Vault. They're there to keep the convergence *in*. The ley lines are being drained because the 'lock' needs more energy to stay closed. The Venin aren't attacking the borders to win a war; they're starving the mountain so the door will swing open."

The wildfire is learning to read the language of the deep, Advast's voice rumbled, a deep, tectonic vibration that I felt in my molars before I heard it in my head. It made the glass jar of charcoal pencils on my desk rattle with a rhythmic, skeletal sound. *The heart of the mountain is a hungry thing, little Scribe. It has been fed on the prayers and the iron of your kind for two thousand years. Now, it wants the marrow.*

"Ridoc, what's the probability?" Rhiannon asked, her voice tight with a resolution I didn't yet share.

Ridoc, who had been uncharacteristically silent, looked up from his own scrap of parchment. His blue eyes were wide, the pupils blown out until they nearly eclipsed the clear iris. He looked like a man who had stared into the sun and was now trying to describe the dark.

"On a scale of one to 'being eaten by a dragon,' we are currently at 'being erased from the index of history,'" he said, his voice cracking. "If we break into the Acheron Vault and the General finds out, she won't just execute us. She'll use the *Binding of the Traitor* on our entire squad. We'll be ghosts before we're even corpses. Our names will be scraped from the archives."

"I'm already a ghost, Ridoc," I said, looking down at my hands. The silver and violet tracery of the bond was glowing through the skin, a map of my new, terrifying geography. "I've been a medical curiosity my whole life. A 'defect' in a world of perfected soldiers. A girl made of lace and prayer. For the first time, I have the key to the library, and I'm not leaving until I've read the last page. Even if the book burns my hands to ash."

The preparation took hours. We couldn't use standard-issue Fourth Wing gear; the Peacekeepers would recognize the magical signature of our harnesses from a mile away. Instead, we scavenged.

Rhiannon found a coil of reinforced dragon-hide rope in the training pits, the material smelling of sweat and old oil. Ridoc, using his gift for making people believe he was harmless, swiped a handful of "Quiet-Step" runes from a Second-Year who owed him a favor for a gambling debt.

And I... I prepared the Stele.

I didn't draw the runes from the Scribe manuals—those were too predictable, too grounded in the "logic" my mother understood. I drew from the memory Advast had shared—the vision of the birth of the mountains, of fire cooling into obsidian. I etched a Void-Veil onto the inside of our collars, a mark that didn't just hide us from sight, but dampened the very heat of our bodies.

It was an agonizing, slow-motion process. Every time the silver tip of the Stele touched my skin, the void-energy was raw and cold—a biting frost that made my fingers go numb. I had to stop every ten minutes to shake the sensation back into my hands, my breath hitching as the energy siphoned directly from my marrow.

"We move at the seventh bell," I commanded, the authority of the bond ringing in my voice, a frequency I didn't quite recognize as my own. "Rhiannon, you're the anchor. Ridoc, you watch the ley-line fluctuations on the reading stone. If the light turns red, the stones are humming, and we run. We don't wait for a signal. We just disappear."

The walk to the ventilation shafts was a masterclass in high-tension terror. The Fourth Wing barracks were silent, but the silence didn't feel like sleep; it felt like a predator holding its breath. Every shadow seemed to stretch toward us as we passed, every flicker of a witch-light torch felt like an eyelid twitching.

My body was a constant, nagging reminder of my vulnerability. My left hip clicked with every third step—a sharp, wet sound that felt like a gunshot in the corridor's silence. I had to lean on the walls more than I liked, the cold stone biting through my flight leathers.

We reached the Seam—the jagged, narrow crack in the obsidian wall I’d found during my mapping sessions—and slipped through. The space was so tight it squeezed the air from my lungs, the rough stone scraping against my ribs like a physical judgment.

The transition from the barracks to the mountain’s interior was like stepping into a freezer. The air was damp and smelled of ancient mineral rot and the heavy, sulfurous musk of the lower peaks. We climbed down the rusted iron rungs of the ventilation shaft, my hands slipping on the cold metal.

"Do you feel that?" Ridoc whispered, his voice hitching as he followed me down.

"The vibration?" Rhiannon asked, her boots scraping against the rungs below me.

"No," I said, pausing as my violet eyes scanned the absolute dark. "The hunger. The mountain isn't just stone anymore. It’s an appetite."

We reached the basement level of the Silent City—the place where the archives ended and the raw mountain began. This was my father’s territory. The walls were lined with thousands of scrolls, their leather cases rotting in the damp, their secrets turning to dust.

We reached the heavy, iron-bound door of the Acheron Vault. It was etched with the seal of the Angel Raziel, but the gold leaf was peeling, revealing a dark, pulsing obsidian beneath that looked like bruised flesh.

"The wards are failing here," I noted, touching the stone. The violet light of my bond flared, and for a second, the wall went transparent. I didn't see a room filled with gold or the Mortal Cup. I saw a Chamber of Shadows, and in the center, a pedestal holding a stone that looked like a trapped, dying nebula.

"Wait," a voice came from the darkness behind us.

The shadows didn't just shift; they detached. Xaden Herondale stepped out of the gloom, his face a mask of cold, clinical fury. He wasn't alone. Sgaeyl was perched on a jagged ledge above, her golden eyes glowing like twin suns, her claws digging deep furrows into the granite.

"I told you to wait, Elara," Xaden said, his voice a low, dangerous rumble that echoed off the vaulted ceiling. "You have no idea what you're about to wake up. This isn't a library. It’s an execution chamber."

"My father died for this, Xaden," I snapped, the spite rising from my gut to meet his anger. "He died alone in these stacks because he was the only one brave enough to look at the truth. I'm not waiting another second for your permission to finish his work."

I slammed the Stele against the Vault door. I didn't use a standard-issue Unlock rune. I channeled Advast’s raw, unfiltered power directly into the angelic seal.

The reaction was violent. The iron didn't just open; it shrieked. The angelic seal shattered into a thousand gold fragments that hissed as they hit the floor. The door swung wide on rusted hinges, revealing a descent into a dark so absolute it seemed to swallow the light of our reading stones whole.

And there, standing at the edge of the abyss, was a figure we all recognized.

It was a man in the charcoal-black reinforced leathers of a Skystriker. His back was to us, his posture as familiar as my own reflection. But when he turned, the air in my lungs turned to ice, my heart stopping in its tracks.

It was Brennan Sorrengail.

My brother. The one the mountain had "swallowed" six years ago. The one my mother had mourned with a cold, dry-eyed silence that had haunted our house for years.

His eyes weren't the warm, honey-brown I remembered. They were a flat, soulless silver, reflecting a light that didn't exist. And in his hand, he held a dagger made of the same obsidian as the mountain—a blade that was currently dripping with a thick, violet liquid that looked like liquid starlight.

"Hello, Elara," he said, his voice a hollow, resonant echo of the brother I had loved. "You're just in time. The mountain is finally ready to speak, and it has so much to say about our mother."

Chapter Twenty-Two

The air in the Acheron Vault turned cold. It was a freezing, airless pressure that felt like being submerged in the depths of a sunless sea. I couldn't breathe. My lungs felt like they had been lined with lead, my heart stuttering against my ribs in a rhythm that was no longer my own.

"Brennan?"

The name was a ghost in my throat, a fragile thing that shattered the moment it hit the heavy, ozone-thick air.

My brother didn't move. He stood at the edge of the abyss, the silver light in his eyes reflecting the dying pulse of the ley lines below. He looked older, his face etched with lines that weren't there when I was fourteen, but the way he held his shoulders—the slight tilt of his head as he assessed a room—was a signature I would know in the dark of the Void.

"You shouldn't have come here, Elara," Brennan said. His voice was a tectonic shift, a low vibration that seemed to originate from the stone itself. "This place is a wound. And wounds don't like to be poked."

The blood-traitor speaks with the tongue of the mountain, Advast rumbled in my mind. The dragon’s consciousness was pressing against the back of my skull, a furious, protective weight. *His soul smells of petrified wood and salt. He is no longer a rider. He is a part of the lock.*

Xaden stepped forward, his shadows lashing out in jagged, frantic bursts that mirrored the chaos in my own chest. Sgaeyl let out a low, vibrating hiss from the ledge above, her golden eyes fixed on the obsidian dagger in Brennan’s hand.

"Six years," Xaden said, his voice dropping to that lethal, quiet register. "We watched the mountain collapse on your wing. We watched the General burn the casualty manifests. We thought you were ash, Sorrengail."

"I was," Brennan said, finally stepping away from the ledge. He moved with a fluid, haunting grace that made my skin crawl. "But the mountain doesn't just kill. It preserves. It harvests."

He looked at me then, and for a split second, the silver in his eyes flickered, revealing a glimpse of the brother who used to sneak me honey-cakes from the mess hall. The recognition was a physical blow, a violent extraction of the grief I'd spent six years carefully burying.

The room began to spin. The violet light of my bond flared, turning the shadows into a strobe-light nightmare. I felt the Adamas-shard against my heart begin to hum—not with power, but with a memory. A memory that wasn't mine. It was the mountain's. It was the shard's.

It was the Great Uprising.

The sky over the Ametrine Peaks was a bruised purple, choked with the smoke of burning wings and the sulfurous stench of dragon fire. It was the final day of the Great Uprising, and the world was ending in a symphony of screams.

I saw it through the eyes of a younger Brennan—twenty-two years old, his charcoal Skystriker leathers soaked in blood that wasn't his own. He was perched on the back of his dragon, a magnificent Orange Daggertail named Marit, whose wings were shredded into ribbons of burnt leather.

"Hold the ridge!" Brennan shouted, his voice cracking through the roar of the wind.

Below him, the valley was a slaughterhouse. The "Traitor's Children"—the fathers of Xaden, Imogen, and the others—were being systematically dismantled by the General's elite guard. The air was thick with Binding Runes, silver chains of light that fell from the sky like rain, locking dragons mid-flight and sending them plummeting into the jagged obsidian below.

Our mother, Lilith Sorrengail, was on the dais overlooking the valley. She didn't look like a mother. She looked like a statue of the Angel Raziel made

of ice and spite. She raised her sword, and the sky itself seemed to fracture.

"They aren't just rebels, Brennan!" a voice screamed in his ear.

It was Fen Riorson—Xaden's father. He was hovering nearby on Sgaeyl's previous rider's dragon, his face a mask of desperation. "They're trying to stop the drain! The General is siphoning the ley lines to fuel the wards in Alicante! She's killing the mountain to save the city!"

Brennan looked at his mother, then at the valley. He saw the way the earth was cracking, the way the obsidian was turning a sickly, translucent grey as the energy was ripped from its marrow.

"Marit, dive!" Brennan commanded.

He didn't dive at the rebels. He dived at the Primary Anchor Stone—the massive Adamas pillar that sat at the heart of the valley, the one that held the wards of the entire province together.

If he could shatter the anchor, the siphoning would stop. The mountain would be saved. But the recoil would kill everyone within five miles.

"Brennan, no!" Lilith's voice boomed across the sky, amplified by her own dragon's roar.

He didn't listen. He slammed his Stele into the heart of the Adamas pillar, channeling every ounce of his rider-bond into a single, suicidal strike.

The explosion was a white-out.

I felt the heat through the memory—a searing, blinding fire that turned the world into ash. I felt the moment Marit's heart stopped, the moment the bond snapped like a frozen wire. Brennan fell. Not into the valley, but into the fissure that the explosion had ripped into the very foundation of the mountain.

He didn't hit the bottom. He hit the Void.

The mountain didn't let him die. The ley lines, sensing a vessel of pure, desperate will, reached out with tendrils of violet light. They wrapped around his broken limbs, stitching his bone with obsidian and filling his lungs with the sulfurous breath of the deep.

He woke up in the dark. In this Vault.

He was surrounded by the Silent Brothers, their mouths sewn shut, their eyes hollowed out. They didn't kill him. They knelt.

"The vessel is ready," they whispered into his mind. "The lock has a new guardian."

For six years, Brennan had lived in the silence. He had watched through the stone as our mother told the world he was a hero. He had watched as she branded the children of his friends as traitors. He had watched as the mountain began to starve, fed only on the siphoned energy of the very people he had tried to save.

The memory snapped back into the present with the violence of a whip-crack.

I fell to my knees, my hands clawing at the cold obsidian floor. The Adamas-shard was searingly hot against my chest, the violet light leaking through the fabric of my tunic like a bleeding wound.

"You didn't die," I wheezed, looking up at the man who was once my brother. "You were... you were the first one they siphoned."

Brennan stepped closer, the obsidian dagger humming in his hand. "Our mother is a strategist, Elara. She knows that a martyr is more useful than a son. She kept me here to stabilize the leak. To be the human anchor for the drain."

He pointed the blade at Xaden. "And now, she’s sent the daughter of the executioner and the son of the traitor to finish the job. She wants the lock open, Xaden. She thinks she can control what’s inside."

"We aren't here for her, Brennan," Xaden said, his shadows pooling around my knees in a protective circle. "We're here to stop the drain. We're here to save the mountain."

"The mountain is already dead," Brennan said, a single silver tear tracking down his cheek. "And the thing beneath it... it’s been waiting two thousand years for a Sorrengail to give it a key."

He looked at me, his gaze dropping to my violet eyes. "You aren't just a rider, Elara. You’re the siphoner. You’re the one who’s going to let the Void out."

Suddenly, the floor beneath us groaned. A massive crack ripped through the center of the Vault, and from the abyss below, a sound emerged that was louder than any dragon’s roar.

It was the sound of a door opening.

Chapter Twenty-Three

The sound that emerged from the abyss was a roar that implies lungs, effort, and the transience of air. This was a frequency—a low, bone-pulverizing vibration that felt like the mountain itself was being ground between the teeth of a cosmic millstone.

The floor of the Acheron Vault disintegrated. The raw obsidian, which had stood for two millennia as the foundation of Basgiath, pulverized into a fine, black dust that rose into the air like a localized storm.

"Get back!" Xaden's voice was a frantic rasp, nearly lost in the tectonic screaming of the stone.

His shadows lashed out, but they weren't attacking. They were a web, a frantic network of dark ribbons that wrapped around my waist and Rhiannon's shoulders, dragging us toward the relative safety of the vaulted archway. My hips clicked in a sickening, wet staccato as I was hauled across the uneven stone, the violet-bond with Advast flaring until my vision was nothing but a strobe-light nightmare of purple and black.

It is awake, Advast rumbled, his voice no longer a whisper but a physical blow to my consciousness. *The Great Anchor. The Viking of the Void. Hide your soul, wildfire. If he sees the light in you, he will swallow the sun.*

From the depths of the black fissure, a claw emerged.

It was the size of a standard-issue dragon's wing, made of a material that looked like petrified wood and ancient, rusted iron. It didn't have the elegant scales of the Daggertails or the shimmering iridescence of the Swift-Wings. It was cragged, a jagged landscape of armor that looked like it had been forged in the cooling crust of the earth.

Then, the head rose.

It was a nightmare of Old Earth biology. It was broader than the gates of Alicante, a massive, blunt-snouted skull that lacked eyes in the traditional sense. In their place were two glowing, horizontal slits of white-hot plasma

that pulsed with the rhythm of the ley-line drain. It didn't have the lithe, serpentine neck of the Nephilim breeds; its neck was a thick, corded pillar of muscle that supported a head meant for one thing: annihilation.

The creature hauled itself onto the basement level, the stone groaning and shattering under its weight. It was a quadruped, standing on four massive, tree-trunk limbs that ended in claws capable of raking through solid basalt like soft clay.

But it was the wings that stole the air from the room.

They weren't for flight—not in this cramped, subterranean space. They were ragged, ancient sails of leathery skin that looked like they had been torn by the teeth of gods. Even half-folded, they spanned the width of the Vault, the tips of the membranes brushing the high, vaulted ceilings and showering us with centuries of dust and debris. This was a Viking Tail, a breed mentioned only in the most redacted Scribe transcripts as the "World-Breakers" that existed before the Angel Raziel drew the first wards.

"Brennan!" I screamed, the sound lost in the chaos.

My brother stood ten feet from the beast’s snout, his silver eyes wide and reflecting the white-hot plasma of the creature’s gaze. He looked like a doll in front of a mountain.

"It’s not an animal, Elara!" Brennan shouted back, his voice echoing with the resonance of the Silent Brothers. "It’s a God! It’s the original battery of the ley lines! Mother didn't just drain the mountain—she drained *him*! And now he’s come to reclaim the debt!"

The Viking-god tilted its head, the movement slow and deliberate, like a glacier shifting. The white-hot slits of its eyes settled on me—on the Adamas-shard glowing through my tunic.

It opened its mouth.

There was no intake of breath. There was only a high-pitched, electronic whine that vibrated through my teeth and made my nose begin to bleed.

The back of the creature’s throat glowed with a neon-violet laser that smelled of ionized air and ozone.

"ELARA, MOVE!"

Xaden tackled me, the force of his weight sending us tumbling into the shadows of a fallen pillar just as the creature unleashed its breath.

It wasn't a flame. It was a thermal lance. A solid beam of fire and laser-light that cut through the obsidian Vault door like it was parchment. The stone didn't just melt; it sublimated, turning instantly into a toxic, glowing gas. The beam tracked across the room, vaporizing the ancient scrolls, the iron racks, and the very air itself.

The heat was unbearable. My flight leathers began to smoke, the smell of singed hair filling my lungs. I looked over the edge of the pillar and saw the path of the beam—a perfectly smooth, glowing trench cut three feet deep into the solid mountain floor.

He smells the shard, Advast hissed, his anger turning into a cold, clinical terror. *He smells the piece of his own heart that the Shadowhunters stole to build their city. You are carrying a beacon, wildfire. Give him the shard, or he will burn the mountain until there is nothing left but ash.*

"I can't give it to him!" I gasped, clutching the shard as it burned through my skin. "If I let go of the shard, the bond with you will snap! My nervous system can't handle the raw void without the converter!"

"Then we fight," Xaden said, his face inches from mine. His eyes were gold-flecked onyx, burning with a desperation I had never seen. He reached into his belt and pulled out his Stele, the silver tool glowing a deep, ink-black. "Rhiannon! Ridoc! Get Brennan out of the line of fire! Elara and I are going to ground this thing."

"Ground it?" Ridoc squeaked from behind a pile of rubble. "How do you ground a god with laser-breath? Do we have a giant lightning rod I didn't know about?"

"The ley lines!" I shouted, the Scribe's logic finally piercing through the terror. "Xaden, the creature is siphoning the drain! If we can reverse the polarity of the Acheron Anchor, we can turn the mountain into a Grounded Cage. We can force the energy back *into* him!"

"And what happens to the person holding the anchor?" Xaden asked, his grip on my arm tightening.

I looked at Brennan, who was currently dodging a second blast of the laser-fire, his Skystriker reflexes the only thing keeping him from being vaporized.

"The same thing that happened to my father," I said, a hollow, cold smile touching my lips. "We record the truth. And then we survive."

I pushed myself up, my hips screaming in agony, my violet eyes locked on the Viking-god as it reared up on its hind legs, its ragged wings unfurling to their full, village-spanning width, ready to bring the ceiling down on our heads.

"Xaden," I whispered. "If we die... make sure my mother knows I was the one who broke her favorite toy."

"We aren't dying today, Sorrengail," Xaden promised, his shadows rising up to form a towering, dark colossus behind him. "I haven't finished making your life difficult yet."

I raised my Stele, the silver tip humming with the raw, unfiltered frequency of the Void. I didn't draw a rune. I drew a Map.

Chapter Twenty-Four

The mountain began to unmake itself.

As the Viking-god—the First Hunger—reared back, the sound that tore from its throat was a physical force. It wasn't the high-pitched shriek of a Daggertail or the booming roar of a Tairn. It was a primal, bone-stripping resonance that echoed the original Godzilla of old Earth legends. It started as a low, guttural thrum that vibrated the fluid in my inner ears and built into a world-ending crescendo that shattered every pane of glass in the Silent City above us.

SKREEE-ONGK!

The roar carried the weight of two thousand years of buried spite. It was the sound of tectonic plates grinding together, of the earth's crust screaming as it was forced apart. The shockwave hit me like a physical wall, throwing me back against the jagged obsidian remains of the Vault door. My vision went white, my lungs seizing as the very oxygen was vibrated out of the air.

"The ceiling!" Rhiannon's scream was a faint needle of sound in the cacophony.

High above, the massive granite pillars that supported the weight of the Basgiath war college began to spiderweb. Dust—centuries of it—poured down in thick, choking curtains, followed by the first literal tons of stone. The Viking-god didn't care. It slammed its four tree-trunk limbs back into the floor, and the impact sent a ripple through the ground that tossed Xaden and me like autumn leaves.

"It's not staying in the Vault," Brennan shouted, his voice barely audible over the grinding of the mountain. He was clinging to a bronze sconce, his silver eyes fixed on the beast. "It's not interested in us, Elara! It's looking for the sky!"

The creature's ragged, village-spanning wings unfurled, the leathery membranes snapping like the sails of a ghost ship caught in a hurricane. With a massive, coordinated thrust of its powerful legs, the god-beast launched itself upward. It didn't look for an exit; it created one.

It drove its massive, armored skull directly into the ceiling of the Vault. The sound was like a thousand cannons firing at once. The floor of the First-Year barracks, the Scribe archives, and the Main Rotunda—levels of history and stone—were punched through as if they were made of wet paper.

"We have to follow it!" I gasped, clutching the Adamas-shard. The violet light was pulsing in sync with the beast's heartbeat now. "If it reaches the surface, the wards will vanish. The Venin won't even need to attack; the mountain will simply fall."

Xaden didn't hesitate. He grabbed me around the waist, his shadows surging forward to wrap around Rhiannon and Ridoc. "Sgaeyl!" he roared into the chaos.

The Blue Daggertail was already diving through the massive, gaping hole the Viking-god had left in its wake. We scrambled onto her back, the dragon's muscles bunching with a tension I'd never felt. Sgaeyl wasn't just angry; she was terrified. She knew she was in the presence of an apex predator that predated her entire species.

We ascended through the wreckage of our lives. We flew past the Scribe library, where centuries of knowledge were being swallowed by the yawning abyss. I saw Scribes I recognized screaming as they fell into the dark, their scrolls fluttering like dying birds. We flew past the infirmary, where the wounded were being buried under the collapse of the stone.

Then, we broke the surface.

The top of Basgiath Mountain didn't exist anymore. The peak had been blown outward, leaving a jagged, smoking crater. The Viking-god stood on the rim of the volcano it had just created, its four legs anchored into the burning rock.

The storm that had been brewing all night finally broke, but it wasn't rain that fell. It was ash.

The creature threw its head back toward the bruised, purple sky and unleashed that primal roar once more. The sound rolled across the valleys of Idris, causing every dragon in the paddocks to fall to their knees in instinctive submission.

Then, it did the impossible.

It beat its ragged, torn wings—wings that looked too decayed to catch a breeze—and the air itself seemed to solidify beneath them. With a single, massive stroke that sent a localized hurricane through the Fourth Wing encampment, the Viking-god took flight.

It didn't fly with the grace of a bird; it flew with the terrifying momentum of a falling moon.

"Look at the tail," Ridoc whispered, his voice trembling as he pointed.

The creature’s tail wasn't a weapon of meat and bone. It was a massive, spiked lattice of pure Adamas, glowing with the neon-violet laser energy it had siphoned from the mountain. As it banked over the valley, the tail swung, and a beam of violet light sliced through the distant watchtowers of the Skystrikers, turning the stone into glowing slag in seconds.

It was wreaking havoc on a scale I couldn't comprehend. The fortress walls were crumbling. The legendary wards of Basgiath were flickering like a dying candle.

"It’s going for the Great Bridge," Xaden said, his eyes narrowed against the wind. "If it takes out the bridge, the supply lines to the front are gone. The kingdom falls by morning."

He is seeking the source of the false light, Advast’s voice was a cold, sharp edge in my mind. The Black Void-Strike dragon was circling above us, his iridescent scales shimmering against the ash-choked sky. *He will burn everything that smells of the thieves who stole his marrow. Including you, wildfire.*

"Then we have to give him a new target," I said, reaching for my Stele.

My body felt like it was being held together by nothing but spite and the violet-bond. My ribs were cracked, my joints were screaming, and the Adamas-shard was melting the skin of my chest. But as I looked at the Viking-god—this ancient, beautiful, terrible engine of destruction—I didn't feel fear.

I felt a resonance.

"Xaden, get me closer," I commanded. "I need to touch the ley lines in his tail. I need to complete the circuit."

"Elara, if you touch that energy, your nervous system will fry," Xaden warned, but he was already banking Sgaeyl toward the monster’s massive, trailing wake.

"I’m a Scribe," I whispered, the violet light in my eyes eclipsing the sun. "I was born to handle the ink. And right now, the world is the paper."

I stood up on Sgaeyl’s back, my hair whipping in the gale, my Stele glowing with a power that felt like it could rewrite the stars. The Viking-god sensed us. It turned its massive, armored head, the white-hot plasma slits of its eyes locking onto me.

It opened its mouth to fire.

Chapter Twenty-Five

The Viking-god didn't fire; it pivoted.

With a speed that defied its tectonic mass, the creature spun its weight on its massive forelimbs. The movement was a blur of ragged wings and shifting obsidian. Before Xaden could bank Sgaeyl away, the creature's tail—a spiked, Adamas-encrusted mountain of bone and violet laser energy—swiped through the air with the force of a falling skyscraper.

The impact was absolute. it canceled our momentum.

Sgaeyl let out a pained, guttural shriek as the tail slammed into her side, sending us spiraling out of the sky. The world became a kaleidoscope of ash, purple lightning, and the terrifying roar of the wind. We hit the ground—the scorched, ruined earth of the Fourth Wing assembly grounds—with a force that should have shattered every bone in my body.

I tumbled across the dirt, my vision fracturing into a thousand points of violet light. My left shoulder dislocated with a sickening *pop*, and for a moment, the world went silent, replaced by the high-pitched ring of a concussion.

I pushed myself up on one trembling arm, coughing out a mouthful of ash. Around me, the devastation was total. The assembly grounds, the barracks, the legendary watchtowers—everything in a three-hundred-meter radius had been leveled by the beast's landing. It hadn't just landed; it had cratered, the shockwave turning solid stone into gravel.

The Viking-god stood in the center of the ruins, its four legs anchored deep into the bleeding ley lines of the mountain. It threw its armored head back, the white-hot plasma slits of its eyes burning with a terrifying, new intelligence.

Then, it let out the Alpha Roar.

it was a command. It was a frequency that bypassed the ears and spoke directly to the ancient, reptilian marrow of every dragon in Idris. It was the roar of the First King reclaiming his throne.

Across the horizon, the sky began to change.

Hundreds—thousands—of dragons, from the smallest Swift-Wings to the massive Tairn himself, broke formation. They didn't attack. They came to him. They circled the crater in a massive, swirling vortex of wings, their individual wills extinguished by the sheer gravity of the Alpha’s presence.

"What is it doing?" Rhiannon wheezed, crawling toward me, her face masked in blood.

"It’s not just calling them," I whispered, my violet eyes tracking the energy as it began to pool in the creature’s throat. "It’s using them as a lens."

The Viking-god unleashed its breath, but it didn't aim at the ground. It fired a solid, neon-violet beam of fire and laser-light directly into the bruised, purple clouds above. The beam didn't stop; it pierced the atmosphere, the intensity of the light turning the night into a blinding, artificial noon.

The sky began to rip.

A jagged, iridescent portal tore open at the zenith of the beam—a doorway to the Void itself. Raw, unfiltered energy poured through the rift like a waterfall of starlight, cascading down the pillar of the laser and into the creature’s open maw.

The evolution was instantaneous and horrific.

The creature’s ragged, village-spanning wings metamorphosed. The torn membranes filled in with shimmering, translucent scales that pulsed with a deep, cosmic violet. The cragged, wooden armor of its hide cracked open, revealing new, obsidian-black plates that glowed with the internal heat of a star.

It grew.

Ten feet. Fifty feet. A hundred. The Viking-god expanded until its shadow covered the entire valley of Basgiath. The wounds from my father’s notes, the scars from Brennan’s rebellion—everything vanished, replaced by a perfected, divine form of destruction.

The creature lowered its head, its new eyes—four burning orbs of violet sun—locking onto the ruins of the college. It wasn't a "structural disaster" anymore. It was the end of the world.

And I was the only one with the key to stop it.

Chapter Twenty-Six

The newly evolved Alpha radiated. The air around its massive, obsidian-plated form began to distort, a shimmering heat haze that smelled of burnt ozone and the beginning of time. Every dragon circling above—thousands of them—stopped their frantic wingbeats and hovered in a dead, eerie silence, their heads bowed toward the crater as if caught in a trance of total subservience.

The Alpha let out a sound that was no longer a roar. It was a summons.

The frequency didn’t travel through the air; it traveled through the tectonic plates. I felt it through the soles of my boots, a deep, rhythmic thrumming that bypassed my skin and vibrated the very calcium in my bones. It was a call and a response, a key turning in a lock on the exact opposite side of the planet.

"It's calling something," Xaden whispered, pulling me to my feet. His shadows were frantic now, lashing out at the air as if trying to catch a ghost. "Elara, the ley lines... they aren't just siphoning. They’re acting as a bridge. A global circuit."

The binary is complete, Advast’s voice was a low, mournful tolling in my mind. The Black Void-Strike dragon was landed a few yards away, his head lowered, his iridescent scales trembling. *The Earth does not have one heart, wildfire. It has two. And the Alpha has just kicked the other one awake.*

On the other side of the world—beneath the crushing depths of the midnight-blue sea near the Antarctic shelf—the response came.

The ground beneath Basgiath suddenly shifted, not in a tremor, but in a long, slow tilt. Far beyond the horizon, across the vast expanse of the ocean, a second roar erupted. Even from thousands of miles away, the sound was a physical presence, a deep, oceanic boom that sent a tsunami of magical pressure rolling across Idris.

It was the Second God.

If the Viking-god of Basgiath was fire and laser-light, this new presence was Void and Storm.

As it breached the surface of the southern ocean, the reports from the Scribe-links began to scream into my head—fragmented, terrified thoughts from observers across the globe. It was massive, a quadrupedal leviathan of shifting silver and translucent ice-scales. As it rose, it didn't just evolve; it ascended. The raw energy of the portal the Alpha had ripped open in Idris was being mirrored on the other side of the globe, the two gods acting as the poles of a massive, planet-wide battery.

The Second God let out its own Alpha Roar.

The two sounds met at the equator, a collision of frequencies that caused the very clouds to crystallize and fall as jagged shards of ice. The sky over Basgiath turned a bruised, electric blue.

Then, the Second God took flight.

It didn't beat wings; it manipulated the very gravity of the earth. It moved like a silver blur, a streak of impossible light that tore through the atmosphere at supersonic speeds. It wasn't just flying; it was a projectile aimed directly at our location.

"How long?" I shouted over the screaming wind, clutching my Stele.

"At that speed?" Ridoc asked, his eyes glued to a navigational compass that was spinning in useless circles. "Ten minutes. Maybe less. When they meet... Elara, when two gods of that magnitude occupy the same ley-line convergence, the mountain won't just fall. It will implode."

The Alpha in the crater sensed its brother’s approach. It reared up on its hind legs, its village-spanning wings snapping open with a sound like a thunderclap. The laser energy in its tail began to strobe, the violet light becoming so intense it turned the falling ash into glowing embers.

It was preparing for a union. Or a war.

"We have ten minutes to break the circuit," I said, my voice hardening. I looked at the Alpha—at the massive, glowing lattice of Adamas in its tail. "Brennan! You said you were the anchor! If you can channel your corrupted energy into the Alpha's tail, I can use the Stele to 'short' the portal!"

Brennan looked at me, his silver eyes flashing with a mix of pride and pure, unadulterated terror. "The recoil will kill us both, Elara. You're talking about acting as a fuse for the planet's core."

"I'm a Scribe," I said, stepping toward the edge of the crater. The wind from the Alpha's wings threatened to toss me back, but the violet-bond held me steady. "I've spent my life recording the end of the world. It's about time I had a say in how the last chapter is written."

Xaden moved to stand beside me, his hand finding mine. His shadows rose up, merging with the violet light of my bond to create a shimmering, dark-matter shield.

"Then we write it together," he said.

High above, the silver streak of the Second God broke the sound barrier over the Idris border, a sonic boom that leveled the remaining trees in the valley.

The two Alphas were about to meet. And the world was holding its breath.

Chapter Twenty-Seven

The sky over Basgiath was no longer a sky.

The Second God, the Female, arrived not as a storm made flesh. Her silver-ice scales shimmered with a cold, lunar brilliance that stood in stark contrast to the Male's solar, violet heat. As she slowed her supersonic descent, the air around her crystallized, sending a hail of jagged ice shards down upon the ruins of the college.

She landed on the northern rim of the crater, her movements fluid and predatory, her four limbs gripping the molten rock with effortless grace.

The Male, the Viking-Void who had leveled our world—turned to face her.

For a heartbeat, the destruction stopped. The two gods stood mere hundreds of feet apart, their massive heads lowered, their nostrils flaring with the scent of ozone and ancient blood. The air between them began to hum, a physical tension so thick that my Stele vibrated in my hand like a trapped hornet.

Then, they spoke. In Power.

They threw their heads back in a synchronized movement that felt choreographed by the stars themselves. The Male's violet-laser fire and the Female's silver-storm breath collided in the air above the crater, weaving together into a towering pillar of white-hot plasma.

And then, they roared.

It was a dual-frequency scream—the baritone grind of the earth's crust meeting the soprano shriek of a dying sun. The sound didn't just shatter stone; it shattered the concept of distance. Every dragon in the sky plummeted another hundred feet, their wings failing as the atmosphere itself became too dense with magic to fly.

But it wasn't an attack. It was a Litany.

The combined roar of the King and Queen traveled downward, piercing through the mantle, through the outer layers of the planet, and striking the very heart of the world.

"They're calling him," Brennan whispered, his face pale as ash. He was staring at the horizon, his silver eyes tracking a seismic wave that was currently ripping across the globe. "The Alphas were just the heralds. They've just rung the bell for the First-Born."

Grayness, Advast's voice was a ragged, terrified sob in my mind. The dragon curled into a ball on the ground, his wings covering his head. *The First of the Viking-Void Rush Tails. The one who ate the first sun. He is coming, wildfire. And he is hungry for the core.*

Deep in the Earth's core, at the exact center of the world's equator, something that had been dormant for five million years opened its eyes.

The report came through the Scribe-link like a death knell. The entire equatorial belt—from the jungles to the oceans—was rising. A mountain range the size of a continent was erupting from the sea, but it wasn't made of rock. It was made of Grey-Void Scales.

Grayness had awakened.

He was the progenitor, the Rush Tail, built for a speed and scale that made the two Alphas look like hatchlings. As he breached the crust at the equator, the earth's rotation itself stuttered for a fraction of a second. He was a colossus of ashen grey and matte-black obsidian, his wingspan so vast that as he took flight, he eclipsed the moon for half the planet.

He didn't fly toward us; he rushed.

Every beat of his wings created a vacuum that sucked the air out of the surrounding atmosphere. He was a shadow moving at the speed of a comet, trailing a wake of grey-void energy that turned everything it touched into a colorless, frozen dust.

"We have to close the portal *now*!" I screamed at Xaden, grabbing his tunic. "If Grayness reaches this convergence, he won't just evolve. He'll use the Alphas as fuel to restart the Earth's core in his own image! We'll all be erased!"

Xaden looked at the two Alphas—the Male and Female—who were now circling each other in a dance of cosmic proportions, their tails glowing with the energy of the rift.

"The Short-Circuit," Xaden said, his voice hard. He looked at Brennan. "Sorrengail, if you're going to be a hero, now is the damn time. Grab the Male's resonance. Elara, take the Female. I'll hold the shadows between you so the feedback doesn't vaporize your hearts."

"And the Grayness?" Rhiannon asked, pointing to the south, where a wall of grey clouds was moving toward us at impossible speeds.

"If we succeed," I said, raising my Stele, "he won't have a home to come back to."

I stepped toward the Female Alpha, the silver goddess of the storm. Her white-plasma eyes fixed on me, and for the first time, I didn't feel like a Scribe. I felt like a Conduit.

The Grayness was coming. The King and Queen were waiting. And the mountain was ready to scream.

The arrival of the First-Born did not happen with a sudden, suffocating silence.

As Grayness descended from the clouds, the air itself seemed to turn to lead. He did not land so much as he reclaimed the earth. When his massive, matte-grey talons touched the scorched soil of Basgiath, the planet's rotation felt like it groaned under his impossible mass. He was a cathedral of ashen scales and void-matter, his presence so dense that light

seemed to bend toward him, creating a gravitational lens that distorted the ruins of the college.

He stood between the Male and Female Alphas, a titan among kings.

"They aren't fighting," I whispered, the Stele trembling so violently in my hand that it drew blood from my palm. "They're... waiting."

The Trinity is complete, Advast's voice was a hollow, echoing chime. *The Fire, the Storm, and the Void. They are the three keys to the lock of the system.*

Then, the horror began.

Grayness did not roar. He reached out with his village-spanning wings and wrapped them around the Male and Female Alphas. Instead of a struggle, there was a dissolution. The Male's violet-laser heat and the Female's silver-storm ice began to bleed into the ashen-grey hide of the Progenitor.

It was a Merging.

The three gods began to collapse into a single point of infinite density. The screaming of the wind was replaced by a high-pitched, harmonic whine that shattered the remaining stone of the mountain into dust. The violet, silver, and grey energies swirled into a vortex, weaving together bones, wings, and plasma into a singular, perfected entity.

When the light died down, only one stood.

It was the World-Eater. It stood on six massive limbs, its hide a shifting mosaic of iridescent obsidian that moved like liquid. It had three heads that moved in terrifying synchronicity, and its wings didn't just span villages—they cast a shadow that eclipsed the entire province of Navarre.

The Merged God threw all three heads back toward the stars and unleashed the Final Alpha Roar.

This wasn't a call to the dragons of Earth. It was a signal to the Void beyond the atmosphere. The sound was so powerful it punched a hole

through the ionosphere, a physical shockwave that rippled out into the vacuum of space.

"What could possibly be left to call?" Ridoc choked out, shielding his eyes from the celestial glow.

The answer came from the night sky.

Far beyond the moon, past the rings of Saturn, a speck of deep, sapphire-blue light began to grow. It moved with a velocity that defied every law of Scribe physics. It was the Neptune God, a creature of liquid diamond and frozen methane, a Viking-Void breed that had survived in the crushing pressures of the gas giant for eons.

It was a streak of cold, blue fire, falling toward Earth like a vengeful star.

"It's not just a battle anymore," Xaden said, his shadows spreading out to cover us as the temperature began to drop to absolute zero. "It's a Harvest. They're calling the planetary guardians home."

I looked at the Merged God, its three heads now glowing with a sapphire light that mirrored the approaching star. The ground beneath us began to liquefy as the Neptune God entered the atmosphere, a sonic boom of such magnitude that the very bedrock of Idris cracked open.

"We aren't fighting a dragon," I said, my violet eyes locking onto the shifting obsidian of the God's heart. "We're fighting the Universe."

I raised my Stele, the tip now glowing with a white-hot frequency. "Xaden, Brennan... if we don't break that Merged heart before the Blue God lands, there won't be an Earth left to record."

Chapter Twenty-Eight

The air shattered.

With the Merged God, the Trinity of Fire, Storm, and Void, standing as a three-headed monolith in the center of the Basgiath crater, the laws of physics began to fray at the edges. My lungs burned with every breath, the oxygen being sucked toward the God’s central mass like water down a drain. We weren't just soldiers anymore; we were gnats caught in the gravitational pull of a collapsing star.

"We can't just stand here and wait for the sapphire light to hit!" I screamed, the sound barely carrying over the low-frequency hum of the God's three hearts beating in discordant unison.

Xaden was already moving. He didn't look like a cadet; he looked like a god of the underworld. His shadows had expanded, no longer mere ribbons but massive, jagged claws of darkness that anchored into the ruins of the assembly grounds. "Rhiannon! Ridoc! Get to the perimeter! If we can’t kill it, we distract it. We force its attention away from the sky!"

"Distract it?" Ridoc shouted, his voice cracking as he dodged a falling piece of the archive tower. "It has six eyes and three heads, Xaden! I think it's pretty well-stocked on attention!"

"Do it!" Xaden roared.

I watched Rhiannon and Ridoc break into a sprint. Rhiannon, her face set in a mask of absolute defiance, began to weave a Telekinetic Web. She wasn't just throwing stones; she was ripping the literal iron out of the broken foundations of the college and hurling it like javelins at the God’s central head—the one that still bore the matte-grey features of Grayness.

CLANG.

The iron shattered against the God’s iridescent obsidian plates, leaving not even a scratch. But it worked. The central head tilted, its four burning orbs of violet sun focusing on the tiny, defiant human below.

"Now, Elara!" Xaden commanded.

I didn't need to be told twice. I ignored the screaming protest of my dislocated shoulder and the way my left hip felt like it was grinding into dust. I gripped the Adamas-shard against my chest, the heat of it searing through my flight leathers, and I channeled everything.

I didn't draw a rune. I drew a *Severance*.

I ran toward God's flank, my boots slipping on the blood and ash. Advast was a screaming tempest in my mind, his terror turning into a cold, predatory focus. *The junction, wildfire!* he hissed. *The point where the three necks meet the spine! It is the only place where the energies haven't fully fused!*

I launched myself onto the God’s massive, tree-trunk limb. The scales were hot, so hot they blistered my palms instantly, but I didn't let go. I climbed, using the jagged edges of the obsidian plates as handholds, the world spinning as the God began to shift its weight.

"Brennan! The anchor!" I yelled.

My brother appeared from the shadows beneath the God’s belly. He looked like a specter, his silver eyes glowing with a frantic, dying light. He slammed his palms against the God’s hind leg, channeling his corrupted, siphoned energy upward. It wasn't meant to damage; it was a Probe. He was feeding the God a "poisoned" frequency, trying to disrupt the harmonic resonance that kept the three Alphas merged.

The God let out a low, vibrating growl that shook the marrow of my bones. It raised a massive claw to swiped Brennan into oblivion, but Xaden was there.

Xaden didn't use blades. He used the Void.

He materialized on the God’s shoulder, his shadows wrapping around the creature’s central throat like a noose. He wasn't trying to strangle a god; he

was trying to create a Shadow-Blind. He forced the darkness into the God's eyes, plunging the creature into an artificial night.

The God roared, a sound that leveled the remaining trees in the valley. It thrashed, its village-spanning wings snapping open and creating a vacuum that nearly sucked the air from my lungs.

I reached the junction.

The skin here was translucent, a swirling whirlpool of violet, silver, and grey energy. It looked like a storm trapped under glass. I raised my Stele, the silver tip glowing with a white-hot, blinding light that rivaled the approaching star from Neptune.

"For the Scribes!" I screamed, and I drove the Stele deep into the glowing junction.

The feedback was instantaneous.

A bolt of raw, unrefined power shot up the Stele and through my arm. My nervous system ignited. I saw my own skeleton illuminated in a flash of violet light. I felt my heart stop, then restart with a violent, agonizing thud.

The God shrieked, all three heads in a horrifying, dissonant chord. The iridescent plates across its chest began to fracture, leaking a thick, glowing ichor that smelled of sulfur and ancient oceans.

"It's working!" Rhiannon yelled, but her voice was cut short.

The sky turned a deep, lethal sapphire.

The Neptune God, the one the Alphas called Abrager, had breached the final layer of the atmosphere. It wasn't a speck anymore. It was a moon-sized entity of liquid diamond and blue fire, and it was falling directly toward our heads at ten times the speed of sound.

The Merged God felt its brother's approach. Despite my Stele being buried in its neck, despite Xaden’s shadows and Brennan’s poison, it began to glow. It wasn't fighting us anymore. It was preparing to be the landing pad.

"Elara, get off it!" Xaden screamed, reaching for me as the air around us began to turn into a blue, crystalline frost. "He's coming! Abrager is here!"

I looked up, and for a second, I saw the face of the Neptune God. It wasn't a dragon. It was a geometric nightmare of crystalline shards and frozen methane, and its eyes were the cold, uncaring blue of a dying planet.

The impact was seconds away.

The atmosphere shattered.

Abrager, the Neptune God, landed like a spear of liquid diamond driven into the heart of the world. The moment his sapphire-blue, crystalline form touched the Merged Hybrid, the heat of the fire-alpha and the storm-ice of the female were instantly neutralized by a cold so absolute it slowed the vibration of atoms.

The Merged God didn't even have time to shriek. The liquid-diamond energy of Abrager acted like a solvent, dissolving the bonds between the three merged Alphas. In a spray of glowing ichor and fractured obsidian, the Trinity was unmade—but not by us. Abrager simply stepped through them, his massive, shifting claws crushing the central head of Grayness into the dirt.

The hybrid was dead before it hit the ground.

Abrager stood in the center of the ruins, a towering monument of frozen methane and deep-sea blue. He looked up at the sky, his eyes—voids of Neptune-darkness, focusing on a point far beyond our solar system.

He unleashed the Celestial Alpha Roar.

It wasn't a sound meant for ears. It was a gravitational wave. It traveled out past the moon, past the edge of the sun’s reach, and dived straight into the swirling, hungry dark of the Milky Way’s center.

We waited in a silence that felt like the end of time.

Then, the answer came.

It wasn't a sound, but a shudder in the fabric of space-time. From the supermassive black hole at the center of the galaxy, a roar responded—a sound so ancient and heavy that it pulled at the tides of Earth, causing the oceans to swell by ten feet in a single minute.

The Sleeping King was awake.

"He's coming," I whispered, my Stele falling from my numb fingers. My violet eyes could see the distortion in the stars, a massive shadow beginning to move toward our sun.

"How long?" Xaden asked, his shadows curling around him like a funerary shroud.

"He is the weight of a billion stars," I said, the Scribe-knowledge flooding my mind with terrifying clarity. "Even at the speed of the Void... it will take him days to cross the light-years. We have a reprieve."

"A reprieve?" Ridoc looked at the blue titan standing in our crater and the sky that was currently being rewritten. "We have a few days before a Black Hole King arrives to eat the planet. What do we do until then?"

I looked at Abrager, who had settled into a watchful, crystalline crouch, waiting for his master.

"We prepare," I said, my voice cold as the Neptune ice. "We have three days to find a way to kill a God made of gravity. And I know exactly where the archives for that are hidden."

Chapter Twenty-Nine

The shadow of the Black Hole King hung over the atmosphere like a bruised thumbprint on the lens of the universe. It was a second, dark sun, devoid of heat, pulling the very light from the edges of our vision. But on the ground, the threat was more immediate, more crystalline, and far colder.

Abrager, the Neptune God, did not move for the first twenty-four hours. He stood in the center of the Basgiath crater, a three-hundred-foot statue of liquid diamond and sapphire ice. He was waiting for his King, but his presence alone was an extinction event. The air around him had dropped to a temperature that shouldn't exist on Earth—a sub-zero vacuum that turned the oxygen into falling, crystalline shards.

"We don't have the days it will take for the King to arrive," I rasped, my voice sounding like grinding gravel. My throat was raw, my lungs feeling as though they were being lined with powdered glass. "If we don't unmake the Sentinel now, the frost will reach the coast by morning. There won't be a world left for the King to rule."

Xaden stood beside me, his shadows no longer flowing like silk, but jagged and brittle, snapping in the frigid wind like frozen whips. "How do you kill something that thrives in the pressure of a gas giant? He isn't made of flesh, Elara. He’s a thermodynamic anomaly."

"He’s a circuit," I countered, the Scribe-knowledge pulsing behind my violet eyes with a frantic, dying heat. "Liquid diamond is the perfect conductor. He isn't just a god; he's a planetary battery. We don't need to break him. We need to short him out."

The first day was a grueling marathon of preparation. We couldn't fly; the air was too thin and cold for the dragons’ wings to catch. Instead, we moved like ghosts through the ruins of our home. Rhiannon and Ridoc led the remains of the Fourth Wing in a desperate, manual labor of war. They hauled massive vats of Dragon-Fire pitch—the hottest substance known to the Nephilim—to the jagged rim of the crater. Every step was a gamble; if a

cadet slipped on the blue frost, their skin shattered like porcelain upon impact.

While they prepared the fire, Xaden and I went into the dark.

We used my Stele to carve a tunnel through the frozen bedrock, tunneling beneath the god’s massive, sapphire talons. The work was slow, agonizing. Every time I drove the silver tip into the stone, the feedback of the Neptune-cold traveled up my arm, turning my veins into lines of ice. Advast was a screaming furnace in my mind, funneling his life-fire into my nervous system just to keep my heart from seizing.

"Almost... there," I wheezed, the violet-bond flare illuminating the sapphire roots of the god above us. They looked like massive, glowing veins of blue light, pulsing with the rhythm of the galactic center.

By the dawn of the second day, the atmosphere had turned a lethal, electric indigo.

"Now!" I screamed into the Scribe-link, the command echoing through the minds of every survivor in the valley.

The sky rained fire. Not the orange of a campfire, but the blinding, white-hot chemical burn of dragon-pitch. The vats were tipped, sending a waterfall of flame into the crater. The thermal shock was instantaneous. The air itself shrieked, a high-pitched, metallic wail as the heat met the sub-zero hide of the god.

Abrager finally moved.

He threw his head back, his sapphire eyes flashing with a cold, planetary fury. He didn't roar; he vibrated. The sound shattered the falling fire mid-air, turning the pitch into harmless, frozen pellets. He raised a massive, crystalline claw to sweep the rim of the crater, ready to vaporize the riders in a single strike.

"Now, Xaden!"

Xaden stepped out from the shadows of the beast’s underbelly. He didn't use blades. He used the Void-Anchor. Drawing on the gravitational pull of the approaching Black Hole King, he tethered Abrager’s six limbs to the very core of the Earth. The God of Neptune was pinned, his sapphire muscles bulging as he fought against the weight of a billion stars.

I didn't wait. I crawled out from the tunnel, directly beneath the God’s central vent.

The "heart" was a swirling whirlpool of liquid methane and diamond dust. It was beautiful. It was the coldest thing I had ever seen. I raised the Adamas-shard, my fingers so frozen they felt like they belonged to a statue.

"For my father," I whispered. "And for the world you think is beneath you."

I slammed the shard into the vent.

I didn't just push it; I poured my soul into the strike. I let the violet-bond consume me, turning my body into a conductor. The Adamas-shard acted as the "short." The liquid diamond inside Abrager didn't just heat up; it destabilized.

The reaction was a sensory-shattering explosion of blue.

Abrager didn't just die; he melted. But he didn't turn into water. He collapsed into a state of super-cooled vapor and liquid oxygen. His moon-sized body sagged, the diamond lattice shattering into billions of microscopic shards that hummed with a lethal, blue light.

With one final, gurgling sound, the sound of a planet’s atmosphere escaping into space, the Neptune God dissolved.

A wave of absolute-zero sapphire liquid erupted from the crater. It was a tsunami of ice that moved with the speed of a landslide. It hit the ruins of Basgiath, consuming everything in its path. The fires were snuffed out in a heartbeat. The stones were encased in six feet of translucent, blue crystal.

"Get to the peaks!" Brennan’s voice was a distant echo as he hauled Rhiannon and Ridoc toward the higher ridges.

I couldn't run. I was the anchor.

I felt the sapphire tide hit my boots. I felt the cold climb my legs, turning my skin into a hard, crystalline shell. My heart gave one final, violent thud against the Adamas-shard before the world went quiet.

I was encased in the center of a sapphire sea. Above me, the blue vapor rose into the sky, seeding the clouds. Within minutes, the sun was gone, replaced by a shroud of indigo ice-clouds.

The "Ice Age" had begun. The valley was a graveyard of blue glass, silent and frozen.

And high above, the Black Hole King saw the death of his guard. He roared, a sound that pulled the tides of the frozen sea toward the sky, and he accelerated.

He would be here in forty-eight hours. And he was coming for the girl in the ice.

Chapter Thirty

The silence was the first thing that truly terrified me.

It wasn't the silence of a library or a quiet night in the archives. It was the silence of a vacuum, a total, suffocating absence of sound that felt like it was pressing against the outside of my skull. I was suspended in six feet of sapphire crystal, my body a frozen sculpture of defiance. Through the translucent, blue-tinted walls of my prison, the world didn't look like Idris anymore. It looked like the bottom of a frozen ocean on a dead moon.

The sky above was a bruised, sickly indigo. The Black Hole King, the singularity wrapped in the scales of a god, was no longer a speck. He was a massive, velvet-black hole in the tapestry of the stars, a hungry void that seemed to be drinking the light of our own sun. He was three days out, and yet I could feel his gravity pulling at the sapphire in my skin.

Wildfire, Advast's voice was a ragged, flickering candle in the dark of my mind. *Do not let the cold settle in your heart. If you stop feeling the anger, you will become part of the Neptune-God's dream. You will be a monument to a dead world.*

I tried to scream, but my throat was a column of ice. I tried to move my fingers, but they were locked in the crystalline lattice of Abrager's final breath.

Then, a flicker of movement.

A shadow, darker than the sapphire ice and more solid than the indigo sky, detached itself from the ruins of a collapsed watchtower. It moved with a slow, agonizing precision, the ice beneath its boots cracking with the sound of breaking glass.

Xaden.

He looked like a ghost. His charcoal flight leathers were coated in a fine layer of blue frost, and his face was a mask of gaunt, hollow-eyed

exhaustion. But his eyes, those golden-flecked obsidian orbs, were fixed on me with a ferocity that could have melted the poles.

He reached my prison and pressed his palms against the sapphire surface. I saw the steam rise instantly; he was channeling every ounce of his internal fire, every scrap of the shadow-bond he shared with Sgaeyl, just to keep his hands from shattering upon contact with the absolute-zero crystal.

"I have you," his voice was a muffled vibration through the ice, a low hum that I felt in my teeth. "Elara, if you can hear me, find the center. Find the shard."

I focused everything I had left on the Adamas-shard tucked against my heart. It was the only part of me that was still warm, a tiny, glowing violet coal in a world of blue frost. I pushed my consciousness into the stone, reaching for the harmonic frequency I had felt when I "shorted out" the Neptune God.

Crack.

The sound was like a gunshot in the silence. A hairline fracture appeared where Xaden’s thumbs pressed against the ice. His shadows didn't just push; they vibrated, oscillating at the exact same frequency as the sapphire lattice.

The wall didn't just break, it shattered.

The pressure change was violent. I fell forward as the ice turned into a freezing blue gas, my limbs feeling like they were made of lead and broken needles. The sudden intake of oxygen scorched my lungs, making me retch as the atmospheric pressure of Earth rushed back into my space.

Xaden caught me before I hit the frozen ground. He pulled me into his cloak, the heat of his body feeling like a forest fire against my crystalline skin. He didn't say a word; he just held me, his breath hitching against the crook of my neck, his hands trembling as they checked the pulse at my throat.

"I'm here," I wheezed, the words feeling like shards of glass. "I'm... still here."

"Barely," he rasped, his voice breaking. He pulled back just enough to look at me, his face etched with a raw, bleeding relief. "You're turning blue, Sorrengail. Literally. Your skin is crystallized."

"It's the... Neptune legacy," I said, leaning my weight into him as my legs began to regain a phantom of sensation. "I can feel the King. I can feel him pulling."

He looked up at the black sun in the sky. "We all can. The tides have stopped. The wind has died. The world is just... waiting to be swallowed."

He helped me toward the "fire." It wasn't a fire of wood; there was no wood left that wasn't frozen solid. Instead, Rhiannon and Ridoc were huddled around a glowing, purple conduit that Brennan had managed to rip from the mountain's exposed core. It radiated a sickly, artificial heat that smelled of ozone and siphoned magic.

"She's alive!" Ridoc shouted, jumping to his feet, though he nearly fell over from the stiffness in his own knees. "Probability of survival just went from zero to... well, one percent. I'll take it."

Rhiannon wrapped a heavy, dragon-hide blanket around my shoulders, her eyes damp with tears she refused to let fall. "The King is accelerating, Elara. He’s three days away. The General tried to launch the Skystrikers, but their dragons' lungs froze the moment they cleared the ridge. We’re the only ones left in the valley."

"We’re the only ones who can reach him," I said, my voice growing stronger as the violet-bond began to circulate through my veins again. "The King isn't coming to fight us. He's coming to collect us. He thinks the Neptune-God's death has prepared the harvest."

I looked at Brennan. "You said the mountain's core is still active. How much energy is left in the Primary Anchor?"

Brennan’s silver eyes reflected the purple glow of the conduit. "Enough to level the continent if it’s released all at once. But we can't release it, Elara. The wards are tied to it. If the anchor goes, the mountain collapses."

"The mountain is already gone, Brennan," I said, gesturing to the blue-glass graveyard that used to be Basgiath. "We don't need an anchor. We need a fuse."

I looked at Xaden. "The King is a black hole. He is the ultimate vacuum. We can't hit him with blades or fire; he’ll just swallow them. But if we feed him a Supernova-Rune, if we give him more energy than his singularity can process in a single microsecond—he’ll collapse under his own mass."

"You want to feed a black hole until it chokes," Xaden said, a dark, dangerous smile finally touching his lips.

"I want to turn Idris into a shaped charge," I corrected. "Three days. We have three days to map the ley lines into a geometric explosive. Brennan, you provide the fuel. Xaden, your shadows will be the containment field. Rhiannon, you're the architect of the telekinetic trigger."

"And you?" Ridoc asked.

I looked at my hands—the skin was still shimmering with sapphire dust, my eyes glowing with a violet light that felt like it could pierce the center of the galaxy.

"I'm the Scribe," I said. "I'm going to write the last word in his book. And it’s going to be Goodbye."

For the next seventy-two hours, we became the most dangerous engineers in history. We didn't sleep. We didn't eat. We lived on the raw, vibrating energy of the bond and the pure, unadulterated spite of a species that refused to be harvested.

We began the descent into the core. The stairs were gone, so we rappelled down the jagged obsidian cliffs of the internal rift, the cold air becoming a pressurized, humid heat as we neared the planet's marrow.

Every hour, the King got larger. By the end of the first day, he occupied half the sky. The stars around him were being distorted, stretched into long, glowing ribbons of light. The "Song of the Void" began to hum in our ears—a low, hypnotic frequency that tried to tell us to just lie down and let go.

"Don't listen to him!" I shouted, slamming my Stele into the stone to anchor myself. "He’s just a gravity-well! He’s just an appetite!"

We reached the Primary Anchor on the second day. It was a pillar of white Adamas the size of a cathedral, pulsing with the life-force of Navarre.

"This is it," Brennan whispered, touching the stone. "The heart of the lie."

"Let's turn it into a truth," I said.

I raised my Stele and began to draw the first line of the Supernova-Rune. It was a geometry I had seen in the Neptune-God's eyes, a fractal pattern that accelerated it toward a single, infinite point.

The King was forty-eight hours away. The fuse was being set. And the daughter of the General was preparing to blow the sky apart.

Chapter Thirty-One

The Supernova-Rune was half-finished when the mountain screamed.

Not a tremor. Not a subsidence. A scream—a single, sustained note of ancient, geological agony that started somewhere beneath the Primary Anchor and tore upward through six thousand feet of bedrock before it reached us. The rune etched into the Adamas pillar flickered. The conduit Brennan had rigged from the core sputtered and spat purple fire.

"That's not the King," Ridoc said, his voice stripped of its usual nervous humor. He had one hand pressed flat against the obsidian wall of the rift, his palm reading the tremor's frequency the way a sailor reads a wave. "The King's gravity pulls. This is pushing. Something below us is pushing up."

I yanked the Stele back from the Adamas surface. The half-drawn Supernova-Rune pulsed an ugly, truncated gold. Around us, the rift walls creaked—a deep, wood-groaning sound that had no business coming from stone.

"Advast." I reached for the bond, for the violet filament that connected us even through eight hundred feet of solid rock. "What is that?"

His answer was not words. It was an image—a flash of racial memory so old it predated language. I saw the mountain from above, from the perspective of something vast and airborne, circling a peak that was still sharp and unscarred by the centuries of war that would eventually hollow it out. I saw the city built into its roots. Not Basgiath—Basgiath was a scar drawn over the bones of something older.

Aretia.

I hadn't recognized the name when I'd first seen it in the footnotes of a crumbling annex in my father's library. He had dismissed it as a cartographer's error—an older name for the same mountain, superseded by the Shadowhunter administrative records of the Second Age. But my

father had been wrong about only a handful of things in his entire scholarly life, and this was apparently one of them.

Aretia was not an older name for Basgiath. It was a buried city. A real one. Sealed under three hundred feet of engineered granite by the First Riders, who had decided—for reasons the history books had either lost or deliberately excised—that what lived beneath the mountain should never be disturbed.

The pushing sensation spiked. The floor of the rift lurched.

"Move!" Xaden's shadows exploded outward, slamming into all of us, hurling us back from the Adamas pillar as the ground beneath it simply ceased to exist. The stone didn't crack or crumble—it dropped away, a perfect circular section of ancient bedrock falling into a darkness so total and so deep it didn't even echo.

We scrambled, grabbing for handholds in the rift wall, Rhiannon's telekinesis snapping out to catch Ridoc before he followed the stone into the void. The conduit, the carefully rigged fuel line Brennan had spent fourteen sleepless hours calibrating, swung free over the opening and began to melt, its purple fire dripping down into the dark like burning rain.

"The Anchor—" Brennan started.

"Is still standing," I said, because it was. The Adamas pillar had not fallen. It stood at the edge of the new chasm, perfectly intact, the half-drawn Supernova-Rune glowing on its face, now suspended over nothing.

From the dark below us, something breathed.

It wasn't air moving through a cave. It wasn't a geological pressure change or the settling of a disturbed gas pocket. I had spent three years cataloguing the respiratory signatures of every bonded dragon species in the archive records, and what rose from that hole was breath—enormous, structured, deeply biological breath, the kind that belongs to lungs the size of cathedral vaults.

Then came the heat.

It rolled up from the chasm like the opening of a furnace door, thick and ancient and wrong in a way that made the hairs on my arms stand up. It wasn't the ozone-and-brimstone heat of modern dragon fire. It smelled of something older—copper and deep-earth minerals and the particular scorched quality of air that has been breathed and re-breathed for centuries in a sealed space.

"Elara," Rhiannon whispered. She was gripping the rift wall with white-knuckled hands, her dark eyes fixed on the hole. "Tell me the archive records say something useful right now."

"The First Riders sealed Aretia," I said, my voice coming out far steadier than I felt. "Every record I've ever read says the reason was classified beyond the rank of General. My father once found a fragment—a single line from a Third Age decommission order. He thought it was a scribal error."

"What did it say?" Xaden asked. He had moved to stand beside me, his body a low wall of heat against the cold, his shadows pooling at our feet in vigilant, rippling arcs.

"'The Progenitor sleeps. Let it sleep.'"

The silence that followed that sentence lasted exactly three seconds.

Then the Progenitor woke up.

The first thing to clear the lip of the chasm was its head—and it took a long, disorienting moment for my mind to correctly parse the scale. I kept expecting the whole creature to be visible at once, the way a dragon cresting a ridge eventually resolves into a complete shape. It didn't. The head alone was the size of a galleon, plated in scales that were not black or silver or any color I had a word for. They were the color of deep time—a dark, shifting iridescence that cycled through every hue the visible spectrum contained, like oil on water, like the surface of a star in its dying hours.

Its eyes opened.

They were not the lambent, jewel-bright eyes of the dragons I knew. They were white. Not pale—white, the total, sourceless white of burning magnesium, two suns in the skull of a creature that had been sleeping since before the Nephilim had learned to carve runes.

It looked at me.

Not at us. At me. With a specificity that felt like being pinned to a map.

The bond-filament in my chest didn't vibrate. It rang—a single, perfect, concert-hall note that I felt from my sternum to the roots of my back teeth. The Adamas-shard against my heart flared so violently I smelled my own flight leathers beginning to scorch.

Wildfire. Advast's voice arrived from above, from the surface, distant but urgent. *Do not move. Do not reach for your Stele. It is reading you. It is deciding.*

"Deciding what?" I breathed, not moving my lips.

Whether you are the end or the continuation.

The Progenitor finished hauling itself out of the earth.

The rift was massive—a structural wound in the mountain's interior carved by the tectonic violence of the last three days. It was not large enough. The Progenitor's shoulders demolished the eastern wall as it rose, three tons of ancient stone exploding outward in a roar of dust and falling rubble. Xaden's shadows snapped up around us, a dome of dark matter that caught the debris and shed it like water. Rhiannon's telekinetic field reinforced the western wall before it could follow. Ridoc made a sound that was not quite a word.

The creature rose and rose and rose. Its neck was a column. Its body, as it finally, fully emerged into the rift chamber, was geological in its mass—not fat, not bloated, but simply large the way a mountain range is large, with

the casual, immovable certainty of something that has never in its life needed to worry about fitting through a door.

Its wings were folded against its sides. They stayed folded. It didn't need them to intimidate. It simply needed to exist.

Then it opened its mouth—and roared.

I have heard dragon roars. I have catalogued twenty-seven distinct phonetic categories of dragon vocalization, from the subsonic territorial rumble of a nesting female to the hyper-compressed laser-roar of an Alpha in full combat mode. I thought I understood the sound a dragon could make.

I understood nothing.

The Progenitor's roar was not a sound, it was a revision of the world's acoustic history—a single, cataclysmic event that retroactively made every other loud noise that had ever existed feel like a polite suggestion. It hit the rift walls and the walls didn't echo it; they transmitted it, the stone itself vibrating at the fundamental frequency of the roar, turning the entire mountain into a resonance chamber. My bones didn't rattle. They harmonized. Every Binding rune I'd etched onto my skeleton lit up white-gold and held, barely, like stitching under a blade.

Above us, through eight hundred feet of rock, I felt every single dragon in the valley go silent.

Even the Black Hole King, expanding his lightless mass on the horizon, seemed to pause.

The roar ended. The silence it left behind was the loudest thing I had ever experienced.

The Progenitor looked at me again. Then it did something I had no category for. It lowered its head—its enormous, iridescent, epoch-spanning head—until the tip of its snout hovered approximately four inches from my face. I could feel the heat radiating off its scales the way you feel a hearth

fire from across a room. Its white eyes, each one larger than my entire body, were absolutely, terrifyingly calm.

In my chest, the Adamas-shard pulsed once. Twice. Then it stopped pulsing and began to glow—steady and constant, the way a star glows, without urgency, without fluctuation.

"Elara." Xaden's voice was very quiet. "What is it doing?"

"I think," I said, with the careful, measured diction of someone who has spent their entire life in archives and knows precisely how important it is to use the correct word, "it's waiting for an introduction."

I did not reach for my Stele. I did not draw a rune. I pressed two fingers to the Adamas-shard through my leathers and I said, to the oldest living thing I had ever encountered, the only thing that felt true:

"My name is Elara Sorrengail. I'm a Scribe. I've read every history of this mountain that survived the First Age, and none of them mentioned you—which means either the historians were afraid of you, or they loved you too much to commit you to paper where the wrong eyes might find you." I held its white gaze. "I think it was the latter."

For a very long moment, nothing happened.

Then the Progenitor exhaled—a slow, vast, deliberate breath that smelled of copper and deep stone and something else, something I couldn't name but recognized in the way you recognize a piece of music you've never heard before but somehow already know. The warmth of it moved through me like a tide.

And in the cavity of my chest, where the violet-bond lived alongside the Adamas-shard and the borrowed fire of twenty etched runes, something new took root. Not a bond—not exactly. Something older than a bond. A recognition.

Above us, through the shattered ceiling of the rift, the stars were going dark one by one as the King consumed them. We had perhaps thirty-six hours before there was nothing left to save.

But the Progenitor was awake.

And it remembered what it had been sealed away to protect.

Chapter Thirty-Two

The Progenitor unfolded its wings.

The sound was not a snap or a crack. It was a pressure change—a sudden, violent redistribution of air that hit us like a wall and sent Ridoc skidding three feet across the stone before Rhiannon caught him. Each wing was a continent. That is not hyperbole; that is the only unit of measurement that applies. They filled the rift from wall to demolished wall, and when they still didn't fit, the walls simply ceased to be walls. The Progenitor's wingspan rewrote the architecture of the mountain's interior the way a tide rewrites a sandbar—completely, without malice, without noticing.

"Down!" Xaden had me by the collar of my flight leathers before I'd consciously registered the need to move. His shadows threw a ceiling over us, a low, dense vault of dark matter that absorbed the first concussive downbeat and shed it sideways into the rubble.

The Progenitor launched.

It didn't take off the way a dragon takes off—the running start, the grunt of effort, the laborious climb through the first hundred feet of altitude. It simply decided to be somewhere else, and the air rearranged itself in panicked compliance. One moment it occupied the rift. The next, a column of superheated atmosphere punched upward through six hundred feet of mountain, and the Progenitor was already clearing the peak, its white eyes fixed on the thing eating the sky.

The crater it left in the summit of Basgiath was a perfect circle, sixty feet across, edges fused to glass.

We stood in the wreckage of the rift and looked up through the hole where the mountain used to be, and we watched.

The Black Hole King was no longer on the horizon. He had crossed it. He occupied the upper atmosphere now, a darkness so total and so structured

that the stars around him weren't simply absent—they were being drawn toward him in long, luminous spirals, like water finding a drain. His silhouette, if you could call a living singularity a silhouette, was roughly the shape of a dragon the way a hurricane is roughly the shape of wind. He was made of the concept of consumption wearing the body of a god.

The Progenitor hit him at the thermosphere.

We felt the collision before we saw it—a shockwave that traveled down through the atmosphere and hit the earth like a second tectonic event, knocking us off our feet. The rift walls shed three feet of stone. Brennan went down hard, catching himself on both palms, silver eyes blazing.

When I looked up again, the sky was on fire.

Not orange fire. Not the violet-and-laser light of the Alpha's combat mode. White fire—the same sourceless, magnesium-white as the Progenitor's eyes—erupting in cascading detonations across the upper atmosphere as the two beings grappled. The King's darkness swallowed the fire and the Progenitor simply made more, pouring it out in sustained, structural columns that weren't burning so much as *insisting.* Where the King's gravity bent light inward, the Progenitor's fire bent it back out again. The sky between them was a war of physics.

"It's not enough," Ridoc said. His voice was flat and precise—not hopeless, just accurate. He was using the navigational compass again, watching the needle. The needle was not spinning anymore. It was pointing straight up, pulled toward the King's mass. "The Progenitor is matching him right now, but the King has been consuming stellar mass for however long he's been traveling. He's been eating *stars*, Elara. He has more fuel than the Progenitor has fire."

I already knew. I'd known the moment I watched the first white column get swallowed and not returned.

I looked at the Adamas pillar. The half-finished Supernova-Rune still glowed on its face, suspended at the edge of the chasm, intact and waiting.

We'd abandoned it when the ground dropped out. We'd been thirty minutes from completing it when Aretia cracked open.

Thirty minutes.

"Brennan." I was already moving, picking my way across the rubble toward the pillar. "How much fuel is left in the core conduit?"

He checked the swinging, half-melted line. "Forty percent. Maybe thirty-five. I lost some when it destabilized."

"Is thirty-five enough to complete the rune?"

A pause. The kind of pause that means he's doing the math and not liking the answer. "To draw it, yes. To *fire* it—" He shook his head. "The Supernova-Rune needs a delivery mechanism, Elara. We built it to be fed into the King via the ley line network. But the ley lines aren't the problem anymore. He's not on the ground. He's in the upper atmosphere being actively held in place by something the size of a continent. We'd need a vector that can reach—"

He stopped.

We all stopped.

I turned and looked at the hole in the summit. At the white fire blooming against the dark, sixty miles above us.

"We don't need a ley line," I said. "We need a courier."

The bond was still there. Thinner than it should have been at this distance—the Progenitor was far enough away now that the new recognition-thread in my chest felt like a wire pulled to its maximum extension, humming with tension. But it was there. I could feel it.

I pressed my fingers to the Adamas-shard.

"Advast," I said. "I need you to talk to it."

His response was immediate and uneasy. *Wildfire, I am a void-dragon, not a—*

"I know what you are. I'm not asking you to bond with it. I'm asking you to translate." I reached deeper, past the violet filament of our bond, toward the newer thread. The recognition. The thing the Progenitor had planted in my chest when it exhaled. "It put something in me. I can feel it. I just can't speak its language."

A long silence from above. Then, from Advast, something I had never felt through the bond before: reluctance edging toward awe.

The old language, he said. *I know only fragments. What do you want to tell it?*

I looked at the Supernova-Rune. At my Stele. At the half-finished geometry of the most dangerous mark I'd ever attempted to draw, now glowing patiently on a pillar at the edge of the abyss.

"Tell it," I said, "that we can coat its fire."

Advast went quiet. Not the quiet of distance or interference—the quiet of someone translating very carefully.

I raised the Stele and returned to the pillar.

"Rhiannon," I said, without turning around. "I need a telekinetic brace on my left side. My hip is going." It was—the last shockwave had rattled something loose, and I could feel the joint sliding in the wrong direction with every step. I didn't have time to redraw the Binding rune. "Ridoc, I need you on the conduit. Brennan, stand ready to anchor—I'll tell you when."

"What are you doing?" Xaden had followed me to the pillar's edge. Below us, the chasm was bottomless black. Above us, the sky was a war.

"Finishing the rune," I said. "But I'm not drawing it for the ley lines anymore. I'm drawing it for *her.*" I gestured upward, at the white fire. "The Supernova-Rune is a fractal accelerant. It takes whatever energy it's fed

and collapses it toward a single infinite point. We designed it to choke the King—to give him more than his singularity could process. But it works on any energy source."

Xaden followed the logic the way he always did—fast, and without flinching from where it led. "You want to coat the Progenitor's fire with the rune. Turn every flame it breathes into a supernova charge."

"If the King tries to swallow a Supernova-Rune—"

"It collapses inward," Xaden finished. "He chokes on his own gravity." He looked up. The white fire was still holding, but the columns were getting shorter. The Progenitor was tiring. "How do we get the rune from the pillar to sixty miles up?"

I met his eyes. "The same way we get everything done."

He understood. His shadows rose without being asked—not a dome this time, not a shield, but a column, a dark spire rising from the floor of the rift and extending upward through the shattered mountain and into the open air above. A conduit of his own. A shadow-bridge from the Adamas pillar to the upper atmosphere.

"I can hold it for eight minutes," he said. His jaw was set. The Mark of the Traitor on his neck had gone pale, which meant he was already burning through his reserves. "After that, the distance is too much."

"Six," I said. "I only need six."

I pressed my Stele to the Adamas pillar and I drew.

This is what the archive records get wrong about rune-etching under pressure: they describe it as a discipline of stillness, of careful, meditative precision. That is true in a classroom. In a rift chamber with a disintegrating hip and a pillar suspended over an infinite drop and sixty miles of air between you and the thing you're trying to save, it is something else entirely. It is controlled desperation. It is the specific, furious calm of someone who has spent twenty years being told they are too fragile for this

world and has chosen, in this exact moment, to make the world adjust its expectations.

The Supernova-Rune is forty-seven strokes. I drew them in four minutes and fifty seconds.

The pillar detonated with light.

Not an explosion—a bloom, slow and total, the rune geometry spreading outward from the Adamas surface in fractal branches, each branch splitting into smaller branches until the entire pillar was a lattice of living gold. The heat was immense. I staggered back, and Rhiannon's telekinetic brace caught me, held me upright, kept my hip in its socket by sheer force of will.

"Brennan," I said. "Now."

He slammed his palms into the conduit line. The thirty-five percent reserve discharged in a single pulse—a violet-white detonation that traveled up the conduit and hit the rune-lattice and was instantly, catastrophically restructured. The Supernova geometry took the raw energy and did what it was designed to do: compressed it, fractalized it, collapsed it toward a single infinite point and then held it there, trembling at the edge of its own event horizon, waiting.

Xaden's shadow-column caught the discharge at the top of the pillar and carried it up.

We watched it rise—a thread of fractal gold climbing the shadow-bridge, ascending through the shattered summit of Basgiath and into the purple-black of the upper atmosphere, climbing toward sixty miles of altitude, toward the white fire and the darkness eating it.

"Come on," Ridoc whispered. He was gripping the broken conduit line with both hands, knuckles white, watching the thread climb. "Come on, come on, come on—"

The Progenitor saw it coming.

I felt the moment it recognized the thread through the recognition-filament in my chest—a single beat of something that wasn't surprise exactly, but was the ancient, considered equivalent of it. A creature that had not been surprised in a thousand years encountering something it had not accounted for.

Then it inhaled.

And the next column of white fire it breathed into the King was threaded through, at the quantum level, with forty-seven strokes of Supernova geometry.

The King swallowed it.

The silence lasted two full seconds.

Then the upper atmosphere turned gold.

The detonation was not loud down here. Sound doesn't carry well from sixty miles up, and what reached us was less a noise than a sensation—a pressure bloom that moved through the earth itself, through the soles of our boots and the marrow of our bones. The King's outline, that impossible lightless shape against the stars, contracted. Not slowly. Suddenly—a violent inward spasm, like a fist clenching, as his own gravity turned against him and the fractal geometry inside the fire he'd swallowed refused to be absorbed and instead kept collapsing, infinitely, recursively inward.

He was choking.

He was actually choking.

"It's working," Rhiannon said, and her voice broke on the last word. Not from fear. "Elara, it's *working.*"

Above us, the Progenitor pressed the advantage. It was not a creature that hesitated. It poured column after column of Supernova-threaded fire into the contracting mass of the King, each one another fractal loop in the recursive collapse, each one making the next more catastrophic than the

last. The gold light spread across the upper atmosphere like a second dawn—warmer than the sun, steadier than the stars, the specific color of a rune drawn in Adamas by someone who intends to mean it.

Xaden let go of the shadow-column and dropped to one knee. I was at his side before he hit the stone, one hand at his shoulder, the other checking the pulse at his throat. It was there—rapid and thin, but present.

"I'm fine," he said, in the voice of someone who is decidedly not fine but has decided not to discuss it.

"You're catastrophically not fine," I said. "Don't move."

"Are you drawing a Healing rune on my neck right now?"

"I'm drawing a Stamina rune on your neck right now. The Healing rune comes after you stop being an idiot." I pressed the Stele to his skin and etched the mark with hands that were almost steady. Almost. "You held a shadow-bridge for six minutes at sixty miles. Your reserves are empty."

"Worth it," he said, and looked up at the gold sky.

I followed his gaze.

The King was smaller. Not by much—not yet. But the contraction was ongoing, self-sustaining now, the recursive geometry of the Supernova-Rune feeding itself on his own mass. He was being made to collapse the way a star collapses: not destroyed by something outside him, but betrayed by his own weight.

The Progenitor circled him. Patient. Ancient. Waiting.

In my chest, the recognition-thread pulsed—once, warm and deliberate, the way you'd press a hand briefly to someone's shoulder to say: *I see you. Well done.*

I pressed two fingers to the Adamas-shard and sent back the only thing I had left to give: acknowledgment. Gratitude. The particular, wordless

understanding that passes between a Scribe and the subject of the most important record she has ever witnessed.

Above us, the gold kept spreading.

Below us, the core of the mountain breathed its last reserves into the rift.

And in thirty-six hours, or thirty, or twenty—the King would finish the collapse the Progenitor had started and the Supernova-Rune had made inevitable. His singularity would swallow itself. His gravity would turn inward one final time and not come back.

We would win. We were going to win.

We just had to survive long enough to see it.

"Ridoc," I said, turning around. "How much of the conduit line is still functional?"

He looked at the melted, sparking ruin in his hands. "...I would estimate none of it."

"Good assessment." I turned to Brennan. "Then we do this the old way." I held up the Stele. "Someone find me a wall."

Chapter Thirty-Three

The King's collapse took eleven hours.

We watched all of it.

There was nothing else to do. The conduit was destroyed, the Adamas pillar had burned itself to a pale, hollow shell when the Supernova-Rune discharged, and the mountain's core was running on fumes—a low, arthritic pulse of energy that was enough to keep the remaining wards from going dark but not enough to power another rune of any meaningful scale. Brennan had tried to re-rig the fuel line twice and given up both times, his silver eyes dim with an exhaustion that went beyond the physical. Ridoc had found a section of rift wall that hadn't fully collapsed and was using it as a backrest, his head tipped up, watching the sky. Rhiannon sat beside him. Neither of them spoke.

Xaden sat with his back against the Adamas pillar's base, the Stamina rune I'd drawn on his neck doing the slow, grinding work of rebuilding what the shadow-bridge had cost him. I sat beside him. His shoulder was warm against mine. I didn't move away from it.

Above us, the gold spread.

The King's contraction was not graceful. Nothing about a singularity turning against itself is graceful—it is a catastrophic, recursive violence, each layer of collapse triggering the next, the Supernova-Rune's fractal geometry winding tighter and tighter through his mass like a thread pulled through a needle's eye that keeps getting smaller. He fought it. Of course he did. There were hours when the gold dimmed and the darkness surged back, hours when his outline expanded and the remaining stars around him bent toward him again and my chest seized with the specific terror of watching something inevitable become temporarily uncertain.

But the Progenitor was always there.

Every time the King surged, she answered. She was not fighting him with volume now—not the sustained, furious columns of the first engagement. She was precise. Economical. She had found the frequency at which his contracting mass was most unstable, the exact resonance point at which another Supernova-threaded pulse would tighten the geometry another degree, and she struck it with the patience of something that has been alive since before patience was a concept that needed a name. Every three hours. Every two. Every ninety minutes as the collapse accelerated and the intervals shortened.

She was playing him like a Scribe plays a closing argument. Methodically. Inevitably.

At hour nine, Ridoc fell asleep sitting up and no one woke him.

At hour ten, Rhiannon quietly took the damaged conduit line apart and rebuilt what she could of it with her bare hands and a set of rune-etched clamps she'd had in her field kit. It wasn't enough to power anything significant. It was something to do.

At hour eleven, the King screamed.

The sound reached us as a subsonic pulse—not heard, felt, the way you feel a thunderclap in the seconds before the noise arrives. The mountain absorbed it. The rift walls shed another thin layer of stone. Ridoc jerked awake, his hand going to his dagger on pure reflex. The gold in the upper atmosphere surged to a brilliance that turned the indigo sky white, white as the Progenitor's eyes, white as Adamas heated past its yield point—

And then the darkness was simply gone.

No explosion. No dramatic implosion visible from the ground. One moment the King occupied the upper atmosphere, a hungry and immovable absence in the architecture of the sky. The next moment he did not. The stars that had been spiraling toward him snapped back to their positions like elastic returning to rest. The gravity-distortion at the horizon dissolved. The clouds, which had been pulling northward in long, unnatural streamers

for three days, drifted to a halt and then, slowly, began to move in the direction wind was supposed to move them.

The sky was just sky again.

I realized I was on my feet. I didn't remember standing. Xaden was beside me, his hand finding the back of my arm. Rhiannon and Ridoc had crossed the rift floor without appearing to walk there. Brennan stood at the edge of the chasm, looking up through the hole in the summit, his expression doing something complicated that I didn't have a name for.

"Is that—" Ridoc started.

"Yes," I said.

He made a sound that was not a word and sat back down on the rubble.

We all needed a moment. We took it.

Above us, the Progenitor descended.

She came down slowly—not the controlled plummet of a combat landing, not the efficient spiral of a dragon returning to its rider. She came down the way the last snow of winter comes down: deliberately, without hurry, as if she had all the time that remained in the world and intended to use it at whatever pace suited her. Her white eyes were dimmer than they'd been at the start. Not dark—the light was still there—but banked, the way a forge fire banks when the work is done and there's no longer a reason for full heat.

She settled into the ruins of the summit with a sound like a continent sighing.

I felt it through the recognition-filament in my chest the moment she made her decision. It wasn't a declaration—it was simply a settling, a shifting of weight that went deeper than physical. The particular quality of intention that belongs to something ancient that has completed a task it has been holding in trust for a very long time.

She was going back to sleep.

"No—" The word came out before I'd chosen it. I pressed my fingers to the Adamas-shard. "Advast, tell her she doesn't have to—"

She knows, Advast said. His voice was gentler than I'd ever heard it. *She is not retreating, wildfire. She is choosing. There is a difference.*

The Progenitor's head came down. Her vast, iridescent neck curved in a slow arc until her snout rested in the rubble of the summit, her white eyes level with the hole she'd torn on her way out. She looked at me through it. Eight hundred feet of mountain between us, and she looked at me with the calm, unhurried focus of something that doesn't need proximity to be present.

The recognition-filament pulsed.

Once. Warm. Final.

She says, Advast translated, very quietly, *that the record is complete. That the Scribe witnessed. That this is enough.*

My throat closed. I pressed my fingers harder against the shard and sent back everything I had—gratitude, acknowledgment, the wordless understanding that passes between a historian and the subject of the most important record they will ever keep. The thing the books had been too afraid to write down. The name. The fact of her.

I will write you down, I thought at her. Every word. I will make sure the next Scribe knows where to look.

Her eyes closed.

The light in them didn't go out. It simply went inward—folded back inside her the way a lamp flame bends away from an open window, present, just no longer visible. Her breathing slowed to that deep, structural rhythm I'd first felt rising from the chasm—vast and biological and geological all at once. The scales along her flanks cycled through their colors one final time,

every hue the spectrum contained, and then settled on something that had no name in any language I knew: the color of the moment before.

The mountain held her.

The silence was enormous and clean.

Then Ridoc said, very quietly: "Elara."

I heard it in his voice before I turned. That specific flatness that means he has done the math and the math is bad.

The sky above the summit had changed again.

Not darkness—not the King's consuming, structural dark. Something different. A seam. A vertical tear approximately three hundred feet long running through the atmosphere directly above the Progenitor's resting body, its edges ragged and luminous, crackling with a sickly energy that I recognized from the archive descriptions of the Greater Void Demon portals, the ones the Silent Brothers had classified as catastrophic-scale and sealed the records on.

The King's collapse had left a wound in the fabric of the upper air. The Supernova-Rune had burned its way through his mass at sufficient magnitude to scar the atmosphere on the other side—and on the other side of the scar was the Void. Not the metaphorical void of empty space. The actual Void. The place the Greater Demons came from.

And they were already coming through.

They came through in silence, which was the worst part. I had always imagined Void incursion as loud—the mythology was all screaming and thunder. These made no sound at all. They poured through the seam the way smoke pours through a crack, shapeless and purposeful and vast, individual forms resolving as they descended: winged silhouettes the size of wyverns, limbed and chitinous and constructed by something that understood the concept of a body without understanding what bodies were for. They fell toward the summit in a slow, deliberate rain.

Toward her.

"They can sense her," Xaden said. His voice had gone to that particular quiet that precedes his most dangerous decisions. "She's dormant. She's the largest concentration of pure primordial energy on the surface of the planet. To them she's—"

"A feast," I finished.

They landed on her. The first wave settled across her folded wings like a tide coming in across a reef, and she didn't stir. Couldn't—or wouldn't. The sleep was too deep, or the decision had been made, or she had spent the last of what she had on the King and there was simply nothing left to spend on this.

We watched them begin to feed.

It wasn't fast. It was the most terrible thing I have ever witnessed precisely because of how slow it was—the slow, systematic dismantling of something ancient and irreplaceable, the Void Demons working with a patience that mirrored her own, as if they had learned slowness from the same epoch she had. The color began to leave her scales. Not all at once. Section by section, the iridescence fading to grey, the grey deepening toward the flat, lightless non-color of something from which all energy has been extracted.

"We have to do something," Rhiannon said. She had her telekinetic field up already, was hurling chunks of rift debris through the gap in the summit at the mass of Demons on the Progenitor's body. The debris hit them and disrupted them and they simply reformed. You cannot fight Void Demons with rocks. She knew that. She was doing it anyway. "Elara, we *have* to—"

"I know." I had the Stele in my hand. My hands were shaking. I looked at Brennan. "The conduit. Anything left in it?"

"Eight percent. Maybe ten."

"And the pillar?"

He looked at the hollow Adamas shell. "Dregs. What the Supernova-Rune didn't burn."

"Give me everything," I said. "Everything Rhiannon's telekinetic field can pull from the ley lines, everything the conduit has left, everything in the pillar dregs." I was already moving toward the fused-glass edge of the summit gap, toward the open air. "Xaden—"

"Already here," he said, from directly behind me.

"I need a launch platform."

He didn't ask what for. He built it—a flat shelf of compressed shadow extending out from the summit gap, solid enough to stand on, oriented directly toward the mass of Demons swarming her body. I stepped onto it. The air at summit altitude was cold and thin and smelled of ozone and the aftermath of gold fire.

The Progenitor was directly below me. I could see the grey spreading across her scales like frost across a window. I could see the seam above, the ragged luminous tear, more Demons still pressing through it, a column of Void-mass descending in an endless patient stream.

I looked at the Adamas-shard against my chest. The recognition-filament, thin and cooling now that she was deep in sleep, pulsed with the last of its warmth.

I thought: *I told her I would write her down.*

I thought: *A Scribe witnesses. But a Sorrengail acts.*

I raised the Stele.

I did not draw forty-seven strokes this time. I drew one. A single mark, the root-stroke of the Supernova geometry—the foundational line from which all forty-six others branch. On its own, in Adamas, with proper fuel, it is an incomplete rune. It doesn't fire. It just holds the potential.

But I didn't draw it in Adamas. I drew it in the Adamas-shard. I pressed the Stele directly to the stone against my heart and etched the root-stroke into the shard itself, and the shard—the fragment of heavenly silver that had been fused to the violet-bond and the recognition-filament and twenty years of borrowed strength—detonated with a light that turned my vision white.

The charge didn't go up. It went down.

It traveled the recognition-filament like lightning travels a rod—direct, instantaneous, with absolute conviction about its destination. It hit the Progenitor in the deep place where the sleep lived, in the geological core of her that was still warm, that the Void Demons hadn't reached yet, and it delivered the only message it carried:

The Scribe witnessed. Get up.

For three seconds nothing happened.

Then the color came back.

Not gradually. All at once—a single, catastrophic return of the full spectrum, every hue simultaneously, brighter than anything I had seen her produce while waking. The Void Demons on her flanks recoiled. The ones anchored to her wings were thrown clear as the wings themselves snapped open—not the slow continental unfolding of before, but a violent, incandescent detonation of wingspan that sent a shockwave across the summit rubble and knocked Ridoc and Rhiannon off their feet and broke three of my ribs on Xaden's shadow-shelf and I did not care, I did not care even slightly.

The Progenitor rose.

She rose with every Void Demon that was still clinging to her body, fifty or sixty of them, unable to detach in time, fused to her scales by the velocity of her ascent. She didn't try to shake them. She rose straight toward the seam—toward the wound in the sky they'd come through—and the Demons still streaming downward reversed, turning back toward the Void in

sudden, instinctive panic, but the seam was already closing around her as she pushed through it, her body filling the tear edge to edge, the luminous crackling of the portal's margin running across her scales like current across a conductor.

She looked back.

One white eye, burning full and brilliant, visible through the closing seam for exactly the length of a single breath.

Then she went through.

The explosion came from inside the Void.

It had no color because there is no light in the Void—what we saw from the ground was the absence of color, a detonation of pure null-space that collapsed inward on itself even as it expanded, the Supernova geometry doing in the Void what it had done in the King: turning energy against itself, feeding on the Void Demons' mass and the portal's own structural energy and the last full burning of an ancient, primordial fire that had decided—not been forced, not been spent, but *decided*—that this was a worthy end for it.

The seam slammed shut.

The sound arrived four seconds later: a compression wave that cracked the remaining rift walls, shattered the hollow Adamas pillar to powder, and knocked every one of us flat on the rubble. My broken ribs introduced themselves to the stone floor with great enthusiasm. I lay there looking up at a sky that was simply, cleanly, entirely sky—no seam, no darkness, no gold fire, no Demons, no King. Just the stars returning to their original positions, settling back into the pattern they'd held for a thousand years before something had come along and tried to eat them.

Ridoc made a sound.

Rhiannon made a sound.

Brennan sat down in the rubble and put his face in his hands.

Xaden found me in the dark and didn't say anything, just pulled me upright and held me there, his arms careful around the broken ribs, his face pressed to the top of my head.

"She chose it," I said, into his chest. My voice came out wrong—flattened, like a rune drawn without enough pressure to make the mark hold. "She woke up for eleven hours. She killed a god. And then she chose—"

"I know," he said.

"She didn't have to—"

"I know." His arms tightened. Gently. "Elara."

I stopped. I pressed my fingers to the place where the Adamas-shard had been. The shard itself was gone—spent, consumed by the root-stroke I'd etched into it. But where it had sat against my sternum, the skin was warm. Warmer than body heat. Warmer than the residual heat of a discharged rune.

The recognition-filament was gone. But it had left something behind. A kind of scar, the way important things always leave scars—not damage, just record. Proof that the contact had been real.

I pressed my palm flat against my sternum and I held it there.

The record is complete, she had said. *The Scribe witnessed.*

"Not yet," I said quietly, to no one in particular. To her, maybe, wherever she had gone. To the record I was already beginning to assemble in the archive of my mind, word by word, the way my father had taught me—with precision, with care, with the particular reverence owed to something true.

I was a Scribe.

I reached into my jacket with a hand that was almost steady and took out the small field-notebook I had carried through every stage of this catastrophe. It was battered. The cover was scorched. Three pages in the

middle had fused together from an earlier encounter with a ley line discharge.

I opened it to the first blank page.

I wrote: *The Progenitor. What the First Riders sealed beneath Aretia. What the archive was afraid to name.*

I wrote: *She was real.*

I wrote: *I was there.*

Above us, the stars held their positions. The sky breathed normally. Somewhere above the treeline—above what remained of it—Advast circled in slow, patient arcs, his void-black scales catching no light at all, his presence a steady violet warmth in the bond.

Well done, wildfire, he said.

I kept writing.

Chapter Thirty-Four

The sun rose.

That sounds simple. It isn't, when you have spent the last seventy-two hours genuinely uncertain whether the sun would still be there to rise. It came up over the eastern ridge of what remained of the Basgiath peaks the way it always had—unhurried, indifferent to the catastrophe it was illuminating, painting the shattered summit in shades of amber and pale gold that had no business being as beautiful as they were.

I watched it from the rift floor, my back against Xaden's chest, his arms a careful architecture around my broken ribs. I had drawn a Healing rune on myself an hour ago, fed it from the last dregs of my own marrow since there was nothing else left to draw from, and the ribs were knitting at approximately half the speed they would have managed with a proper Adamas source. It was deeply unpleasant. I was choosing to focus on the sunrise instead.

"The wards," Rhiannon said. She was standing at the collapsed eastern wall of the rift, looking out at the valley through the gap. Her voice had the careful neutrality of someone delivering a report they haven't yet decided how to feel about. "They're still up."

"The core has enough left for the wards," Brennan said. He was sitting cross-legged on the rubble, his silver eyes half-closed, monitoring the ley line pulse the way a physician monitors a patient's heartbeat. "Barely. They'll hold for another week, maybe ten days. After that we'll need to find another Adamas source or the outer wards start failing in sequence."

"A week is enough," I said.

"Enough for what?"

"To send word. To get people here." I shifted carefully—the Healing rune protested with a sharp, specific pain that I filed away and ignored. "The Skystrikers. The Silent Brothers. The rest of the wings. The King is gone.

The Void seam is closed. The wards are still standing." I paused. "Basgiath is still standing. Mostly."

Ridoc, who had been lying flat on his back on the rubble with his arms spread like a man making a stone angel, turned his head to look at me. "When you say 'mostly'—"

"The summit is gone. Three of the outer towers. The eastern residential wing." I had done a structural assessment by feel and rune-sense in the small hours of the morning, while everyone else slept and I couldn't. "The library is intact."

"Of course it is," Xaden said, very quietly, into my hair.

"The library is *always* intact," Ridoc agreed, in the tone of someone who has made peace with this fact about the universe.

The sun climbed. The light reached the valley floor and moved across it slowly, and what it revealed in sequence was: the blue-glass graveyard that the Neptune-God's breath had made of the lower city, still crystalline and alien in the morning light. The scorched craters from the Alpha's laser strikes. The flattened forest to the south, the trees laid flat in radiating lines from the tectonic events of the last three days. And beyond all of it—beyond the devastation, at the edges of the valley where the oldest wards ran—Idris, still green. Still breathing. Still there.

The ley lines were thin. I could feel that from here, the attenuated pulse of a network that had been systematically drained by the Venin alliance and then pushed to its limits powering the defenses. They would need months to recover. Maybe a year. But they were there, and they were moving, the slow circulatory system of a land that had survived worse than this—had survived the First Age, the Void Wars, the Great Uprising—and had quietly, stubbornly persisted.

"Someone has to go up," I said. "To the summit. To make sure she—" I stopped. Restarted. "To document the site before anyone else reaches it."

The silence that followed understood what I meant. The Progenitor was gone, but Aretia was not. The buried city was real, the chasm was real, the hollow Adamas pillar was real, and when the Skystrikers arrived in their organized, administrative efficiency, someone was going to start asking questions and drawing conclusions that would find their way into the official record before I had a chance to shape the narrative.

I was a Scribe. Shaping the narrative was my function.

"I'll go," I said.

"Your ribs—" Rhiannon started.

"Are sixty percent healed and fully functional for light activity." A generous assessment. "Brennan, I need whatever Adamas dust is left from the pillar. Even the powder will fuel the Stele for a few lines." I was already calculating—what I needed to document, in what order, with what level of precision. The chasm dimensions. The fused-glass ring of the Progenitor's launch point. The stratigraphy of the Aretia seal, visible now where the Progenitor's exit had sheared through it: three hundred feet of engineered granite, laid in deliberate courses by hands that had understood exactly what they were enclosing and had chosen to enclose it with care rather than contempt.

Brennan wordlessly produced a small vial of Adamas powder from his field kit—a rider's emergency supply, the kind everyone carried and almost no one ever used. It was enough to fuel six or seven marks. I would have to be economical.

I was always economical.

Xaden helped me to my feet. He didn't comment on the way I leaned into the assist more than I would have twenty-four hours ago; I didn't comment on the shadows moving in quiet, protective arcs around us. We had arrived, somewhere in the past seventy-two hours, at the place where we no longer needed to narrate what we were doing for each other. It had happened without announcement, the way most important things do.

"I'll come with you," he said.

"You need to rest—"

"Yes," he agreed pleasantly, "I'll rest at the top." He offered his arm with a formality that was entirely, characteristically disingenuous.

I took it. My ribs and my pride had a brief internal discussion and reached a compromise.

The climb through the rift took twenty minutes. The summit, when we reached it, was a landscape of such complete transformation that for a moment I simply stood in it and let my mind catch up to my eyes. The fused-glass ring was exactly sixty-three feet in diameter—I paced it. The launch crater at its center had a depth of approximately four feet and a temperature, even now, that made the air above it shimmer. The Aretia stratigraphy was visible in the sheared cliff face to the north: three centuries of engineered stone, and beneath it the first glimpse of something older, a carved lintel in a style of masonry I had never seen in any archive and recognized instantly from the image Advast had shown me in racial memory.

The city was real. The city was *real,* and intact, and waiting below the mountain with all the patience of something that has been waiting for a very long time and has no particular objection to waiting a little longer.

I opened the field notebook. I began to document.

Xaden sat on a piece of rubble at the crater's edge, tilted his face up to the sun, and rested. He looked, in that moment, less like the most dangerous person I had ever met and more like someone who has been carrying a very heavy thing for a very long time and has set it down in a patch of sunlight for just a few minutes. I looked at him for longer than was strictly necessary for documentation purposes.

Then I looked back at the carved lintel and kept writing.

Two hours later, when I had filled eleven pages with measurements, structural observations, stratigraphic notation, and the first complete written account of what had occurred here in the past three days—every word of it, including her—I reached the final entry.

I wrote: *The portal closed at dawn on the fourth day. The sky held.*

I wrote: *She is not gone. She is resting. The distinction matters.*

I closed the notebook.

Xaden opened one eye. "Done?"

"For now." I looked out over the valley—at the ruined city and the surviving wards and the thin, recovering pulse of the ley lines and the improbable, obstinate green of Idris at the valley's edge. "The official record is going to say we defeated the Black Hole King using a Supernova-Rune and a Primary Anchor discharge. Which is true. As far as it goes."

"And the unofficial record?"

I pressed my palm to my sternum, where the scar of the recognition-filament was still warm. "Is here. And here." I tapped the notebook. "And will be in the Archive, in the restricted annex, in a file marked 'cartographer's error,' where the right person will find it when they need to."

Xaden looked at me for a long moment. Then he said: "Your father would have approved."

It was the most precise thing anyone had said to me in three days. I didn't trust my voice with a response, so I simply reached over and put my hand in his.

We sat on the summit of Basgiath in the morning sun, with the valley laid out below us like a map of everything that had almost been lost and hadn't been, and we stayed there until the distant sound of dragon wings broke

the silence from the south—the first of the Skystrikers, coming to find out what was left.

Chapter Thirty-Five

They came in waves.

First the Skystrikers—forty riders, General Lilith Sorrengail at their head, her charcoal leathers coated in the fine ash of three days of border combat, her expression when she landed in the valley and saw the blue-glass city and the shattered summit doing something I had never once in my life seen my mother's expression do: it faltered.

She found me on the valley floor. She looked at me for a long moment—at the scorched leathers, the field-notebook, the careful way I was holding my left side where the Healing rune was still working.

"You're alive," she said.

"I made the calculations," I said. "They were accurate."

She put her hand on my shoulder. It lasted approximately two seconds. For her, that was an eternity. I understood, in those two seconds, that it was the closest she knew how to come to the thing she actually meant, and I accepted it as such.

"The King," she said.

"Gone."

"The Void seam."

"Closed."

"The wards."

"Holding. The core needs resupply within ten days. I have a full structural and ley line assessment in—" I held up the notebook.

She took it. Read the first three pages with the focused, vertical attention of someone who processes information the way a blade processes resistance. Stopped at the fourth page.

"What is Aretia," she said. Not a question. The tone of someone who has encountered a word they recognize from a context they'd sealed away.

"A city," I said. "Sealed beneath the summit by the First Riders. The records were classified above General-rank. I imagine you have clearance."

Her eyes came up from the notebook. She looked at me with an expression I had no existing category for and would spend some time afterwards trying to correctly name. It was somewhere between professional assessment, maternal reckoning, and the particular look of a person who is being forced to revise a very old assumption.

"Your father found a reference," she said. "Twenty years ago. I told him it was a scribal error."

"He thought so too," I said. "He was wrong. So were you."

A pause.

"Yes," she said. "We were." She handed the notebook back. "Finish the record. Full archive standard. Restricted annex." The ghost of something that was almost—almost—a softening moved across her face. "Your father would have wanted it done properly."

"I know," I said. "I'm doing it properly."

She held my gaze for one more moment. Then she turned to begin coordinating the Skystriker assessment teams, her boots finding their familiar, authoritative rhythm across the rubble.

I let out a breath I had been holding for approximately twenty years.

The Silent Brothers arrived next—six of them, eyeless and grey-robed, moving through the blue-glass graveyard with the unhurried attention of beings for whom disaster is primarily a cataloguing problem. They set immediately to assessing the crystallized sections of the city for structural stability and began the long, patient work of reversing the Neptune-God's legacy where reversal was possible and documenting it where it wasn't.

The Fourth Wing riders arrived on the second day—the ones who had been stationed at the outer borders when the tectonic events began. They came in ragged, exhausted, their dragons bearing the minor burns and scale-damage of three days of peripheral combat with the Venin who had tried to press the borders during the chaos. Seeing the valley seemed to break something loose in all of them simultaneously—that specific, physical release of tension that a body can only perform when it finally believes the danger is past.

Ridoc received seventeen separate expressions of relief from his squadmates, which he bore with increasing emotional dishevelment until the seventeenth, at which point he sat down and stopped pretending he was fine, and Rhiannon sat beside him without comment and remained there for approximately an hour, and this was, I noted without writing it down, the most effective Silent Brother maneuver I had ever witnessed.

Brennan was found by the Third Wing riders on the second morning, alive and mobile and bearing the specific expression of a man who has been officially dead for several years and is uncertain of the administrative process for reversing this. The reunion with our mother was witnessed by approximately forty people and documented by none of them, which was correct.

The valley slowly, effortfully, incompletely began to resemble something that could be rebuilt.

On the third day, Xaden found me in what remained of the archive room—the section of the library that had survived, its wards intact, its shelves holding with the particular stubbornness of well-built things that have decided not to fall down. I was cataloguing. I had been cataloguing for most of the past thirty hours, with breaks for sleep enforced by Rhiannon's telekinesis and meals enforced by Ridoc's persistence.

"The Silent Brothers want the summit sealed," he said, from the doorway.

"I know." I didn't look up from the index I was compiling. "I already spoke to them. They agreed to a six-week documentation window before any structural work begins."

"You negotiated with the Silent Brothers."

"I made a logical case."

"The Silent Brothers don't speak."

"They communicate. I used the Scribe-link." I turned a page. "They were receptive to the argument that sealing the site before full documentation was epistemically irresponsible."

He was quiet for a moment. I heard him move into the room—the specific quality of silence that is Xaden navigating a space with his shadows drawn close, attentive, the unconscious proprioception of someone whose power is also a kind of perception.

He leaned against the shelf beside my table. I kept writing.

"Elara," he said.

"Mm."

"Put the notebook down for a moment."

"I'm in the middle of a—"

"Elara."

Something in the way he said it. Not urgent. Not alarmed. The particular tone that is none of those things and lands with more weight than all of them. I put the notebook down and turned to look at him.

He looked tired in the way that goes deeper than sleep—the tiredness of someone who has been holding themselves at maximum tension for a very long time and is only now, in the relative quiet, feeling the cost of it. His shadows were still. The Mark on his neck had faded from combat-dark to

its ordinary depth. His eyes were on me with that specific, unguarded attention that he deployed rarely and with the full knowledge of its effect.

"When this is documented," he said. "When the record is complete. When the Silent Brothers have their six weeks and the archive has its restricted file and the official account is submitted and approved." He paused. "What do you want to do?"

I had not thought about this. There had been no room to think about it—the days since the King's fall had been pure logistics, pure recovery, pure documentation, the urgent present tense of survival work that leaves no space for the future. The question landed in the middle of me with a weight I hadn't expected.

What did I want to do.

I looked at the archive around me—the shelves of surviving records, the indexed history of a world that had nearly ended and hadn't, the incomplete annals of a mountain with a buried city beneath it and a story that would take decades to fully tell. I looked at my notebook, eleven pages of the most important documentation I would ever produce. I thought about the carved lintel in the sheared summit face, the masonry style I had never seen in any existing archive, the city intact and waiting.

I thought about the warm scar on my sternum where the recognition-filament had been.

"I want to go down," I said. "Into Aretia. I want to document what's there." I paused. "And I want you to come with me."

The corner of his mouth moved. Not a smile exactly—the specific, restrained precursor to one. "Into an unmapped underground city of unknown extent beneath a mountain that recently exploded."

"The structural assessment indicates the lower chambers are stable."

"Your structural assessment."

"My structural assessments are accurate." I held his gaze. "There are records down there that predate anything in this library. There are answers to questions my father spent his entire life asking. And there is—" I stopped. Pressed my hand briefly to my sternum. "There is something down there that she was sealed to protect. And I think it's time someone found out what it was."

Xaden looked at me for a long moment.

"When do we go?" he said.

"After the six weeks," I said. "After the documentation window. After I've finished the index and submitted the official account and made sure the restricted file is correctly catalogued."

"Of course." He reached over and closed the notebook for me, gently, with one hand. "But not tonight."

"The index—"

"Will be there in the morning." He held out his hand. "You have three broken ribs that are eighty percent healed, you haven't slept in a continuous block for five days, and Advast is circling the valley sending me pointed messages about your caloric intake."

I looked at his hand. I looked at the notebook. I performed a quick assessment of priorities and reached a conclusion.

I took his hand.

"The index will be there in the morning," I agreed.

We left the archive, and the valley was quiet around us, and above it the stars were exactly where they were supposed to be.

Chapter Thirty-Six

Six weeks later, I stood at the lip of the Aretia chasm with a Stele in one hand and a fully charged field-kit of Adamas in the other and more questions than I had ever held in my head at one time in my life.

That is saying something.

The summit had been documented to archive standard. Every measurement, every stratigraphic layer, every notation about the fused-glass ring and the launch crater and the carved lintel—all of it submitted, reviewed by the Silent Brothers, countersigned by the Head Librarian's office, and filed in the restricted annex under a reference code that would be findable by the right person and invisible to the wrong one. The official account of the Black Hole King's defeat was in the public record. The unofficial account was in eleven pages of a scorched field-notebook, preserved in oilskin, lodged in the restricted annex directly behind the official account with a note in my handwriting that read: *See also: cartographer's error, Third Age, ref. Aretia, N.*

My father would have found it in approximately four minutes. I had confidence in the eventual reader.

The chasm itself had been secured—the structural assessment confirmed stable chambers to a depth of two hundred feet, and the Silent Brothers had run a preliminary ward-survey of the first three levels and found the original First Rider wards largely intact, dormant but coherent, waiting for an authorized Stele to reactivate them. The kind of wards that don't degrade. The kind that were built by people who intended what they sealed to remain sealed for as long as it needed to be.

They had been built by people who understood that sealed did not mean destroyed. That sleeping did not mean gone. That the right moment was worth waiting for.

I understood that too, now. I had a scar on my sternum that had taught it to me.

"Ready?" Xaden asked, from beside me.

I looked down into the chasm—into the dark, which was not actually dark because I had rigged a series of Illumination runes along the first hundred feet of descent and the Adamas-light threw the walls into sharp relief, revealing the carved stone of Aretia's uppermost level: columns, intact. Archways, intact. The lintel I had documented from the summit face, now fully visible, bearing an inscription in the script of the First Riders that I had spent three of the past six weeks translating and had rendered, provisionally, as: *We seal this in trust, not in condemnation. What rests here rests in love.*

Rhiannon and Ridoc were already on the rope descent—Ridoc narrating his concerns about the structural integrity of the first archway to no one in particular, Rhiannon ignoring him with the practiced efficiency of long familiarity. Brennan was below them both, his silver eyes providing their own light, one hand trailing the ancient stonework as he descended.

Advast was on the summit above us, too large for the chasm, his void-black presence a warm constant at the edge of the bond. *I will be here,* he had said, when we'd discussed the logistics. *I am always here.* And then, after a pause: *She is also here, wildfire. Not in a way you can see. But in a way you can record.*

I had written that down too.

I looked at Xaden. He was watching me with the patient, attentive stillness of someone who has learned that the most important moments are rarely the ones that announce themselves.

"Ready," I said.

I stepped off the edge.

The descent took eight minutes—controlled, careful, my Stele tracing a stabilizing line along the rope to keep my joints from bearing full load. The Adamas-light grew warmer as we went deeper, catching on surfaces that

had not seen light in centuries and reflecting it back in colors I had no names for yet but intended to find names for, or invent them if none existed. The air changed from cold and thin to something older and more complex—the specific atmospheric chemistry of a sealed space, mineral-rich, the trace signatures of materials I would need to have analyzed properly but could already tell were not in any existing index.

The floor of the uppermost chamber arrived under my boots with a solidity that felt, after everything, almost shocking. I let go of the rope and stood in the city of Aretia, in a space that had last been stood in by the First Riders, and was quiet for a moment.

It was large. Not the word—*vast* was closer, *cathedral* closer still, and even then the scale exceeded the vocabulary. The ceiling was supported by columns fifty feet high, carved from the mountain's own stone and inlaid with Adamas in patterns I recognized immediately as derivations of the root-stroke I had etched into the shard—the same fractal geometry, rendered in permanent heavenly silver, covering every column from base to capital. The effect, with the Illumination runes active, was of standing inside a lattice of living light.

In the center of the chamber, on a raised dais of the same unknown masonry as the lintel, was a door.

Not an archway. A door—a single slab of material that was not stone and not metal and not Adamas, though it shared properties with all three. It was approximately twelve feet tall and perfectly sealed, and around its frame was carved, in the script of the First Riders, a text I recognized.

I had translated it three weeks ago from a fragment in my father's library. He had marked it *provenance unknown, possibly apocryphal.*

It read: *Here we place what cannot be destroyed. Here we place what must not be lost. Here we place the record of the first fire, the first bond, the first word spoken between a rider and a dragon at the beginning of the world. Reader: if you have come this far, you were meant to.*

I stood in front of the door for a long time.

Xaden appeared beside me, looked at the inscription, looked at me.

"Can you read it?"

"Yes." I traced the letters with one finger, not quite touching. "It's the First Rider script. I've been translating it for three weeks." I turned to him. "Xaden. This isn't just a city. This is an archive. Aretia was their archive—the First Riders'. Everything they knew. Everything they learned. Everything they wanted to survive them."

"And the Progenitor," he said slowly, "was sealed here to protect it."

"She wasn't a guard," I said. The word came out with a conviction that surprised me—immediate, certain, the feeling of a translation that has finally resolved into its correct meaning. "She was a curator. She was sealed here to keep the record intact until someone came who could be trusted with it."

In my chest, the warm scar pulsed once. Steady. Constant.

I pressed my palm to it.

Then I raised my Stele, pressed it to the lock on the door—a single depression in the unknown material, exactly the size and shape of a Stele's tip—and drew one stroke.

The root-stroke of the Supernova geometry. The same mark I had etched into the shard. The same mark that was inlaid in the columns behind me, that was carved into the lintel above, that was threaded through the architecture of this entire city like a signature.

The door opened.

The light that came through it was not Adamas-light and not Illumination-rune light and not the white fire of the Progenitor's eyes. It was the specific, sourceless, warm light of something that has been waiting in a

sealed space for a very long time to be let out, and is not surprised that the wait is over, and is not in a hurry, and is simply, quietly, glad.

I stepped through the door.

I opened my notebook.

I began, at the beginning, to write everything down.

Epilogue

From the Restricted Annex, Basgiath Archive, Reference Code NE-ARET-001 Filed by: E. Sorrengail, Second Rank Scribe, Fourth Wing Countersigned: Head Librarian's Office, the Silent Brothers, General L. Sorrengail

Note, appended in hand: If you have found this file, you were meant to. The door is still open. The light is still on. Come down when you are ready.

What follows is the complete record of the Progenitor of Aretia—what she was, what she protected, and what she chose. It is the most important document in this archive. It is also the truest.

She was real.

I was there.

— E.S.